Stone Cold

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29409522.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F, F/M, Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Wolfa (Original Character)/Azeria (Original Character)

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Additional Tags:
Additional Warnings In Author's Note, Blood and Torture, ok TBBW was fluffy and sweet, this one is different, I mean there still will be A LOT of fluff and super-sweet scenes, Also warning for, Swearing, Read the notes please, because that's where I'll warn you, if you might want to skip those bad chapters, mentions at suicide

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Part 2 of Of war and love (She-Ra and the Princesses of Power)

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by wolfish

Summary

Sequel to The Big Bad Wolf, so if you haven't read it you will be like: "who's that? Why is *insert character name* doing this?"

Wolfa is their friend now... well, Adora is still jealous, but they're trying their best, and all that she and her friends have to do is organize Mermista and Sea Hawk's wedding and help Scorpia to take her seat on the Fright Zone's throne. Until a weird and unknown spaceship lands in the Whispering Woods and four, creepy aliens come out of it... Soon Adora, Catra and their friends will find out that magic can't save them, this time.

Notes

Hi there! :) I said I would post the sequel this week and I did! Yay! I'm going to update once a week.
Again, sorry if there are any errors, English is my second language and I'm doing my best. I hope you'll like this story! As always, comments, corrections and advices are more than appreciated <3

Goodbyes

It was… weird, to be there. Bright Moon. The most important kingdom of Etheria, the headquarters of the Rebellion. The kingdom the Horde never managed to conquer.

And now she was protecting it, together with the people she once hated and feared. Princesses, for the most part, plus a pirate, a talking horse, sorcerers, a guy that was pretty good with bow and arrows, a warrior that kept trying to talk to her and *her* . Wolfa glanced at Catra once again, sitting there in the War Room with all of them. Her alien pet was sitting quietly next to her, their mane and tail blue. It meant that Catra was calm, she had discovered. Well, Queen Glimmer had told her. She gazed at her, in order to stop staring at Catra, at least. If Adora had noticed, she didn't show.

"... we're safe, now," the Queen was saying, "but I still think that we must be prepared in case of an attack. We're not in Despondos anymore, we have no idea of who might still want to attack us. Etheria is an immense resource of magic, after all."

"I completely agree" Adora said, all serious and tense like the Force Captain she could have been. "Bright Moon is well guarded, but there are many kingdoms that need further protection. Or we might just find a way to protect the whole planet. A magical shield, maybe?"

"Easier said than done" Micah intervened, "Etheria is a huge place to protect. There isn't such a powerful sorcerer."

"I know, I mean, using a sort of… enhancer, maybe? Something I'm sure Entrapta and Hordak could build. Right?"

Hordak wasn't there (he seemed to avoid those meetings), but Entrapta smiled widely, her eyes sparkling with excitement.

"Really? Can I?"

Adora looked at her.

“If you can contain the risks…”

That weird princess started babbling about science and Wolfa stopped listening to her. She focused on Catra again, feeling Azeria’s stare piercing her head. Catra was looking at Entrapta, listening to her, apparently, her gorgeous eyes narrowed and her long tail slowly swaying.

“No, don’t do that!” Catra said, talking to the tech princess. “You just said that it’s dangerous!”

“No, I said that there’s 78% of possibility that it might end with a massive explosion.”

Catra lowered her ears, her lips pressed to form a sloping line curved downward.

“That sounds a lot like the definition of ‘dangerous’.”

“But it’s an experiment!”

“A dangerous one!”

“Entrapta,” Glimmer cut in, “I’m sure you can find another way to build that enhancer.”

The princess’ eyes brightened.

“Oh, sure! I might use some lenticular mirrors to…”

Wolfa stopped listening again. Catra, Catra, Catra. She couldn’t stop thinking about her (and glancing at her). But sooner or later her or Adora would notice, so she *had* to stop. Even because it was absolutely useless. She would never be with her. She was with Adora, she loved Adora and none else, not like that. She kept repeating it to herself, but she still loved her, and it still hurt.

She sighed and forced herself to look away. The floor was quite interesting after all, right? Right.

When Entrapta finished explaining to them how she meant to make the enhancer, and it looked a sufficiently safe way to do it, Adora decided that it was time to say what she'd wanted to say for weeks.

"Fine, so you're gonna build the enhancer. Scorpia, you will be busy taking care of your kingdom… queendom? Whatever…" Scorpia blushed. Adora knew that she didn't feel ready to rule a kingdom, but Perfuma, who was holding her pincer now, had her back. She had no doubt that Scorpia would be a perfect Queen for the Fright Zone. "Perfuma will help you. Mermista and Sea Hawk have a wedding to organize, with Frosta and our help. So we all have something important to do, but…" Adora gazed at Glimmer. "There's one more thing we should do. Two, actually."

Glimmer frowned.

"What? Did we forget something?"

Adora nodded, smirking.

"Sort of. I'd like to… I mean, I know it's not vital, but it feels right. I thought we might build two statues, to honour Mara and… Angella." Glimmer widened her eyes, then she smiled softly.

“Oh, Adora…”

“If you agree, of course.”

Glimmer’s smile broadened and then she teleported next to her and hugged her tight.

“Of course I agree. It’s a wonderful idea, thank you!” Adora smiled when she kissed her cheek, relieved. She was afraid it would be too painful for her, but Glimmer looked just happy with the idea. She watched her hug Catra too (Catra didn’t look too happy about it, but not even so annoyed), and she heard her ask in a whisper “Do you have anything to do with this?” And when Catra denied, Glimmer didn’t look as convinced as she should have before disappearing and reappearing on her seat. Adora leaned over to Catra.

“Why did she ask you…?”

Catra shrugged.

“Oh, just a little talk we had a while ago. Nothing important.”

Adora frowned, but both Catra and Glimmer seemed to be just fine, so she straightened her back and held herself from asking again. If they talked about Angella, she didn’t have to interfere. She was curious, but she wanted to leave Catra her space with their friends.

She pretended once again not to notice Wolfa’s glances at Catra (*don’t be jealous, don’t be jealous!*), and stood up when Glimmer officially ended the meeting. It was time to say goodbye to their friends, who had to leave for their kingdoms. She and Catra joined the princesses. Entrapta patted Catra’s head with her hair, Scorpia was hugging Bow and Glimmer together, her eyes filled with tears.

“You’ll have to cheer her up in the Fright Zone” Adora said to Perfuma, who nodded smiling while watching her girlfriend.

“She’s stronger than she thinks, and she’ll be an amazing ruler.”

Adora smiled.

“I know. But we’ll miss you. Both of you.”

Perfuma turned and looked at her.

“The Fright Zone isn’t that far. We’ll meet again soon.” She looked at Catra and aimed a finger at her. “And we’ll start those meditation sessions!”

Catra rolled her eyes.

“Sure.”

“Catra…”

“Okay, okay, I promise!”

Perfuma smiled and hugged them both.

Scorpia freed Bow and Glimmer and joined the hug, almost lifting the three of them.

“Argh, Scorpia, stop it!” Catra hissed. “Don’t be so dramatic!”

“But I’m going to miss you so much!”

“We can communicate using the screenpads!”

“It’s not the same!”

“Don’t worry, Scorpia, it’s just for a couple of months…” Adora intervened, mostly because breathing was becoming quite hard. Scorpia let them go and sighed loudly, but Melog rubbed against her legs and made her smile.

“I’m sorry, guess I’m just stressed for this Queen thing…”

Adora put a hand on her spiked shoulder, careful not to harm herself.

"I know it's hard, but you can always call Glimmer for advice, and we'll be right there if you need us."

Scorpia smiled at her and then sniffed, holding back the tears.

"Thank you!"

Melog jumped in her arms and licked her face, making her laugh. Catra glared at them, and Adora hid a smirk, wondering what she was telling them.

Melog, I swear, if you keep showing them what I feel…

Your emotions are deep and strong. I can't help it. And it's for the best, trust me.

It's annoying! I hate you.

I love you too.

She hugged Scorpia, anyway. She would actually miss her friend, and she knew how bad it would be for her to go back to the Fright Zone.

"If someone messes with you, just call me and I'll make them wish they were never born" she whispered in her ear. Scorpia

laughed and tightened the hug.

“Thank you. I’m going to miss you, wildcat.”

Catra smirked.

“Now let me go, I have a reputation to uphold.”

Scorpia laughed again, but she let her go. Catra noticed that her eyes were glassy, so she snorted and walked away from her to say goodbye to Mermista (her so-called pirate was starting to sing with Bow, unfortunately). They shared an annoyed stare. It wasn’t that easy to make friends with someone when you had conquered their kingdom during a war… but they were trying, somehow.

“So… see you soon.”

“I mean, we need to organize my wedding anyway, right? We’ll see in, like, a week or so.”

“Indeed. That’s why I don’t understand why your fiance is crying.”

Mermista rolled her eyes.

“Yeah, he’s like, you know, made this way.”

Catra lowered her ears to protect them from Sea Hawk's loud voice a little bit, at least, and met Frosta’s stare.

“Bye.”

The princess narrowed her eyes.

“Bye.”

Fine, she was done with goodbyes.

While Adora was talking to Mermista and Frosta she turned and noticed Wolfa looking away and blushing a little. And Azeria staring at Wolfa with worry in her orange eyes. And, oh, Scorpia was now approaching Wolfa, or at least she tried, because the

former soldier scowled at her and Scorpia stopped, lowering her shoulders, the hesitant smirk on her face disappeared. Catra sighed watching her turn around and walk back to hug Swift Wind.

What an idiot. Wolfa had to move on.

Maybe she needs more time.

Catra looked at Melog.

Maybe she needs a kick in the ass.

Melog laughed.

That, too.

Of fears and hopes

Chapter Notes

> Hi!!! This chapter is a little shorter, and... you'll see. I'm posting the next one too, just beacuse I'm good and generous and... not really, it's just because I need your kudos and comments like I need oxygen xD About that, thank you for the kudos and the comments! <3

Wolfa had just left the War Room, and she about to go to the beach and swim a little bit, like she did the day before, when a strong yet delicate grip on her left wrist made her turn abruptly, her right fist raised and ready to strike… but she met Azeria's bright eyes, her smile, that was shaken by her reaction and faltered. Azeria let her go immediately and stepped back, her hands up.

"Hey, relax, I just wanted to talk to you."

Wolfa breathed in her scent, noticing once again how she smelled like flowers and moss. She found herself wagging her tail, and forced herself to stop.

"Well, I don't." She turned and walked away, hating her body reactions. What was that? Stupid tail! She wasn't happy that she kept *stalking* her like that! It was annoying, and, really, all she could think about was Catra. It was already hard enough to see her canoodle with Adora every fucking day, she didn't need to worry about that vixen, too. She knew that following the group to Bright Moon was a bad idea, but she had no idea of how painful it could be. Not a week had passed since they basically forced her to go there and she already wanted to throw herself off a balcony. That's why she needed some air, now, and the beach was the best place to go, because the princesses never went there (jerks, it was beautiful!), and most importantly *Catra* never went there.

Unfortunately, right when she was about to exit the castle, Glimmer appeared in front of her, startling her. She held herself from growling.

“Wolfa! Phew , you made me run to catch you!”

Wolfa raised her right eyebrow.

“You teleported yourself literally in front of me.”

“Yes, after running! Nevermind. Anyway, I was thinking, you haven’t met your friends since you came back, yet…”

Wolfa inhaled slowly to keep calm and started walking again, her paces long and fast, forcing Glimmer, who was way shorter than her, to basically run next to her.

“And I never will.”

“Why? I thought you were a team!”

“That’s right, we *were* . They’re better off without me.”

Glimmer grabbed her arm (she was stronger that she looked) and forced her to stop.

“Wolfa, wait! Why do you think that?”

Wolfa looked in her purple eyes, recognizing confusion and worry inside of them. It made her nervous. Why did Glimmer even care, anyway? What was wrong with her?

“It’s just the truth. People barely notice I exist, even if I’ve been in their lives since the beginning, and when I leave, or when they leave, they’re happier.” She had to look away because Glimmer’s stare was filling with pity.

“Wolfa…”

She shook her head and glared at her.

“Don’t you even try, Your Majesty. We both know that it is the truth. Now leave me alone, if you please. I might be one of your guards, but today I’m off duty.”

Glimmer sighed and stepped back, and she almost ran away from her, from that bloody castle, from everyone.

Glimmer watched her walk away and sighed again. She teleported back in front of the War Room, where Bow was waiting for her.

“What did she say?” he asked immediately. Then he saw the expression on her face and rushed to hug her. He was warm and comfy, so familiar, and Glimmer was already starting to feel better. “Hey, what happened?”

“She doesn’t want to meet them. She said that they’re better off without her, that people don’t care about her… Bow, I’m afraid we did the wrong thing bringing her here. She’s so… unhappy.”

Bow distanced, but he kept the contact with her holding her shoulders.

“But we showed her we care, and I think that that’s exactly what she needs. And I’m sure that if we keep doing so, she will realize that she’s worth love, eventually.”

Glimmer looked in his eyes. Could she love him more than this?

“But did you notice the way she looks at Catra?” she whispered. “She’s still in love with her!”

“Yeah, we knew that…”

“Yes but I thought she would… I don’t know, she said she accepted that Catra loves Adora!”

Bow shrugged.

“Yes, but she never said she stopped loving Catra. I don’t think that that’s even possible! Would you stop loving me if I loved someone else? I know I wouldn’t, if you did.”

“Oh, Bow…” She stood on her tiptoe and kissed him, wrapping her arms around his neck. Bow hugged her and lifted her.

“Don’t worry” he said, later, when they both broke the kiss to breathe. “She will feel better, eventually. I think that she believes that she could be happy only with Catra, but that’s not true, and when she gets it, she’ll be just fine.”

“But she could use some friends, in the meantime.”

“She has us.”

“She doesn’t like us, Bow. She needs someone who really knows her, but she hates Scorpia, so…”

“She said she doesn’t want to see them, Glimmer, we can’t force her to do that.”

“I know, but…”

“Just give her some time. It’s been just five days.”

Glimmer sighed and leaned her head against his chest.

“I know. I hope you’re right.”

"Are you ready?"
Scorpia gave Bright Moon one last glance, then she turned and gazed at Perfuma, smiling.

"No, but we have to go before it's dark, so…"

Perfuma hugged her and she wrapped her arms around her, careful not to hurt her with her pincers.

"You know, you don't have to do this. You could leave the throne to someone else…"

Scorpia shook her head.

"No, it's my people. I can't abandon them."

Perfuma looked at her, smiling, and her soft and fresh hands cupped her face, making her blush.

"You're so brave…" Scorpia didn't have the time to protest that the princess kissed her. Her heart flipped, and she lifted Perfuma, holding her in her arms, and stepped on the skiff. They broke the kiss and she looked into her eyes, feeling happier than she

thought she'd ever be, even with the weight of a kingdom over her shoulders.

"Thank you" she murmured. Perfuma gave her another quick kiss.

"I love you. Let's go now, we have a forest to go through."

Azeria hid behind the huge floating rock, climbing its side, and when she found a safe spot where she could hang without risking to fall, she dared to look down. Wolfa was on the beach, staring at the narrow tongue of sea that wetted the Bright Moon's coast, right under the castle. She had kicked away her boots and she was taking off her shirt. Azeria blushed and looked away. Maybe, following her wasn't actually a good idea. She gave another glance, unable to hold herself from doing it, and her mouth dried seeing her muscled back bend when she started taking off her trousers, too. She had the time to notice the thick, surely soft white and grey fur that ran from Wolfa's shoulders to her tail, larger on her shoulders (it touched her shoulder blades forming a sort of diamond between them) and thinner on her lower back. She was basically naked, her breasts and buttocks covered only by grey, crossed bands. Okay, she didn't mean to see her this way, time to go.

She jumped from rock to rock until she could safely jump to the ground, far enough from the beach so that Wolfa couldn’t see or hear her. What was she thinking? Talking to her was becoming harder, day after day. Wolfa was so standoffish, so *angry* , so unwilling to give her a chance. She knew she should just let her go, but… there was something, behind all that rage, something in her fierce glare, in the few moments when she wagged her tail when she approached her, that told her that she didn’t really want to push her away. So she kept hoping, and trying, even if all she got were harsh words and growls.

Darkness from above

Adora yawned and blinked, trying to focus the ceiling. She lifted her head a little bit, enough to see that Catra was still sleeping at the foot of the bed. She smiled, remembering how empty she felt every time she woke up without her, a feeling that now was replaced by that comfort and warmth that was spreading around her heart.

Catra was so cute when she was sleeping. Adora had always held herself from grabbing her and cuddling her to wake her up, but now… well, now she didn't. Catra moaned and tried to push her away.
"Adoraaa, it's too early!" It was, it was barely dawning outside, but she was awake and nothing could stop her from bothering her girlfriend now. She dragged her under herself and held her tight.

"It's never too early to kiss you."

She tried, but Catra's hand slammed against her face and pushed her away.

"No! Haven't brushed my teeth yet!"

"I don't care! And neither did I…"

Catra tried to stand up but Adora kept her in place. She moved her hand and gave her a kiss on her neck. Catra started to purr immediately and she smiled.

"See?" she whispered on her skin, keeping her still. She felt her shiver. "It's never too early." She kissed the side of her neck again and Catra turned her head to give her more room.

"Mmgh, Adora…" she moaned, and she wasn't struggling anymore against her. Adora moved her arms upwards and held her wrists with just one hand. Catra opened her eyes, her pupils were dilated, almost rounded, her lips slightly parted, her cheeks red. She was gorgeous and Adora felt her body tense, react, wetten.

She kissed her mouth, and Catra didn't seem so worried about brushing her teeth anymore. A faint moan again, her body rocking gently against hers. Adora's heart rate grew exponentially.

With her free hand she touched her exposed belly, feeling the tension of her abs under her fingers, that crawled upwards, under the rim of her grey top. Catra moaned her name, and she felt a warm and pleasing shiver shake her body and Catra's tail caress her side...

KNOCK! KNOCK! KNOCK!

It couldn't be true. Catra's eyes snapped open.

"Oh, come on!" she snarled. "WHO IS IT?"

"BOW! WAKE UP, THE SCOUTS SPOTTED AN UNKNOWN SPACESHIP!"

Adora leapt up and Catra stood up in turn.

"COME IN, BOW!" Adora yelled, and the door opened, letting her friend walk in. He already had his bow and arrows in his hands, and he was sweating.

"Glimmer's waiting in the War Room with Entrapta and Hordak, get dressed, see you there. I'm gonna wake up Azeria and Wolfa and join you."

Adora nodded, her mind already working on a defense strategy.

"Go" she said to him while moving to the closet to take her clothes. Catra was already half dressed. Bow ran away while Adora was taking off her tank top and her shorts to wear her trousers and her shirt. She tied her hair and put on her boots, and she was ready. She gazed at Catra.

"Let's go."
Catra looked pissed off.

“I already hate whoever is driving that spaceship.”

Adora snorted. She kind of hated them, too.

Glimmer felt tired and tense. She had had just a couple of hours to sleep before the guard had woken her and Bow up and she really needed to sleep, after what she had done with Bow. She smirked remembering the night they had just spent together, and she felt her eyes close, cradled by the warmth she still felt… She opened her eyes. No, she had to stay awake.

She focused on Entrapta, who was sticking out her tongue while tapping on her screenpad, concentrated on whatever she was doing. Hordak pointed at something on the screen.

“Maybe, that spot there…”

“Mmmmh, nah. That’s a volcano.”

“And this one?”

“Oh, that must be Tauro working with Emily and Darla. Look, those are the rotors…

“Right.”

Glimmer sighed, her eyes were closing again but fortunately Adora, Catra, Melog, Bow, Azeria and Wolfa entered the room one after the other, giving her what she needed to stay awake. Both

Adora and Catra looked ready to set fire to someone, Bow was nervous, Azeria looked calm but wary and she and Wolfa were wearing their uniform, the new uniform. Glimmer had been more than surprised to listen to Wolfa and Adora suggest the same changes to the Guards' uniforms and agree with one another, when Wolfa accepted to become a Royal Guard, five days before.

The new helmet left more space around the eyes, and the robe and dress were gone. Wolfa was wearing the new white trousers, a purple and grey jerkin, blue-grey boots and metal shoulder straps and bracelets. Just like Azeria, who accepted the job one second after Wolfa did.

Wolfa slightly bowed her head when she entered the War Room. "Your Majesty." She was so professional when she was on duty, so different from the angry girl that had snapped at her just a few hours ago.

"What's happening?" Adora asked.

"The sentinels spotted an unknown spaceship cross the sky above Bright Moon, but then the spaceship disappeared. Like, completely. It just vanished."

Adora and Catra shared a glance.

"It vanished, or is it just invisible?" Catra asked. Glimmer stared at her.

"We don't know it yet, Entrapta and Hordak are trying to detect it."

"When did it happen?" Azeria asked, her velvety voice caressing the air.

"Less than half an hour ago. I already sent messages to the other princesses and General Juliet with a squadron to search the Whispering Woods, just in case they crashed there."

Azeria smirked at her.
"Perfect. What can we do then, Your Majesty? Looks like you've already solved the situation."

"I wish, but I haven't. If they're not in the Whispering Woods, then I have no idea of where they could be. The sentinels said that the spaceship was weird, that it looked alive . I don't know what that means, but I don't like it." Glimmer shivered, remembering their frightened stares. "I have a bad feeling."

"Didn't they tell you anything else?" Catra asked, frowned. "What the hell does it mean 'alive'?"

Glimmer shrugged.

"I don't know, Catra, but they were scared."

"It was just one ship" Bow said. "Even if it's dangerous, we've faced an entire alien armada, I'm sure we can handle just one spaceship."

"Assuming that there's actually just one" Catra said, wagging nervously her long tail. "If they can make them invisible…"

"Then we will act like we expect there to be more than one" Adora said. "Glimmer, send another message to the princesses, tell them to prepare to defend their kingdoms from a lot of enemies, not just one. Entrapta, any idea of where the spaceship could be?"

The princess' hair motioned a big no while she kept working on the screenpad.

"They didn't leave any trace, but… hey, wait. Is that…" Entrapta widened her eyes, Hordak narrowed his.

"There wasn't anything there, before" he said. Adora rushed to look at the screen.

"Where?"

Entrapta's hair pointed at the screen.

"Here… that's the Crystal Castle."

Glimmer leapt up.

"WHAT?!" She met Adora's alarmed stare.

"We need to go there."

"Quickly. Everybody, come next to me."

Wolfa frowned.
"Can you really…?"

"Your stupid bracelet weakened me, but I can do a lot more than you think. Hordak, you keep the castle safe." She couldn't believe she was leaving the castle in his hands, but they didn't know their enemy. Entrapta looked at her.
"I need to come with you! I need to study that new kind of spaceship!"

"I need you to stay here and warn us if something strange happens. I promise you'll get to study that spaceship, if they're not a danger for Etheria."

Entrapta sighed.

"Anyone could do that! Leave someone else here! Please! I really need to see that spaceship!"

Glimmer sighed.
"Fine." Entrapta cheered and grabbed Hordak and dragged him closer to Glimmer. "Azeria, can you…?" Glimmer asked.

Azeria glanced quickly at Wolfa, then nodded.
"Of course, Your Majesty."

"Let's go then."

There was nothing there. Or so it seemed. Entrapta's trackpad kept showing a red, pulsing circle right in front of the entrance of the First Ones' ruin, but the clearing before it looked empty.

Catra raised her ears, trying to catch a sound… She pressed her right hand over Adora's mouth before she could speak, narrowed her eyes and listened carefully, focused on that empty space in front of them. It looked empty, it really did. But she could tell that there was *something* . The lowest sound was vibrating in the air, like…

"Sounds like an engine" Wolfa whispered. Catra turned and met her penetrating gaze. "They're watching us."

Catra nodded and lowered her hand, looking at Adora now.

"Don't turn into She-Ra, yet. I'd like to surprise them, if they want to surprise us."

Adora smirked and clenched her fists.

"Old style, then. Let's see if they actually want to fight, first. Maybe they're just scared."

"Arrow Boy, you're the best with words, why don't you go there and ask them if they want to kill us?"
"Was that a compliment?"

"Maybe I just hope they're gonna shoot you first."

He and Glimmer, who was holding Entrapta still, scowled at her.

"How funny, Catra."

She sneered.
"I know, right? Let's go, now."

They left their hiding between the trees and walked through the clearing. The sound was stronger now. Catra couldn't see Melog, but she could tell that they were somewhere at her right when they talked.

They're not using magic.

That's good news, isn't it?

Mh. Maybe. Or maybe that's why they're here. Like Horde Prime.

Catra shivered. She hoped Melog was wrong.

"It's not magic that makes the ship invisible" she whispered, glancing at Glimmer, who gazed at her in confusion. "Melog" she just said, and the Queen understood.

Bow stepped forward and cleared his throat.

"Hello, visitors! My name is Bow, I'm… a friend? I hope we can be friends, anyway. Show yourselves, don't be afraid, we're not here to hurt you!"

Catra raised one eyebrow.

"They should definitely shoot you."

"Catra!" Glimmer scolded her.

Catra, look!

She turned her head and her eyes widened as, from the nothing that seemed to be there, spiky and ever-moving shapes emerged slowly. The ship seemed made up of rigid tentacles, of an iridescent black, and they kept moving, changing dimension and position.

“Oh. That’s what they meant when they said that it looked alive” Glimmer murmured.

Entrapta squaked.

“Ooooh! Faaascinating!”

She wasn’t wrong. Even having traveled through a vaste part of the universe to bring back the magic to other planets, they’d never met anything like that.

“I really hope that they’re good guys” Catra whispered.

A larger part of that spaceship was moving slowly now. A ramp appeared in front of them, long and narrow.

Adora stepped forward.

“Stay behind me.”

The guests

Chapter Notes

Hi! Thanks for the kudos!!! Action is coming, I promise!
Little bonus: my drawings of Wolfa and Azeria with their new uniforms :D
Hope you'll enjoy this chapter :) <3





Wolfa was ready to attack. The ship was the weirdest thing she'd ever seen and it made her feel uncomfortable. Out of the corner of her eye she saw Adora move forward, further than Bow, even. That idiot! She was the most powerful there, they really didn't

need her to die first! But if she stepped up to protect her, the aliens would understand that she was valuable, so Wolfa stayed still where she was.

Something blinked inside the ship and then four figures appeared on top of the ramp. Wolfa narrowed her eyes watching them. They were tall, with large shoulders and four arms, but just two legs. Their skin was dark grey with black stains on their elongated oval faces, in contrast with their light-blue tunics. They all had long, dark-purple hair that shimmered with tons of shades, like their ship. They didn't carry any weapons with them, or so it seemed.

They stopped at the end of the ramp, just a couple of metres away from Adora.

Wolfa looked in their light-blue irises. She didn't like what she saw there. The fake smile on their face, the dangerous light in their eyes…

"Hello, Etherians" one of them said. Their voice was soft, pleasing. "My name is Koli, and these are Siali, Trali and Ruli. We're the four kings of Kadrima."

Adora was opening her mouth but Wolfa stepped closer and got their attention. They all looked at her, and their cold eyes made her shiver.

"I'm Wolfa, Royal Guard of Bright Moon, and I serve and protect Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon and her glorious kingdom." She felt that everyone was staring at her, but she kept her eyes on the four alien kings. "Why are you here?"

"I'm not talking to a simple guard. This Queen, where is she?"

Wolfa clenched her teeth and her grasp on her staff.

"Show some respect!" she snarled. "You landed on her realm and you're lucky we didn't..."

She felt a touch on her shoulder and turned, realizing that Glimmer was next to her now. She shut her mouth, she had to, to show them that Glimmer was in control there.

“It’s me. Please, kings of Kadrima, tell me what you came here for. I’m curious.”

They all bowed their head to her, and she did too.

“We beg your pardon, Queen of Bright Moon, if we’ve been rude, but we come from a very long trip and I’m afraid we might be a little bit tired. We only seek asylum on your peaceful planet.” Wolfa narrowed her eyes, her ears low. There was something wrong, something that didn’t match between their faces and his words. “We had to leave ours when Horde Prime destroyed it. We’re the only survivors, unfortunately.”

“Horde Prime tried to do the same on Etheria. You’re welcome here, of course, as long as you won’t try to damage this planet or its inhabitants.”

“We mean no harm.”

Wolfa stared at Glimmer, trying to tell her she was doing the wrong thing, but the Queen was looking at the aliens, smiling. She tried with Adora, but that moron was smiling at them, too, as Bow.

“We defeated Horde Prime” Adora said. “He won’t hurt anyone else.”

Really? None else could see that they were lying?! Wolfa turned and looked for Catra’s gaze. Catra noticed and she tried to tell her everything with a stare, and Catra narrowed her eyes, lowering her ears even more, her tail wagging. Wolfa felt a bit of relief: she didn’t trust them either. But why wasn’t she saying or doing anything?

“We’re honoured to meet the ones who defeated that monster. You saved the universe and avenged our people.”

“You said you’re tired” Catra suddenly said, smiling to the aliens. But… yes, she was pretending to like them. Wolfa smirked innerly. “Why don’t we go to the castle and offer our new friends food and rest, Your Majesty?”

Wolfa saw Adora give a start and Glimmer raise one eyebrow.

“Ehm... sure” the Queen said hesitantly, but then she got a hold on herself. “Of course. Follow us, if you please.”

The kings stayed still, though. The one next to Koli, Siali, raised his chin, his eyes fixed on Catra.

“And who are you?”

Catra smirked.

“Oh, I’m just a simple Etherian like any other, who happens to be around the castle quite often.”

Siali didn’t seem to be satisfied with her reply, but Glimmer, who gave another questioning glance at Catra, pressed the aliens to follow her and started walking, forcing them to do the same if they didn’t want to insult her. Bow went next to Glimmer and Entrapta started asking questions to Ruli, who didn’t look so happy about it.

Adora went next to Catra before following the group in the forest.

“What’s up?” she whispered. Catra nodded at Melog, that was still invisible, but she knew Adora would understand.

“We think they’re lying. I don’t trust them, Adora, be careful.”

“I had the same feeling” Wolfa intervened. There was no time for jealousy now. She glanced at the spaceship, and swallowed. “I don’t think we should let them get close to the Moonstone. Why did you invite them to the castle?” she asked looking at Catra now.

“To make them leave the ship, so that Entrapta and Hordak can study it. Glimmer can teleport them here in a second while those aliens eat and sleep.”

Adora stared at her.

“Don’t say ‘aliens’ like that. Technically, I’m an alien too, you remember that, right?”

“I say it like that because they’re clearly up to something and because I’m not sure they’re actually kings of anything, not because I care where they come from, you dummy!”

Wolfa held back a sigh.

“Your plan sounds perfect, as always” she murmured, turning to look at those tall figures walking away, mostly to avoid Catra’s gaze. “I’ll make sure they won’t notice Entrapta and Hordak’s absence. We’d better go, now.” She turned to find Adora’s narrowed eyes staring at her. Catra grabbed her girlfriend’s hand and dragged her away. Wolfa followed them, sighing. Gah, she missed the Crimson Waste.

Glimmer showed part of the castle to the visitors, trying to understand if they were trying to fool her or if they were just

telling the truth. Catra's behavior alarmed her. She almost lost it when she called her 'Your Majesty'. Catra, calling her that? Something was terribly wrong. And that evasive reply she gave to Siali… she was telling her that she didn't trust them, but she had a plan, or she wouldn't invite a possible enemy to the castle. So she led them to the sitting room and ordered a variety of food for them, entertaining them with the most idle chatter she could think about while trying to find out something about them.

"Would you mind telling me more about Kadrima? How far is it?"

Trali replied to her, this time. His voice was lower, more masculine than Koli's, and a little, silver ring decorated his right eyebrow piercing his dark flesh.

"It isn't even in this same universe. Kadrima is located in the universe called Karindos."

Now Glimmer didn't have to pretend to be interested.

"We've never been there. How long does it take to arrive here from there?"

"Eight, nine months with our ship. But it actually took more, because we stopped on other planets before landing here. That's how we came to know that this is a safe place."

"About your ship… I've never seen anything like that."

"Because you've never been to Kadrima" Ruli said. His eyes were long, elegant, with long, purple eyelids, and his lips were painted in blue. "Everything is… *was* made like this. The buildings, the ships, the furniture… It's a metal. Its name is kolundrio. Its molecular structure makes it indestructible, because it renovates itself continuously."

"That's incredible!" Bow exclaimed. "Do you think I could take a little piece of it to study it?"

Ruli frowned.

“Impossible. You don’t have the tools to cut the kolundrio.”

Bow looked so disappointed that all she wanted to do was reach out and hug him, but she forced herself to stay still. If they were dangerous, she didn’t want them to know how much she cared about Bow.

The servants came with the food and Glimmer kept chatting with the guests while she watched them taste their food. They didn’t show any kind of reaction.

“I don’t want to bother you anymore. You must be really tired, you can sleep in our guest room. The guards will escort you there once you’re satisfied with the meal. Now, if you will excuse me, I have some duties I can’t postpone. I’ll be happy to meet you again in the morning” she said standing up. Oh, her mother would be proud of her newfound diplomatic skills. “If you ever need anything, please feel free to ask.”

They thanked her and they bowed to each other, then she, Bow and Adora exited the room, leaving the kings alone with the guards, General Juliet, Wolfa and Azeria included.

As they were far enough, Glimmer grabbed Bow and Adora and teleported them to her room.

“What the hell is happening?” she asked, looking at them. Bow looked confused but Adora’s stare was the one she always had when she was following a plan and she was focused on her tasks.

“Catra, Melog and Wolfa think that they’re lying. Catra’s with Entrapta and Hordak in the War Room, go there and bring Entrapta and Hordak to the alien ship, they will break in and study it. Wolfa will make sure that the aliens won’t notice it. I’ll keep an eye on the Moonstone.”

Glimmer widened her eyes.

“Are you kidding me? Why didn’t you tell me anything?”

Adora frowned.

“When was I supposed to tell you?”

Okay, maybe she was right.

“Fine. Okay, so Entrapta and Hordak to the ship. Give me a second.”

Glimmer teleported herself inside the War Room. Catra was already starting to explain her plan but she placed a hand over her mouth, making her widen her eyes and lower her ears.

“Adora already told me. See you later.”

She put her hands on Entrapta and Hordak’s shoulders (touching Hordak was still weird) and brought them in front of the ship.

“Don’t make a mess” she said, but Entrapta wasn’t even listening already, she was running to the alien ship screaming with joy. Glimmer looked at Hordak. “Please, keep her calm and don’t make anything blow up.” She then teleported back to the War Room. Catra was still there, sitting on the table with a foot on her chair, that leg bent and the elbow leaning on the knee, the other one dangling and her tail wagging nervously.

“I knew something was wrong when you said ‘Your Majesty’.”

Catra grinned and jumped down from the table.

“It’s not like I could call you Sparkles in front of them. They had to believe we owe you some kind of respect, at least.”

Glimmer furrowed her brows.

“But I *am* the Queen, Horde Scum, and you do owe me some respect.”

“I’ll keep calling you Sparkles anyway.”

They smiled at each other.

“Better if we go before Adora freaks out” Catra said.

“Right.” Glimmer offered her her hand, but Catra shook her head.

“I’d rather walk.”

Glimmer shrugged.

“As you wish.” She teleported herself in her room, that Adora was walking up and down.

“Glimmer! Why did you take so long? Is everything okay?”

“Relax, Adora, I just stopped by to talk to Catra. She’s coming, she said she’d rather walk.”

Adora sat cross-legged on the floor, sighing.

“Okay. Now we’ve got to plan our next move.”

Bow gave a glance at his screenpad.

“We can’t do much but wait for Entrapta and Hordak to break into the ship…”

“That’s not true, we can…” Catra entered the room, making Adora pause. “We can try and get some information about Kadrima and Karindos. Bow, maybe your fathers know something about that universe…”

He pressed his lips together.

“I’ve never heard them talk about it, but I can try to ask.” He moved to the balcony and called them.

Glimmer gazed back at Adora.

“What else? Maybe I can help Entrapta if I…”

“You have to stay here, just in case they get out of that room and want to talk to the Queen” Catra said.

Glimmer sighed.

“Why don’t we pay Double Trouble to play me while I’m out doing something more useful?”

Catra clenched her jaw.

“I wouldn’t trust them. They could change sides and get us killed.”

“I pay them a lot. I don’t think that our *guests* could pay them more.”

“We already don’t know what we’re facing, Sparkles, we don’t need someone that would stab us in the back smiling if they thought it would be better for them.”

Okay, Catra was clearly mad at Double Trouble. She wondered what had happened between them after they accepted to work for her and betray Catra. Maybe it was better to keep Double Trouble as far as possible from her.

“Fine, I’m staying here, then. But I need to do something more useful than keep a bunch of aliens calm.”

Bow came back from the balcony.

“They’ve never heard of Karindos, that universe is never mentioned in the First Ones’ scripts” he said.

“It was worth a try” Adora commented. “We don’t know how fast their ship is, maybe Karindos is really far away. News from Entrapta?”

Bow shook his head.

“Not yet but...” His screenpad started beeping. “It’s her.” He answered the call and Entrapta’s loud and high-pitched voice filled the room.

“Hi Bow!” Glimmer teleported herself behind him to look at the screen. Entrapta’s face covered it completely. “Glimmer! Looks like we might have a little problem here…”

She frowned.

“What happened?”

“Oh, nothing, just…” The frame buzzed and tilted and suddenly Hordak’s face was all she could see. And he looked terrified. And he was clearly running.

“Take us away from here, the ship had a defense system and it’s attacking us!”

As to confirm his words, he framed a blackish mass crawling behind them (he was carrying Entrapta on his shoulder while she was apparently trying to detect something from that alien thing).

“Hold on, send us your position!” Glimmer shouted. As Hordak did it she teleported right there, grabbed them one second before that that thing could touch them and brought them to safety. Hordak fell on the floor, panting, Entrapta rolled down from his shoulder and jumped cheering.

“Yay! I collected enough datas to make an algorithm that will allow me to understand the molecular structure of the ship! And if I do, I will be able to disrupt it, with the right amount of energy!”

Bow helped Hordak to stand up.

“They said that it’s made of a metal that continuously recreates itself, I don’t know if we can… disrupt it!”

Entrapta’s eyes shimmered.

“A living metal! That’s the best thing I’ve ever heard!”

Glimmer furrowed her brows.

“No, considering they have it and can use it and we don’t.”

“But we could! We just need to understand how it works and make a couple of experiments to override its structure!”

“Did you manage to enter the ship?” Adora asked.

Hordak shook his head.

“We tried, but that thing attacked us. It… blurted out of the ship’s wall. It looked like it was a part of it.”

“It was amazing!” Entrapta squeaked.

Melog appeared in the room, his mane and eyes red. Glimmer watched Catra stare at them and widen her eyes as her ears lowered.

“What…?”

Catra turned and looked at her before saying rapidly: “They killed the guards, Azeria’s wounded and Wolfa’s chasing them in the castle! We need to go, now!”

Helpless

Chapter Notes

> Sorry I'm late! I'm going through a hard time lately, hope you can forgive the delay. As promised, here's some action! Hope you'll enjoy this chapter, I'll do my best to update the next one in time, for the honor of Gayskull!

Catra shook her head, dizziness slowing her after that Glimmer had teleported them inside the sitting room. Glimmer ran to Azeria, who was uselessly trying to stand up. There was a large cut on her left thigh, and it was bleeding *a lot* . The guards' bodies were laying on the floor next to her, their throats slashed.

"What happened?" the Queen asked while pressing her hand on the wound. Azeria moaned but beared the pain.

"They're quick, you need to find Wolfa or they'll kill her!" she panted.

The light in the room increased suddenly, reflecting on the walls with rainbow and golden shades. She-Ra kneeled next to Azeria and healed her wound. Then she looked her in the eyes.

"What direction did they go?"

Azeria's eyes were full of fear. Catra had seen her fight, and if she was afraid…

"I don't know, they… they went *through* the wall."

Catra gave a jump.

"What?!"

Azeria looked at her while She-Ra was helping her to stand up.

“I swear, they just walked through the wall. Wolfa used the door, I think she’s trying to follow their smell…” She walked to Glimmer and grabbed her by her shoulders. “Please, she won’t make it alone. She saved my life pushing me away from their blades and…”

“Blades?” Catra said. “They didn’t carry any weapons with them!”

She met her frightened stare once again.

“They were invisible until they used them.”

Shit!

“Glimmer, there’s nothing here they could want but the Moonstone!” She-Ra said. “Bring us there!”

Glimmer nodded. They all gathered around her, giving one last glance to the fallen before disappearing.

Wolfa jumped the now unconscious guard that Siali threw against her and spurred her legs to move faster, growling in the effort. Those bastards were fast, and they kept disappearing through the walls of the castle.

“Cowards!” she shouted. Koli turned and she saw rage in his cold eyes. He stopped, Ruli did too but he grabbed one of his upper arms and tried to pull him.

“What are you doing? We can’t waste our time with that guard!”

But Koli kept staring at Wolfa as she ran towards them.

“I want to get rid of her. Go on, I’ll join you as I’m done with her.”

Ruli glanced at her, then he joined the other two Kadrimans and they ran through another wall. There was only one of them left, now. Wolfa used her spur to pounce on him, but he grabbed her mid-air and threw her against the wall. The impact left her breathless, but she stood up just in time to avoid his once invisible dagger. She used the wall to push herself against him, managed to grab one of his arms, the one with the black dagger, and kicked his belly. He didn’t even seem to notice, and she had used all of her strength. She widened her eyes, tried to punch his face but he was quicker and hit her hard enough to make her fall on the floor. She rolled away, stepping back then when he started walking towards her.

“You’ve just condemned yourself, silly girl” he said.

Wolfa took time ducking his blows, trying to think. She needed a weapon, but they broke her staff a couple of corridors ago. The dagger. She had to steal his dagger.

“Why are you here? What do you want?”

Koli smirked and tried to kill her once again, but she rolled away. Stealing that dagger wouldn’t be that easy, not when her enemy was almost twice as tall as her and had two additional arms.

“Why do you care? You’re not going to see me obtain it, because now you die.”

He darted towards her and she tried to move, but he was faster. He pinned her to the wall, she parried the lunge but he punched her in the face and in the guts at the same time, and she could do nothing but try to breathe and see something, and he was already stabbing her, pushing the dagger all the way into her belly.

The pain was almost unbearable. Her body went limp, the feeling of that weird, warm metal sinking into her abdomen shocking her.

Their stares met. Koli gave her a cold, satisfied smile.

“You’re not worth fighting me.”

Then he pulled the blade out of her and let her fall to the floor.

Adora narrowed her eyes, searched all around them, but there was no sign of the four murderers.

“Where the hell are they?” she murmured.

Azeria kept walking up and down the floor before the bridge that led to the Moonstone, flipping one of her kives between her slender fingers.

“We need to find her, if they…” Adora met her worried, frightened eyes. “I need to find her, I’m sorry, I can’t stay here waiting.”

“You can’t go alone” she protested. Bow stepped next to Azeria.

“I’ll go with her.”

“They killed seven guards in the blink of an eye” Glimmer protested. “I’m not risking your life like this, Bow.”

Azeria stared at her in disbelief.

“Are you going to leave her alone to die?! She’s protecting you !”

Glimmer scowled at her.

“Of course not. I’m coming with you.” She turned and looked at Adora, but she stopped her raising a hand.

“Go, I will kill them as they come here. But, please, grab Wolfa and run away, don’t try to engage them if it’s not necessary. Be careful.”

Glimmer nodded before touching Azeria’s and Bow’s shoulders and disappearing. Adora clenched her jaw, tightening the grip on her sword.

“Wolfa will survive” Hordak said, surprising her. She turned and looked at him, who was staring at the entrance of the castle with narrowed eyes. “She’s not stupid, she won’t let them kill her.”

Entrapta lifted her eyes to him and interlaced her fingers with his.

“She’s gonna be just fine.”

Adora hoped they were right. She turned to find Catra staring at Melog. They were communicating.

“Is everything okay?” she whispered. Catra glanced at her.

“No. Melog is worried, and so am I, honestly. What if they’re not alone?”

“They’d have already attacked us. I mean, why wait?”

“Maybe they’re waiting for something. Maybe they’re here to start something.”

“Catra, whatever they want, we won’t let them get it. I won’t.” With all that power rushing through her veins, she was pretty sure about that. Catra didn’t look as reassured as she thought she would be, though.

“I hope so, because Glimmer hasn’t come back, yet.”

A stab of fear made her falter.

“She must be searching every room. It takes time…”

Catra’s gaze was still full of worry.

“What if they don’t want the Moonstone, Adora?”

“What else could they want?!”

Catra sighed and looked away, shaking her head.

“I wish I knew.”

“Maybe it’s my fault” Entrapta suddenly said, and they all looked at her. “They attacked after I tried to override their ship to break into it…”

“We had to try, Entrapta” Hordak protested.

“But they might have seen it as a war statement!”

“No” Adora cut in. “They planned on attacking us, they came into the castle carrying invisible weapons. It’s not your fault, Entrapta.”

She looked relieved. She was about to say something when the four aliens appeared from the wall at their side. Adora pushed Catra away to save her from a lunge, the blooded dagger hissed moving quickly next to her side and she had to parry with her sword Siali’s next sweep.

He was smiling.

Why was he smiling?

Adora pushed him away and gathered her power in her sword, sending a blast of energy against them all.

But nothing happened.

She blinked, confusion turning fastly into terror as she realized that Koli was holding something in his hand. It looked like a box,

squared, made of the same black metal of their ship and daggers.

And he was smiling.

As she realized why, it was too late.

Not that she could've stopped him anyway, but…

She felt like the box was pulling her soul out of her. She fell on her knees, screaming as pain blinded her. She lost her sword, and she was feeling more and more weak…

Catra heard Melog and Adora scream at the same time. She widened her eyes, watching with disbelief the thick thread of goldish-raimbow and blue energy link them to the box Koli was holding in one of his hands.

Not on my guard, bitch.

She jumped on him and scratched his face, making him scream as she slashed his left eye. He faltered, blinded by the pain and the grey blood. Catra climbed his tall body and sank her claws in his shoulders, making him scream again while avoiding his hands. The box had stopped sucking energy from Adora and Melog, but the other three Kadrimans were rushing to help Koli.

Hordak tackled one of them, but it was a luck that Glimmer and Bow reappeared in that moment. Bow threw one of his arrows

and a net imprisoned Ruli, Catra kicked Trali's face making him walk back while punching Koli's neck and head again and again. He fell on his knees, but she had to jump away to dodge his furious punches and his dagger.

She saw two of Glimmer's blasts hit both Koli and Ruli, but they didn't even seem to notice. *Oh, shit. Magic can't hurt them.*

Koli raised the box again and Glimmer, Adora and Melog screamed again. Catra tried kicking his arm but he grabbed her ankle and threw her away, making her bang against the castle wall.

It hurt like hell, but she stood up again. Adora's screams were crashing her heart, and that made her furious.

She was running again against them but Bow made them blow out with an arrow, and she was pushed again against the wall by the shock wave.

When she recovered, a few seconds later, she noticed that the four bitches were bleeding. One of them (Ruli, probably), had lost one of his arms. She sneered. She was about to go there and finish them when a huge shadow covered part of the castle, making her look upwards. Their fucking ship was silently flying just above them!

She watched them jump, or… fly? They could fly?! They levitated to the ship, flying through the iridescent black metal of its fuselage. Then the spaceship simply disappeared.

Of needs and awarenesses

Chapter Notes

> Hey :) Sorry if I'm late again, I'm still in a shitty situation, please forgive me. Enjoy the chapter and feed me with comments if you wish, thank you! <3

"Adora!"

Adora moaned and stood up, staggering. She was about to fall again when Melog tiredly changed shape, becoming similar to a person, and helped her to stand on her feet. She felt drained of all of her strength. Catra hugged both her and Melog, then she touched her face.

"Are you okay?"

Adora nodded.

"Yeah, I'm… I'm fine. I think." She shook her head, squinting. She gazed at her. "You?"

"I'm fine." Catra turned and she followed her stare to Glimmer, who was holding on to Bow's arm. Hordak was limping towards Entrapta, but he was looking at Glimmer.

"Where are Wolfa and Azeria?" he asked. And Adora realized in that moment that they weren't there. With one arm around Catra's shoulders while she was holding her waist, and Melog a big cat again at her side, she joined her friends.

Glimmer was pale and looked frantic.

"We need to go to her now! Adora, you're the only one who can save her."

Adora felt the blood rush away from her face.

“What happened?” Hordak barked.

“I don’t know, when we found her she was already… There’s no time, we need to go.” Glimmer moved one hand from Bow’s arm and touched her. Catra put a hand on her arm, Hordak, Entrapta and Catra imitated her and Melog touched her legs. Glimmer shut her eyes, and brought them to Wolfa.

Tears were rushing all over her face. Azeria didn’t mind wiping them away. She kept pushing on the wound, warm blood spilling between her fingers.

“They’re coming, keep breathing… please, keep breathing.”

Wolfa laid unconscious in a pool of fresh blood. She was paler than ever, dark circles were forming around her closed eyes.

They stabbed her, and not at the heart. Whoever did this, they wanted to give her a slow, painful death. Oh, she would make them pay for this.

Wolfa’s chest was moving slowly, weakly, and the pauses between every breath were becoming longer.

“Hold on, Wolfa, please. Just keep breathing.”

When she found her there, almost motionless on the floor, surrounded by her own blood, she thought her heart would just stop beating. How could she have grown so fond of a woman she had barely had the chance to talk to, she didn't know. But she knew since the very first moment she set her eyes on her, she couldn't bear a life without that fierce, stubborn warrior.

She felt something happen behind her and she almost passed out for the relief seeing that Adora was there with everyone else. She looked tired, and shocked when she saw Wolfa. Azeria looked in her eyes.

"Please, save her."

Adora nodded and raised her right hand.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she shouted. Azeria watched the transformation happen with expectation and worry in her heart.

She-Ra kneeled next to Wolfa and leaned her hands on her body, her shiny eyes closed, and Azeria drew back her hands, looking down with wonder at the wound as it started healing.

Pain. It was the first thing she felt. A deep, wide pain crunching her abdomen. It was deeper on a precise spot. Then she

remembered. The dagger, the Kadriman's smiling, cold eyes, the feeling of her life leaving her through the wound…

She blinked. Was she alive? There was light. A lot of light, it was all she could see. And it was coloured. Like a rainbow reflecting on a golden, shiny surface. She knew those colors…

She blinked again, her mind seemed to wish to escape far, far away, where she was just a moment ago, away from that pain, from any pain she'd ever experienced. But there was also something dragging her towards that light. A voice that kept calling her name. She knew that voice, it made her feel… confused. She liked it, but she also didn't like it at all. It was annoying, but she actually wanted to hear it.

"She's awake!" that voice shouted. It looked… happy, but frantic. Wolfa grunted, the pain was still there, intense, deep. The light vanished, and her senses started functioning properly. She opened her eyes. Azeria. She was staring at her, she was smiling and weeping, and she looked so relieved. She felt her warm hand on her cheek, a soft touch… Wolfa sat up abruptly, breaking that contact, but the pain on her abdomen stopped her from moving further and forced her to curl up moaning.

A touch on her shoulder, but this wasn't Azeria. Wolfa looked up between narrowed eyes and realized that Adora was there, too, and so the others, Hordak included, but she ignored him as always, as she ignored the pain and disappointment that his presence made her feel.

Adora was scrunching her eyebrows, an apologizing, tired smirk on her face.

"The pain will last for a while, but you'll be fine, don't worry."

Wolfa glanced at the spot where the dagger pierced her belly. Her uniform was cut, but her skin under it was intact. She stared at Adora.

"You saved my life" she murmured, astonished.

“Don’t look so surprised, Wolfa, we don’t leave anyone behind.”

Yeah, but she was different. She should be, at least, even if they kept trying to make her feel at home. Except that… she was feeling at home, in that exact moment. She thought Adora was just pretending to tolerate her presence there, but she saved her when she could simply let her die there on the floor. Who would miss her? (Azeria, her mind suggested, but she pushed away that thought). She could tell that Adora was pissed off everytime she looked at Catra, and yet she chose to use her last strength (it was clear that she was exhausted, for some reason) to save her from certain death.

“Especially the Royal Guard of Bright Moon, that protects and serves the Queen of Bright Moon and her glorious kingdom” Glimmer said, and Wolfa blushed slightly.

“You make it sound foolish, but you’re forgetting I took an oath.”

Glimmer laughed softly.

“You didn’t swear to say that so passionately, though.”

Wolfa’s cheeks were burning now.

“I-I take these things seriously…” she tried to say, but Catra snorted and her mind stopped working.

“You take everything too seriously. You should just try to relax sometimes, trust me” she said *smiling at her* , that smart, smug grin of hers that made her heart crunch and jump and blow out in a million fragments.

Catra walked to Adora and helped her stand up, and that helped her to stop staring at her, fortunately. She looked at Adora, right in her eyes.

“Thank you” she murmured. Adora frowned, clearly surprised, but then she nodded with a little smirk. “What happened?”

“They ran away” Bow said. “But we have a problem anyway: they can stop magic.”

WHAT?!

“They didn’t just stop it” Glimmer corrected him. “They were absorbing our powers.”

“Yeah, they can suck magic away from us” Adora added, gloomy. “And we can’t stop them.”

“And magic can’t hurt them, Sparkles hit them but they didn’t even flinch” Catra said. “Koli was using a sort of box to suck your magic, by the way, which means we must break that thing and stop them from doing it.”

Wolfa ignored the pain that still lived in her belly and stood up. Adora widened her eyes and moved to help her.

“Hey, what are you doing? You’re still weak…”

Wolfa glared at her. She was damn right, but there was no time to let the pain and weariness win so she forced herself to stand on her feet without her help.

“There’s no room for weakness during a war.” She had to pause to breathe, because she still felt like that dagger was tearing her muscles apart. “Why did they run away if they’re so strong?”

“I threw an explosive arrow against them” Bow said. “Then their ship arrived and they levitated inside of it.”

Ah. Better and better…

“Fire can hurt them, at least…” she murmured, looking away from them and noticing just then the large blood stain on the floor. Really large. Shit, she had to be almost dead when Adora saved her. *Focus, dumbass. Fire. You must use fire.*

“I could build a giant flamethrower!” Entrapta said enthusiastically, making her look at her. That princess scared her, sometimes. She looked way too happy to build things to kill people. She met Hordak’s gaze for a moment, but she immediately looked away.

“Make four” Catra said.

“I need to build more explosive arrows” Bow mumbled.

“No” Adora stopped them. “Entrapta, locate them like you did the first time. We need to know where they are. They’re injured, so I don’t think they will attack now, but we need to know if they’re heading to other kingdoms. And if they’re staying, why are they staying. What the hell do they want. That’s what we need to know.”

“I tried asking them, but I wasn’t lucky” Wolfa said looking at her. “They won’t tell us willingly.”

Adora sighed. She was staring back at her, her eyes were filled with determination and she looked ready to do whatever it took to bring them down. Wolfa swallowed, finally recognizing in her the Force Captain she was meant to be, and also feeling a bit in awe, because she could almost feel on her skin the aura of power surrounding her.

“You know what?” Adora said. “It doesn’t matter. Whatever they want, they won’t obtain it, because we’ll destroy them.”

Behind her, she saw Bow and Glimmer smile.

“Yes!” Bow cheered, raising his fists. “Best Friends Squad back in action!”

Adora turned and smiled widely at them. Wolfa felt a sparkle of jealousy and melancholy ignite her heart. She missed her friends, but she also knew they had moved on. Their bond was created by the Horde, and when the Horde had been destroyed, their friendship shattered too.

“They’re in the Whispering Woods” Entrapta suddenly said. Everybody looked at her.
“At the Crystal Palace again?” Adora asked. Entrapta shook her head.

“No, just in the woods. Between the trees. There’s nothing next to them.”

Adora sighed, clearly relieved.

“Good. They don’t care about the First Ones’ tech, then. Maybe they landed there just because there was enough space for their ship.”

“Or maybe they’re just trying to hide, now” Catra suggested. “They came here prepared, with a thing that can suck out your magic, a thing that can make She-Ra helpless.”

“Hey!”

“It’s true, Adora! I don’t like it either, but it's a fact and you must accept it, because you must be crazy if you think I’ll let you risk your life again now that we know what they can do!”

“Catra, I won’t stand aside while they murder our friends!”

“You fucking will instead! You can’t fight them, Adora!”

Wolfa silently stepped back. They were almost yelling.

“I will find a way!”

“You want them to suck your magic until you die? You think I didn’t hear you screaming?”

Adora hesitated.

“Maybe I can’t fight them as She-Ra, but…”

“What? Magic is inside you anyway, you dumbass, even if you don’t transform!”

“Catra, I won’t let you and anyone else fight them alone. They’re too dangerous, and I need to protect you all.”

“And I need you to stay alive!” Catra shouted. “Look at you! You can barely stand on your feet, you’ve never been this tired! I’m not letting you kill yourself just because you always need to be in control!”

A thick silence fell between them. Wolfa felt awkward. She thought she would be happy to see them fight, but she wasn’t.

“Catra is right” Bow said, and they both looked at him. “Adora, Glimmer… Let us deal with them, at least until we find a way to neutralize that box.”

“Adora” Wolfa said almost in a murmur, and she looked at her. She seemed ready to fight again, even if she kept her left arm wrapped around her stomach. “I will protect Catra with my life. You have my word” she said. She saw it in Adora’s eyes: she believed her.

Glimmer frowned, looked at Wolfa, then at Bow again.

“Promise me you’ll stay away from them, if you can.”

He smiled at her.

“That’s what I love about throwing arrows: I can do it from a distance.”

Glimmer giggled and slapped his arm, then she kissed him.

Wolfa looked away, meeting Azeria’s stare, who had stayed silent until then, she realized.

She heard Adora sigh.

“Fine” she grunted.

“Oh, so if Arrow Boy says it you listen, but if I do, you just don’t care?” Catra hissed.

Wolfa looked at them again.

“Of course I care, Catra, and it’s not like I agree with Bow, but you, him and Glimmer agree and I can’t ignore it.”

“I agree too” Hordak said. Adora pointed at him with her hand as if he was some sort of proof.

“Same” Azeria nodded. “We need to do this without magic, or they’ll destroy us.”

Glimmer nodded.

“And we need to alert our friends now! Bow…”

He grabbed his screenpad.

“I’m on it.”

Glimmer raised her chin and straightened her back.

“We have to take care of the fallen, now” she murmured.

Wolfa lowered her gaze. She hadn’t been quick enough to save them, she had barely managed to push Azeria away before that Ruli would kill her. She had watched them die, even their General, who had tried to save her colleagues.

They surprised her with those invisible daggers, but she would make them pay for the lives they’d taken.

The group was moving, but she waited to be the last: she could barely walk and she didn’t want them to see it. Obviously, Azeria made her wait useless: she stopped and walked side by side with her.

“Who stabbed you?” she asked in a whisper. Wolfa glanced at her.

“What matters?”

“I need to know.”

Azeria’s stare was frightening: she looked ready to cut someone’s throat. *She wants to avenge me* , she realized with mild surprise. And with that thought came another one: *If I tell her, she will put herself in danger* . And Wolfa realized in that moment that she didn’t want to see her lying motionless on the floor in a red puddle, even if she was annoying.

“I… can’t remember. It’s all a blur.” She blushed realizing that she was lying, for the first time. She *hated* it, but what could she do? But, oh, she just did what she despised the most, but she did it to protect her! She felt so conflicted she forgot the ghost of the stab’s pain.

Azeria gave her a skeptical look.

“Wolfa, are you lying to me?”

Shit, busted! What was she supposed to do, now? Lie again? Tell the truth and make that lie useless, a useless waste of honor? No way. She just kept her mouth shut and gritted her teeth to bear the pain and picked up the pace, leaving her behind.

Ready to fight

The funeral rites were quick and somber. They couldn't afford anything better, not with the threat of the Kadrimans weighing over their heads.

They were out there, waiting for the best moment to attack again. And there was nothing she could do.

Adora waited for Glimmer's speech to finish before going back inside the castle. Catra didn't follow her, giving her some space. She needed it. She needed to think.

She recollected in her mind the way she felt when Koli used that box. It was like her soul was being absorbed by it, drained out of her to that little, black object. It had been terrifying, absolutely horrible. But, even though her logic brought her to think that she wouldn't get that energy back, she felt good now. But just to check… she stopped inside an empty room and raised her hand.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

Power flew in her veins immediately, intense and breathtaking as always. She stared at her sword while thinking. So the box didn't actually absorb her magic, it simply made her feel like it did. Or maybe it did, but then it released it. It was a device they used to stop her (and the princesses, and Melog) from attacking, probably, and nothing more. Not that it wasn't effective.

She abandoned her She-Ra form, making the sword vanish with it, and closed her fist. They killed the Royal Guards, they wounded Azeria, they stabbed Wolfa to death… she didn't want Catra and her friends to fight them. They clearly weren't strong enough to fight back. The Kadrimans would kill them and she couldn't stand that possibility.

Maybe She-Ra couldn't fight them, but Adora could. Not face to face, though, Catra was right - as always, lately. She had to find a

way to hit them without letting them get near her. But, how? Cannons? Maybe Hordak could help with that. Perhaps… Dropping bombs on them from Darla would be wrong, right? She had to talk about it with Bow. Right now.

"Well… I can't say I would like the idea in any other situation, but they could kill us all next time, so…"

Catra walked inside the War Room while Bow was speaking. She had followed Adora's scent, after giving her some time to think. She knew she would come up with a plan, and she had to know the details.

Bow was standing while Adora was sitting on the table in front of him, giving her back to the door.

"What idea?" Catra asked. They both glanced at her, a bit startled.

"I thought I could use Darla to drop bombs on them. I would destroy part of the Woods, but…"

Catra raised her ears, widening her eyes.

"You want to blow up those bastards? I'm in!" she smirked. Adora snorted.

"Of course you are."

“Adora, remember that we don’t know the reach of that box, or which weapons they have on their ship. They could shoot Darla...” Bow said.

Adora raised a finger.

“If they see it. But if Melog comes with me…”

Catra lowered her ears. Bow was starting to make her nervous.

“They’re not affected by magic, what if they see you anyway?” she objected. “They shoot you and you’re both dead.”

Bow nodded.

“That’s indeed a possibility. Moreover, until they stay inside their spaceship, I don’t think we can do anything. They said we don’t have the means to cut through that metal…”

“They could have lied” Adora protested.

“Let’s set fire to it, and see what happens” Catra suggested. “Using Darla might be hazardous, but we still have the Horde’s robots. Let’s use them.”

Bow smirked.

“This is the best idea ever, Catra!” Catra looked at him and they both stayed silent for a couple of seconds, surprised. “It’s still weird to say it. By the way, we absolutely need to do it! I’ll call Scorpia and ask her to send us those robots…”

Catra snorted.

“She can’t.”

Bow froze.

“What? Why?”

“She has no idea of how they work. She kindly asks them to attack... Lonnie could help us, actually.” She gazed at Adora, who frowned.

“But she’s in the Crimson Waste. Tauro is closer.”

Her girlfriend was a fucking genius!

“I love it when you use that brilliant brain of yours!”

She grabbed her face and kissed her, then let her go and blushed remembering that Bow was watching them. He and Adora had the same surprised expression on their stupid faces.

She slapped Bow’s abs, making him grunt and bend over.

“Ouch! Why?!”

“I didn’t like the way you were looking at me. Make yourself useful and call Tauro, he’s got some work to do.”

Bow glared at her but he exited the room to do it, leaving them alone.

“Could you try to be a bit nicer to him?” Adora laughed.

Catra looked at her, gathering in her stare all the innocence she could find.

“I am being nice. He’s alive.”

Adora laughed, snorting, and she couldn’t help but smile.

“Hey, Adora, I… didn’t mean to yell at you, before” she managed to say, and Adora suddenly stopped laughing and looked at her with a bit of surprise in her beautiful eyes. “I just… I can’t lose you.”

Adora’s lips curved in a soft smile. She jumped off the table and cupped her face.

“And I can’t lose you, that’s why I don’t want you to fight them if I can’t be there to protect you.”

Catra sighed.

“Adora, I can take care of myself.”

“I know! But...” She scrunched her eyebrows. “Catra, Wolfa defeated you more than once, and they almost killed her.” Catra was already protesting but Adora stopped her putting a finger over her lips. “No, wait, let me finish. Azeria is the fastest warrior I’ve ever met, and she would be dead if Wolfa didn’t attack the Kadrimans. I have faith in you, I know you can do almost anything if you want it, but I don’t want to find you laying on the ground bleeding out.”

She sighed again, then grabbed Adora’s hand and pushed it down.

“I get it, Adora, really, but someone has to fight them, or they’ll slaughter us all! I promise I won’t let those assholes kill me, trust me! I don’t want to die now that I’m finally happy.”

Those words seemed to deeply affect Adora. She watched her eyes become glassy and fill with even more love than they’re already showing. It made her heart skip a couple of beats. It was mesmerizing to recognize all that love in her stare, even now. It was still hard to believe that all of this was true.

“Okay” Adora agreed in a whisper. Catra leaned her forehead against hers.

“I love you.”

“I love you, Catra.”

Wolfa sat on the armchair where Ruli was sitting, before they'd murder her colleagues. She touched the velvety purple cushion and shut her eyes, taking in a deep, long breath. The servants had cleaned up the room from the blood, and the smell of the detergents was strong and almost made her sneeze, but, under it, she could still smell the death and the Kadrimans' scents. She could also smell Glimmer, Azeria and all of the people who entered and exited the room in the last few hours, but she focused on the Kadrimans. Ruli, Koli, Siali, Trali. It was easy to distinguish them. Ruli's smell was thick, heavy, similar to the bark of a huge tree. Siali's was liquid, fresh, it remembered her of a stream of cold water. Trali smelled like fresh fruits and milk. And Koli's scent was intense, like broken green leaves, and somehow spicy.

Flowers and moss. Wolfa's eyes snapped open. She turned, meeting Azeria's startled stare.

"Are you okay?" she asked. Wolfa relaxed her body, but she stood up.

"Yes." She marched out of the sitting room, but she was forced to walk next to her in order to do so, as she was standing right in front of the only door. She saw she was about to grab her arm, and she also saw her hesitate and drop her hand. She appreciated it. But still… "Stop following me everywhere."

Azeria clearly didn't listen to her, as she trotted at her side.

"I wasn't, I just came there to see if they left anything. Maybe something invisible."

“Do it, then.” She glanced at her while she was still marching away from the sitting room.

“I want to know what you were doing there, first.”

Oh, so she was demanding now.

“Just checking a thing.” She stopped, since Azeria was still following her. Azeria was a guard too, now, and they’d been sleeping in the same barracks under the castle, but she didn’t want her there, now. She needed some sleep before the next war council, and she didn’t want anyone around, especially her. “Go to do your thing now, vixen.”

“Wolfa, I just wanted to thank you. You saved my life when they attacked us.”

She held back a loud sigh.

“It was just instinct, I’m trained to fight and protect my comrades at the same time.”

“I know, but thank you anyway. Also...” Wolfa glanced at her again. Azeria was staring at her with so much affection in her eyes that it made her feel uncomfortable. “Trying to catch them was really brave.”

“I was just doing my job. I couldn’t just let them go around the castle. And I failed, anyway.”

Azeria widened her eyes.

“You didn’t fail! You fought them and they stabbed you to death.”

“That’s the definition of failure. Now, if you’ll excuse me, I’d like to get some rest.”

Azeria though put a hand on her shoulder, and Wolfa tensed.

“You’re ready to die for a kingdom you were fighting against less than a week ago. I know you’re doing this for Catra, Wolfa, don’t get me wrong.” And with that she shut the protest she was about to give voice to. “I’m not that silly. But you’ll forgive me if all I can see is a woman who’s ready to fight and sacrifice herself for what she believes is right and valuable, and for the person she loves. Your passion and commitment are incredible, and I couldn’t hope for a better partner during a battle.”

That took her off-guard. She found herself out of words and Azeria simply gave her a little smirk before turning and leaving. Wolfa stayed there, in the middle of the corridor, speechless.

She’d never understand that woman.

Scorpia yawned, then read the message again. ‘DANGEROUS ENEMIES, DON’T APPROACH THEM THEY CAN SHUT OFF YOUR MAGIC!!!! THEY ALSO HAVE INVISIBLE DAGGERS!”

And then there was a rough sketch of said enemies. Yeah, they didn’t look friendly at all. But Bow didn’t say to go back to Bright

Moon, so maybe it was something they could handle without their help.

Scorpia sighed and looked down at her old bed, inside the Force Captains' barrack. Perfuma was sleeping peacefully, wrapped in the pink blankets she had brought from Plumeria. She tried, but she just couldn't sleep and so she had just started to silently roam around the barracks when the first message from Bow had arrived. And this one was the second.

Beside Perfuma's presence, a lot had changed inside there. Almost all of the walls were covered in flowered climbing, and the smell of iron and smoke had disappeared. It didn't seem like the Fright Zone anymore, actually, and it was a good thing.

Her stuff was still there, like the last time she'd been there to gather Catra's and send it to Bright Moon. The picture with her mothers, her stuffed scorpion, the crystals and the rounded stone, the jacket that Catra had given her in the Crimson Waste. She sighed again. She didn't miss those days at all, now. Catra was still important to her, but not as much as she was before. She glanced at Perfuma again and a little smile curved her lips.

I won't be controlled

“It disappeared!” Entrapta yelled.

They all woke up abruptly. Adora’s heart started punching her chest while she sat up, gazing at Entrapta in the faint light inside Glimmer’s bedroom, where they were taking turns sleeping, all together, just in case that something like that would happen.

“How?!”

Entrapta glanced at her while tapping on her trackpad, her hair moving to motion a shrug.

“The signal was there, and now there isn’t anymore. I’m trying to track the ship again.”

Adora stood up, as Catra already did.

“They’re attacking us again” she said. Catra nodded.

“Let’s go. If they attack us here from multiple positions through the walls, we’re dead. Got to the kitchens with Melog and Sparkles.”

Adora looked in her eyes feeling scared, anxious, frustrated.

“Be careful.”

Catra smirked.

“Always am.”

And then they left, running to the positions they’d selected in case the Kadrimans would attack again. The kitchens were the last place they would go to, or so they thought, seen that they were so annoyingly snobbish.

She knew that Catra and Bow were going to the gardens, Wolfa and Azeria to the entrance of the castle and Entrapta and Hordak to the Moonstone, and Hordak had brought with him his cannon. It was a good plan, her plan, and they were prepared, this time. She kept repeating it to herself while she was running to hide. She really hated that part of the plan, and she knew that Glimmer hated it too, but staying there would just be a distraction for her friends and they could get killed trying to protect them.

The kitchens were dark and empty, since they evacuated the castle. Too many people had already lost their lives.

Glimmer immediately started to walk the huge room up and down.

"I can't believe we have to stay here while they're out there to fight four invincible aliens!" she grunted. Adora frowned.

"Well, they're not invincible. Bow…"

"I know, Adora, but they're dangerous and if anything happens to them…" Glimmer didn't end that sentence but with an anguished stare. Adora sighed.

"I know. I can't stand it either. I feel so useless!" she grunted in turn.

"I mean, I know that we must stay here, but it's so frustrating!"

"Yeah…" Adora sighed and fell sitting on the floor. She crossed her legs while Glimmer was doing the same at her side. "I officially hate the Kadrimans. At least, those four."

"I want a giant barrier around Etheria so that none can come here anymore without our permission" Glimmer muttered. Adora gazed at her.

"Oh, it would be just great!"

Glimmer smirked and leaned her head on her shoulder. Adora relaxed a little bit, but not much, because Catra, Bow, Entrapta and the others were out there, fighting, probably, or about to.

Catra wagged her tail nervously, her hands clasping the stun-baton. She wanted a tank, or something that could make those morons blow up. Not that it was possible to bring a tank inside the castle without destroying at least part of it, so…

She searched the dark sky once again, but nothing was covering the stars but a couple of little, dark-grey fluffy clouds.

"What if they could listen to us and they're attacking the kitchens instead?" Bow whispered again. Catra rolled her eyes. He was panicking since they arrived at the gardens.

"If you keep saying it, they surely will."

He made a high-pitched, anxious noise that made her want to punch his face repeatedly. "Bow, stop it! You're distracting me!"

"They're not here, Catra! We'd be fighting already!"

"Maybe they're fighting against Wolfa and Azeria."

"Then we should help them!"

"And leave this place unguarded? Are you brain damaged or what?"

“I’m not brain damaged, I’m just worried for our friends!”

“Well then you should just…”

An explosion made the ground quake, the castle swayed slightly. Catra lowered to keep the balance, Bow fell on the grass yelling. She looked around, finding a column of smoke on the right side of the castle. Right where the kitchens were. *Adora!* And there, floating in the sky silently, slowly appeared the weird, ever-moving spaceship like a black, creepy creature. And four, tall figures flew out of it, together with four black little versions of the ship, moving towards the castle.

Catra hissed, grabbed Bow and ran with him inside the castle.

“I told you they were attacking there!” he shouted hysterically, and she couldn’t even blame him.

“So, how is it going with Catra?”

Glimmer watched Adora blush a little, and hid a smirk.

“Ehm… okay. I mean, good, great!” She blushed even more. “I just don’t know if she feels at home.”

Glimmer jabbed her in the side with an elbow.

“Come on, Adora! I can tell you’re happier than never! Both of you. I’ve never seen Catra so relaxed. She purrs everytime you’re around.”

Adora smiled.

“Yeah. It’s just that…”

Glimmer frowned.

“What?”

Adora glanced at her.

“She still feels guilty. I know that she looks okay, but I can tell that she’s not… not completely. She thinks she’s a monster, or that people think she is it. Or that people should.”

Oh. Well...

“She’s stubborn, Adora. It will take a while before she stops blaming herself for what she’s done. It’s not that easy to let it go, trust me.”

Adora gazed at her.

“Glimmer, you did what you thought was the best thing…”

She smiled at her.

“And I was wrong. I almost got us all killed. And, yes, I still blame myself and hate myself for that. It’s hard, Adora, when you hurt someone, it’s hard to forgive yourself. I’m trying, Catra is trying. It takes time, and it’s a thing we have to do on our own. But having you and Bow, and all of our friends to show me how much love I still deserve, even after what I’ve done, helps. A lot.”

They were both touched, and they couldn’t help but hug each other. They were separating when the world became white and loud all of a sudden.

Glimmer found herself laying on the floor, barely able to breathe. Her ears were ringing, and she couldn’t see much.

And then all she could feel was pain, and the feeling of her soul being pulled away from her.

“GLIMMER!” she heard Bow shout out. Wolfa sprinted and used a column to make a turn and push herself towards the kitchens. A wall had been destroyed, and the sea and the spaceship were now visible through the gash. She could hear the Queen and Adora scream, and she forced her legs to move even faster, growling in the effort. She extended her (new) staff, the kitchens’ door was visible now.

A strange, black sort of large, squishy spider jumped in the corridor from the open door. It was something unbelievable, her brain had a hard time trying to rationalize it, because its shape changed continuously.

Azeria surpassed her and jumped over the thing while showering it with knives. The thing fell making electrical noises and became a puddle, still, now, while Azeria landed behind it. She winked at her, and her heart skipped a beat. Wow, it’d been amazing, she had to admit it. She followed her inside the kitchens.

Adora was curled up on the floor, Glimmer was clasping it and Catra’s pet was hiding under a table. They were all screaming in pain.

Bow and Catra were already there, and they had engaged the four Kadrimans and the other three black moving things they had brought with them. Catra was slashing one of them with her claws while blasting Koli with her stun-baton, Bow was throwing arrows so quickly she could barely see his hand moving.

Wolfa set her eyes on Koli. He was holding a black box in one of his hands, and purple, goldish-rainbow and blue rivers of magic were being swallowed by it.

She wanted to charge him, but Trali was in between, so…

She pounced on him, using her staff to keep him distant enough to avoid his dagger easily. She managed to hit him repeatedly, but then he grabbed her staff and pulled it with so much strength that, if she didn't let it go, he'd drag her right to his dagger. So she let go of her weapon and kicked his face instead, managing to make him falter. And she hit him again and again until he fell on the ground, letting go of his dagger. She grabbed it and stabbed him right to the heart. He widened his eyes. Then he sneered, showing white, pointed teeth, clasped her with his four strong hands and threw her away, making her hit a counter, some pots and, finally, the wall.

The impact left her breathless and sore, but her bones were still intact, so she could fight. She stood up again, shaking her head, but on guard. But Trali was retreating under the hail of knives that Azeria was throwing at him. But she was almost out of knives, and… a blast blew up part of the room, the one where Siali was. Wolfa turned and saw Hordak march inside the room, his right arm, armed with the cannon, aimed at the Kadrimans.

BOOM!

Another blast, and Koli fell on his knees with a scream. Ruli and Trali moved immediately to protect him while Siali emerged from the smoke and debris limping, his face covered in grey blood. Trali's dagger was back in his hand, and that deep wound on his chest didn't seem to affect him very much. What the hell did it take to kill them?!

BOOM! BOOM!
Dust and smoke covered them, but the trails of light that ran from the princesses to the box were still there, so…

They were almost out of weapons: Bow had just three arrows left, Azeria was holding her daggers now, Catra was panting but she still had her stun-baton. Hordak was the one with the most powerful weapon. And it was him that they struck.

The spaceship exploded a shot that made the castle shake. It missed Hordak, but the wall behind him was demolished by the blow and the ceiling started collapsing.

No.

Not him.

She hated him, but… *not him*.

Wolfa jumped and tackled Hordak. She held him tight and jumped again, rolling away from the wreckage that would've crushed him.

He looked at her in disbelief. She avoided his stare and stood up to defend from the Kadrimans again.

No distractions during a battle.

Adora kept screaming. She couldn’t tell how much time had passed, but she was crying now. That pain was just unbearable, it was too deep, it was like burning alive and having her bones crashed and ripped out of her body. She could barely hear and see what was happening around her. Reality came like quick, blurred flashes to her. Glimmer screams. The Kadrimans approach. Another explosion. Bow throws his last arrows. Hordak shoots the enemies. Azeria swoops down on Trali.

Pain, pain, pain. And the feeling of being helpless, *controlled* . Anger was rising inside of her, but she couldn’t even move a finger...

She screamed louder.

Catra hits Koli with her stun-baton, but he punches her and makes her fall.

Pain.

She forced herself to open her eyes.

Koli is towering over Catra, he raises his dagger while holding the box with another hand.

No!

I won’t be controlled.

She screams so loud that her throat aches, but she doesn’t care. She feels it, finally, the power of She-Ra rushing through her veins. The pain gets more intense, but Koli is trying to stab Catra, who’s ducking his blows. She’s faster than him, but Ruli is coming and if she can’t fight two of them at the same time…

Adora stands up, her eyes lighten up. Her whole body, too, and becomes taller, larger. The sword appears in her right hand and she grasps it, clenching her teeth to stand the pain.

The Kadrimans looked at her in disbelief, just for a moment, but it's enough for her to shout out her rage and run to Koli, using all her strength to strike him with her sword. He parred with the dagger, but her sword cut the blade like butter and slashed his chest. She yelled and backed away, eyes widened.

"It can't be…" he murmured.

Ruli attacked her but she kicked him away with so much fury that she sent him flying outside the wrecked wall. Koli raised the box, and she fell on her knees screaming again.

No, no!

Stand up, Adora. You're stronger than this.

Catra is attacking Koli again. She's trying so hard to make him let go of the box that she becomes predictable. He knows what she wants, he knows what she'll do. That's why he grabs her arm while she tries to strike him with the stun-baton and moves the dagger towards her.

NO!

Adora stood up and jumped on him, holding her sword with both hands, and she pierced him from side to side. Their eyes met, he looked so surprised…

Then he pushed her away, coughing when the sword slipped out of his belly. He pressed one arm against the wound, staggering.

"Retreat!" he coughed. Siali kicked Wolfa away and ran to him, lifted him and jumped in the air, levitating then to the spaceship, like Trali was doing. The box stopped sucking her magic and she could finally breathe decently.

BOOM!

Hordak shot them mid-air, but the blast hit something invisible around them… the same thing that was dragging them to the

ship, probably. He tried shooting the ship, then, but he didn’t even scratch that metal. The spaceship flew away silently and disappeared.

She had just the time to check that Catra was okay before passing away.

A new commander

Chapter Notes

> Hi! I just wanted to thank you all for the lovely comments and the kudos! Thank you so much, I am beyond grateful! Hope you'll enjoy this new chapter :*

She looked tired. Beautiful, as always, but tired, even if she was sleeping. Catra kept staring at her.

Six hours. Her eyes were burning, her back was rigid and sore, her whole body was screaming her to get some rest, but she had to make sure that Adora was okay, first.

She caressed her loose, dark-blonde hair once again.

“Come on, Adora. Wake up” she whispered, anguish making her voice weak. Not that she cared. All she cared about was Adora, now.

For the first time in six hours, Adora reacted to her voice. She moaned softly and frowned. Catra’s heart started racing.

“Adora? Can you hear me?”

Adora’s eyes opened slightly. She blinked, moaning again.

“Catra?”

Catra smiled widely.

“I’m here.”

Adora slowly turned her head and gazed at her, her eyes still half-closed. She blinked again and narrowed them, as if she couldn’t focus her. Then she gifted her with a weak smile.

“Hi.”

Catra caressed her face.

“Hey. How are you feeling?”

Adora took in a deep breath, then let out a low moan.

“I need a vacation.”

Catra laughed, relieved, but also still worried for her. And a bit surprised, too.

“Really? You? My all-duty-no-fun-Adora?”

Adora looked at her again.

“I’m not like that!”

“Sure, and I’m a mermaid.”

Adora let out a weak, soft laughter, and she smiled distractedly.

“How are Glimmer and Melog?”

“Better than you, since they didn’t try to fight while they were being absorbed.”

Adora shrugged.

“The love of my life was in danger.”

Catra felt her cheeks flare, and she saw Adora blush in turn. She leaned over and grabbed her face and kissed her, letting that kiss speak for her. But also… She broke the kiss and slapped her arm.

“You idiot! You almost killed yourself! Don’t ever do it again or I swear, Adora…”

But Adora was smiling at her. She felt her warm touch on her cheek and she couldn’t help but purr.

"I had no choice. I realized while we were… let's say, busy saving Etheria, that I can't live without you… my love." Adora was blushing again, but she barely noticed it. *My love* . She had never called her that, and… it brought tears to her eyes, and an uncontrollable smile on her face. My love. A part of her tried to tell her she should mock her for being so disgustingly romantic, but that part of her was childish and belonged to her past, at least now. So, no, she wouldn't mock her girlfriend for saying two words that made her so happy. "And I don't want to give up our future, so don't worry: I'm not going anywhere."

Did she just wake up and decide to make her cry?! She shut her up kissing her again, closing her eyes to hold back the tears. Was it possible to love her more than she already did? She was pretty sure it wasn't, and yet she felt an explosion of pure, burning love in her chest, so intense that it took her breath away. And it was the most beautiful feeling ever.

Wolfa pulled out the last metal splinter from her shoulder, holding back a wail. The piece of metal tinkered hitting the floor. Then she cleaned the wounds with some cold water, wrapped them with clean bandages and tied them pulling the knot with the free hand and her teeth. She let out a sigh of relief and leaned her head against the wall. She wiped away the sweat from her forehead and took another moment before standing up, but the Royal Guards' barracks whirled around her and she had to sit down on the floor again. She shut her eyes, taking long, deep breaths. Okay. Maybe she needed to just stay there for another couple of minutes. Pulling out of her own flesh twelve shards had been more exhausting than she thought.

She didn’t even realize that those splinters had hurt her, while she was fighting. She’d been lucky: had they hit her neck, she’d be dead. And she risked her life just to save Hordak. What an idiot.

Flowers and moss.

She opened her eyes, catching the sight of Azeria standing still at the door of the empty barracks. She felt her own tail wag slowly. This time, she didn’t stop it, and Azeria smirked and came closer. She sat next to her, her back against the wall. Her orange gaze fell on the blooded shards she had left on the floor, then raised to her bandaged shoulder.

“I didn’t realize you were wounded. Do you need anything?” her velvety voice asked.

“I’m fine. I didn’t notice it either, not until I tried to take off the shoulder strap and realized it was pinned to my shoulder.”

Azeria frowned.

“You can’t be serious. Are you really trying to tell me that all those slivers didn’t hurt?”

“They did, I just didn’t notice.”

“How?!”

Wolfa shrugged.

“I don’t know. It’s not the first time, sometimes I just don’t feel the pain while I’m fighting. Or until I calm down.”

Azeria couldn’t seem more surprised. And worried.

“That’s… dangerous.”

She shrugged again, looking away.

“I know” she sighed. “Anyway… that thing you made with that alien robot… it was cool” she said glancing at her. Azeria grinned.

“Thanks! Wanna learn how to do it?”

Umh, she doubted she’d ever be capable of jumping that high.

“I’m too heavy.”

“Nah, you just need to get a running start.”

Wolfa looked at her and she saw her lower her large ears and widen her eyes. She could almost hear her heart beating fast, mostly because of the pulsing vein on her neck. Her mouth dried. Was her own heart beating faster? Azeria was staring at her with such a loving look, and she was leaning over…

Wolfa stood up abruptly, startling her. She felt dizzy, but she was strong enough to stand on her feet. Azeria stood up in turn.

“Wolfa! What’s wrong?” Azeria tried to touch her arm but she growled and stepped away, and she hated the regret she felt seeing Azeria so confused and sad.

“I… need to go” was all she was capable of saying before running away from the barracks, leaving Azeria there, still confused, still sad.

“They knew we were there. How?”

“Because they’re super-powerful and we have no idea of what they can or cannot do, Sparkles.”

Glimmer looked at Catra.

“What would you do, then?”

Catra raised one eyebrow.

“Are you asking me…?”

Glimmer nodded.

“Yes. Tell me your war strategy. Please.”

Catra couldn’t hide the surprise, but then she sneered and stood up.

“Okay, first of all, we must hide your magic. It’s clear that they want you,” she said looking at her and then at Adora, “or to kill you. Either way, we won’t let them win. Entrapta, whatever device they’re using to detect their magic, can you interfere with it somehow?”

Wow, Catra was quick to take control. Entrapta nodded.

“Oh, sure, I just need to modify the…”

“Whatever it is, do it now! Go!” Both Hordak and Entrapta left the War Room quickly under her determined stare. Glimmer didn’t ask her to give orders on her place, but if it’d lead them to defeat those aliens, she could accept to have Force Captain Catra with them for a while. “Also, we’re too exposed here. We need to leave Bright Moon.”

Everyone widened their eyes, but Glimmer almost passed out.

“WHAT?!”

“The Fright Zone is safer, Spark… Glimmer.” Catra looked deadly serious now. “I know this is your home, but if we stay here, they’ll destroy it. They didn’t attack the other kingdoms, which means that their targets are you and Adora… well, She-Ra. If we move, they’ll follow us.”

“I won’t abandon my kingdom, Catra.”

“You wouldn’t, you’d save it. You know what I would do to get you, if I were them? I would start bombarding Bright Moon, killing your people, and I would let you know that I’d stop only if you’d deliver yourself to me.”

Glimmer saw Adora pale next to her. She felt quite shocked, too. She was beginning to suspect that Catra had never *really* wanted to hurt them. Not that it mattered, now.

“I said ‘if I were them’, Sparkles, don’t look at me like that. I’m not an asshole from Kadrima. Whatever, what I was trying to say is that if you stay here, you put them in danger. But if you leave Bright Moon, they won’t have leverage on you.”

“Unless they conquer Bright Moon and use it anyway” Adora protested. Catra looked at her.

“They shot the kitchens, Adora. What makes you think they won’t attack the Fright Zone if they detect you there?”

“But we would put the Fright Zone people in danger, going there” Bow said.

“The Fright Zone people are former Horde soldiers, mostly” Wolfa cut in. “If they smell danger, they fight. They might even become our army...” She glanced at Catra. “... with the right person in charge.”

Glimmer saw Catra gasp and blush.

“I’m… not the right person, definitely.”

“Why?” Adora asked. “You were great as Force Captain!”

Catra’s cheeks were fire-red.

“Oh my, she’s so cuuute when she blushes!” Bow whispered in Glimmer’s ear, making her giggle. But Catra heard him anyway

and glowered at him before answering Adora's question.

“I think they hate me. I might… have not let them sleep for a while. Days. Lonnie was furious.”

“Lonnie can kiss my ass” Wolfa muttered. When she realized they heard her, she blushed looking very, very embarrassed. “Ehm… we never got along. She used to make fun of me when we were kids. She sort of stopped when I grew up taller than her and broke her wrist during a fight she had started.”

What a lovely place was the Fright Zone, fit for children… on the other hand, Wolfa was finally starting to open up to them!

“Wait, *you* broke her wrist?!” Adora almost shouted. “She said she fell from the catwalk!”

Wolfa snorted.

“Of course she said so…”

“Whatever,” Catra cut in, “I’m not leading the New Horde.”

Glimmer laughed.

“The New Horde?”

Catra shrugged glaring at her.

“What do you want to call it, the Sparkly Army?”

Glimmer had to hold back laughter.

“I think that we should ask Scorpia if she agrees, first of all.”

“Right. I keep forgetting she’s a princess.”

“Queen, actually” Bow corrected her. “Aaand, I’m calling her already.” He put his quiver on the table, turned the screenpad and leaned it against it before sitting on Glimmer’s lap. Glimmer motioned at Adora and Catra to come closer. She felt Melog’s

paws over her shoulder right before Scorpia answered the call. Her face filled the screen.

“Heyyy, oh, wow, you’re all there… are you okay guys?!”

“We’re fine!” Bow said. “But, we might also need a little bit of help…”

Scorpia frowned.

“What happened? Are you sure you’re not hurt?”

“The invaders kind of blew up part of the castle, it’s not safe anymore here…” Glimmer began to explain, but Catra interrupted her, speaking fastly.

“They’re too powerful and they can detect magic, Entrapta is creating something that will hide you guys but we need a safe place that’s hard to destroy and an army.” Glimmer scowled at her, but she had to admit she summed up things pretty clearly.

Scorpia was shocked.

“Oh. Oh! You want to come here? Sure!” Her eyes lightened up. “You didn’t even have to ask!”

“We’ll put you and the Fright Zone people in danger, Scorpia” Glimmer said. “They will attack us as they notice we moved there, probably.”

Scorpia’s smile became fierce.

“Let them come. We have tanks, robots and soldiers here, it’s going to be fun!”

“Thanks, Scorpia. We’ll be there as soon as possible.” Glimmer shared a smile with her and then ended the call. “Okay”, she sighed, “so, as soon as Entrapta is done with the device, we move to the Fright Zone. Then we’ll see who the former soldiers like the

most…" An idea crossed her mind. It was a terrible idea, but… "Probably Hordak."

Bow gasped. Like anybody else, to be honest. "What?"

Adora grinned awkwardly.

"I mean, he clearly can lead an army, but…"

"Yeah, Sparkles, it's not a good idea."

Glimmer frowned.

"Why not? He would never try to conquer Etheria again."

Wolfa cleared her throat.

"I think that you might want someone the soldiers respect and admire, not someone they fear. I don't think they'd follow his orders anymore, at this point."

"Exactly" Catra agreed. "Someone like you."

And Wolfa widened her yellow eyes, her cheeks red.

"WHAT?!"

Glimmer blinked, thinking that exact same word.

"You're the only possible candidate, Wolfa" Catra explained. "They hate me, they despise Adora because she defected, and she's She-Ra, Glimmer has magic and was their enemy, Bow is too soft…"

"Hey!"

"...like Perfuma, who has magic anyway, Azeria killed many of them, Scorpia is dense and soft, too, actually I still don't get how she became Force Captain in the first place, and she's a princess anyway, Hordak's been a scary asshole to all of us... *them* . You're

the only one left. They trust you, you're strong and bitchy enough."

Wolfa paled.

"C-Catra, I-I c-can't…" Was she stammering?! She looked so panicked! And so cute! "I mean, I was just a s-soldier, n-not a Force Captain…"

"Are you kidding me?" Adora snorted. "You attacked us, all the princesses together, with just three soldiers! And you won that battle!"

Wolfa blushed.

"Y-yes but…"

"Oh come on, I thought you were a warrior, not a frightened cub!" Catra spat. A tense silence fell all over them. Glimmer hid a smile, because she knew what Catra was doing, and she was sure that Adora got it, too. She glanced at Azeria, who was secretly smirking, next to Wolfa, who was all-eyes on Catra, her face red and her ears low. Then she snarled and bumped her fist on the table, startling them all.

"I'm starting to hate you, kitty" she growled. Catra couldn't look more satisfied.

"Making people hate me is what I do best."

Adora gave her a nudge.

"Not really…"

Glimmer watched those two idiots share an amused and loving glance.

Wolfa grunted.

"Oh, come on!" she blurted out "Take a room!"

They all laughed (both Adora and Catra blushed a little bit) but Wolfa, who looked quite upset, actually. Azeria put a hand on her shoulder, but Wolfa shrugged with a low growl, and she drew back her hand before getting a bite. Glimmer sighed. She really hoped Wolfa would eventually get her broken heart healed, but it looked like it would take a while, yet.

She stood up.

"Okay guys, we're done here. Pack your things up and get ready to leave Bright Moon. Azeria, if the Kadrimans move…"

The Royal Guard nodded.

"You'll know it immediately."

"Great. I really hope they'll stay in the woods, though, at least until we leave. That'd be really nice of them."

Old scars

The Fright Zone looked like an old skeleton invaded by vines and flowers. She could also hear some birds chirping. It was so weird!

She had called that place home for so long… now, all she felt looking at its concrete and iron was distress and the urge to make it better, to renew it. She decided there and then that she would help Scorpia to do it. There was so much to do, and she couldn't just ignore that place just because it still held some bad memories. She grew up there, and even if Bright Moon was her home now, the Fright Zone was still important to her.

"Are you going to stare at that door until the Kadrimans attack, or are you coming inside?"

Adora blinked, her sight focused on Catra and the half worried, half amused smirk she was giving her. Adora smiled at her in turn and grabbed her hand, walking with her inside the building.

"Sorry, I was just considering the idea of helping Scorpia to rebuild this place."

"Rebuild?"

Adora glanced at her.

"After the battle. Or battles. I'm sure they'll blow up at least part of it."

Catra giggled.

"That's what I call being optimistic!"

"I am. I said just 'part of it'."

Catra laughed again, let go her hand and wrapped an arm around her waist.

"I also guess that with 'considering the idea', you mean you already decided that you want to do it."

"That's… correct. But only if you…"

Catra smiled at her, her heterochromatic eyes full of love.

"Of course."

Adora felt as her heart was pumping pure love in her veins. She stopped walking to kiss her girlfriend, and couldn't help but thinking that she'd feel at home anywhere, as long as Catra was at her side.

Catra had to break that kiss, even if kissing Adora was everything she wanted to do in life. But, again, there was a battle to prepare, and they needed to concentrate on that from now on. Also because the meeting they had planned one hour before, when they'd arrived there and got a series of bone-crushing hugs from Scorpia, had started ten minutes ago.

She stepped back holding her hand again, and pulled her towards the room where they once listened (Adora, at least) to the Horde officers' classes.

Scorpia, Perfuma, Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta, Hordak, Wolfa and Azeria were already there (Catra had sent Melog to Plumeria, where Swift Wind was keeping an eye on the kingdom, just to keep them safe seen that they were, like, made of magic).

They all looked at them when they entered the room.

"You're late. I was about to come and get you" Glimmer scolded them. "And don't you try to tell me you got lost, it would be the dumbest excuse ever."

“Sorry, Glimmer, it won’t happen again” Adora said. Catra held back a sigh.

Bow smirked at Adora.

“I know it’s hard to come back here for you” he said, and he looked at Catra, too. She rolled her eyes.

“I’m fine. Scorpia, tell me you did something useful, in the meantime.”

Scorpia straightened her back.

“Oh, sure! I gathered the soldiers in the training hall, as you asked. They’re waiting for orders.”

“How many soldiers do we have?” Wolfa questioned her. Her stare pierced Scorpia, who blushed a little bit while she stood at attention.

“Ehm… fifty-six, and seven officers. I didn’t gather the cadets, I don’t think they’re ready, but if you...”

Wolfa narrowed her eyes.

“Tanks? Robots?”

“Twenty tanks and seventy-eight robots, and five skiffs, Commander.”

Catra caught the hint of a proud smirk on Hordak’s face. She raised one eyebrow, but didn’t comment.

Wolfa hesitated for a moment, then she sighed.

“Good job, Force Captain” she said between clenched teeth. Uhm, she didn’t see that coming. Maybe Wolfa didn’t need a kick in the ass anymore.

Scorpia grinned.

“Thank you! That’s my job, actually, I mean, I’m pretty good at it by now because I’ve been…”

Wolfa snarled at her, leaning her hands on the table before her, hunched like a beast ready to plant their fangs on someone’s neck.

“You should learn to shut the fuck up, crab.”

“Hey!” Perfuma put herself between them, facing the new commander of the Horde. “Don’t you dare to talk to her like that! She’s amazing and she was just being nice to you! You owe her some respect!”

Wolfa’s ears were flat and her fangs were showing, her tail was puffing and her uniform was lifting on her shoulders, pushed up by her fur. *Oh oh...*

“I owe her nothing, *Princess* . She’s under my command now and I can…”

“You’re wrong. She’s the Queen, here. *You* ’re under her command, actually, let alone the fact that she spared you many times when you attacked us.”

Wait, what?

“Scorpia!” Catra growled. “Did you?!”

Scorpia blushed.

“I didn’t want to hurt her…”

Adora frowned.

“Oh, sure, you didn’t want to hurt Wolfa when she kidnapped Glimmer, but you didn’t hesitate to throw tanks at us when you were under Prime’s control.”

Scorpia widened her eyes.

“I didn’t *want* to do that!”

Perfuma rolled her eyes.

“Again, Adora? Seriously?”

“Stop it!” Glimmer silenced them all. “Wolfa, stop being a bitch to Scorpia, she’s a friend *and* a Queen, you can’t talk to her like that. Scorpia, please, stand up for yourself, you’re probably the most powerful princess, don’t let anyone treat you like garbage. Adora, Perfuma is right, the story about the tanks is getting old…”

“But it was unfair!” Adora pouted. Catra giggled and Adora punched her shoulder. “Shut up!”

“You’re such an idiot!”

Wolfa cleared her throat.

“You’re right” she said. Catra wasn’t sure if she was talking to her or to Glimmer until she saw her stare at Sparkles. Then Wolfa sighed, looked at Scorpia, who seemed quite embarrassed, and gritted her teeth, her fists clenched. “I apologize for my behavior… Queen Scorpia” she spat. “Thank you for the help you so kindly gave to the army.”

Oooh, she was *furious* . She looked ready to kill both Glimmer and Scorpia now. Perfuma looked quite satisfied, instead. And Scorpia was blushing.

“Oh, I, uh… my pleasure… Commander Wolfa” she stammered. Catra held back a sigh. *She’s hopeless* .

Wolfa turned again to face Glimmer, but, even if she was standing at attention now, she wasn’t looking in the Queen’s eyes, and hers were burning with rage.

“With your permission, Your Majesty, I’d rather get the troops organized, now.”

Glimmer sighed.

“We need to talk about this, Wolfa.”

The commander glanced at her.

“I’m afraid there’s no time, now, the Kadrimans could…”

“They will attack the east side of the Fright Zone, because that’s where they lost our signal,” Catra cut in, “when Entrapta activated the scrambler.”

“And if they do, they will find a lot of robots ready to shoot them” Adora added. “We’re safe here. But I agree with Wolfa anyway, there’s no time to lose.”

Glimmer grunted.

“I know, I know… Okay, go, Wolfa.” The commander marched outside the room quickly. Scorpia sighed.

“Maybe I should try to talk to her…”

“I wouldn’t, if I were you” Azeria said, unexpectedly. Catra raised one eyebrow.

“Seriously? You try every time.”

The fox-girl nodded.

“Yeah, but she doesn’t hate me. She snaps at me, she might growl and snarl, but that, what she just did, damn…” Azeria sighed glancing at Scorpia. “I was sure she would actually assault you. I don’t know why, but she’s really mad at you.”

Catra snorted.

“If you don’t know why, you’re dumber than I thought.”

Azeria stared at her, lowering her large ears.

“Please, enlighten me.”

“She’s jealous” Adora grumbled before she could open her mouth.

Azeria frowned.

“Of Scorpia? Why? You two…?”

Catra blushed.

“No!” she said way too loud, and Scorpia blushed and glanced down. Shit, she didn’t mean to say it *that* way. Urgh! Why was dealing with people so damn hard?! “I-I mean, Scorpia, don’t…”

“Nevermind, wildcat” she almost whispered. “I know you never even considered it. And I really don’t care anymore.” She gazed at Perfuma, who looked a bit conflicted though.

“Well that’s not.. true…” she admitted, blushing. She eyed Adora, who was looking at her with her eyes wide open. Everyone was, actually, Scorpia included. She sighed and lowered her eyes, fists clenched. It was time to explain a couple of things, wasn’t it? “I did, actually” she muttered. “But I knew it wouldn’t be what you wanted. I couldn’t give you what you needed, that’s why I kept pushing you away. Also, you were kind of… clingy, and it was annoying.”

Silence, for at least one entire minute, and she didn’t dare to raise her gaze. Then Scorpia talked: “So it was my fault? Because I was clingy?”

Catra looked at her.

“Well, I don’t like to be touched and you kept invading my personal space, but that’s not what I said. I said that I didn’t mean to hurt you, dumbass. Maybe I did it the wrong way, but I was trying to protect you from… well, *me* . I love Adora, Scorpia, I always have, and all that could come from me and you ending up together was you getting hurt.” Wow, she couldn’t believe she actually put it into words, finally. It had always been like a secret

only she knew, and now everybody was looking at her like she grew a couple of big, shiny horns.

Scorpia started weeping.

“You pushed me away because you cared about me?”

Catra sighed.

“Of course, dumbass.You were… *are* my friend.”

Her eyes shimmered.

“Can I hug you now?”

Well, she was making progress, at least.

Catra smirked, shaking her head.

“If you must…”

And half a second later she was being squeezed by one of Scorpia’s enthusiastic hugs.

“I love you so much!” Scorpia was squealing. Catra snorted, and tried to push herself out of her hold.

“Shut up!”

Scorpia let her go, but kept smiling.

“You really…”

“Stop it!”

“But I thought you were just being mean and instead you were…”

“Doing it on purpose, yes. I just… I didn’t think you’d leave, someday. I thought you’d stay. Or say goodbye, at least.”

Scorpia's shoulders fell as the smile on her face became a sad, regretful expression.

"Oh, Catra, if I knew…"

But Catra punched her arm, smirking. Scorpia leaving her alone had been the last straw, and she didn't really want to remember how she'd felt that day.

"It's all right. Now, can we talk about the guys who want to kill us all, please? Wasn't that the purpose of this meeting?"

"Yes, sure, right!" Glimmer said. "The guys, I mean, the Kadrimans… Bow, pull it together!" Catra glanced at him and saw him wipe his eyes. That guy was impossibly sensitive!

She turned and met Adora's stare. She was smiling, and she nudged at her.

"Hey" she whispered "I'm proud of you."

Catra choked. She had to look away, take a breath.

"Shut up, dummy! Sparkles is talking."

Out of the corner of her eyes, she saw that Adora was still smiling, but she set her eyes on Glimmer and listened to her, even when Catra moved her tail to touch her hand.

I'm proud of myself, too.

The Fright Zone, her home. She had missed that place so much… but it looked so different now, and yet, it was still the same. The

smell was different, though. And it was disturbing, it made her nervous. Like being there with Hordak, Catra and the others, and having to pay respect to Scorpia, and being responsible for all the people that were now looking at her expectantly.

Wolfa let her stare wander over the soldiers and officers. Octavia was glaring at her like she was some sort of disgusting bug that she wanted to step on, but almost everybody else looked just to be waiting for orders. She grabbed the metal rail in front of her. She was never one to give orders, she would simply obey, but, oh, there she was, the new Commander of the Horde made by the sixty-two people gathered down there. If somebody told her it would happen, just a few months ago, she would call them nuts.

Okay.

She filled her lungs and made sure that her voice sounded cold and steady.

"Soldiers" she began, winning her shyness somehow, just because Catra gave her that role, Catra expected her to be a Commander, so she would be a Commander. "My name is Wolfa. Some of you may remember me, while I've never met others. The Horde was a great… huge armada, and the Fright Zone is vast. The ones who know me, also know that I was a simple soldier, like many of you. I wasn't a Force Captain, let alone a Commander." She saw Octavia smirk, and she clenched her teeth, hearing some whispers between the troops. "But times have changed. I recently led a few attacks against the princesses." More murmurs that made her smirk. "They were all successful, but I was defeated eventually. And that led me to a new awareness. First of all, I realized that the princesses aren't evil. They may still act like bitches, though." Many of the soldiers laughed together with her. She noticed Octavia look around like she was surprised, and held back a sneer. "They're powerful, loyal and brave. Lord Hordak fooled us. Shadow Weaver manipulated us. The princesses are not enemies, and we were uselessly fighting for someone who lied to us!" The voices started to raise from the crowd, and she let them vent. When they calmed down, she plowed on: "I'm not lying to you.

Just a few days ago I swore I would protect Queen Glimmer and the kingdom of Bright Moon. I'm a Royal Guard of Bright Moon, I'm not a Horde soldier anymore. This, us, we're not the Horde. We're free, we won't fight and die for someone who used us!" Her voice was becoming louder, and it made an effect on the soldiers that started cheering her. She clenched a fist and bumped it against the rail. "The princesses forgave our crimes. They welcomed us between them, and they're ready to fight to protect us because we're their people!" The crowd cheered louder. "That's why I'm asking you to fight this war! Fight for the princesses, fight for Etheria! The Kadrimans dared to attack us, to kill our people! We won't let them get away with it, we're not letting them win this war!" she growled, and they shouted their approval. "Those assholes can stop the princesses' magic, we will stop their stupid hearts and put an end to this. We are warriors! We are a pack and we will fight as one!" she shouted. "Are you ready to defend Etheria?"

"YES, COMMANDER!"

"Are you ready to fight for the princesses?"

"YES, COMMANDER!"

"Everyone to battle stations, then, let's show those assholes what we're capable of! Force Captains, Commanders, eight soldiers each, I want you to cover the east and south side. Bring all the tanks and robots you can. Soldiers, use long-distance weapons as long as you can, and shoot for their heads. Their weapons can be invisible, be careful. I will come with…"

She had to stop, because from Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle had just made their entrance. Lonnie gazed up at her, a hand on her hip. She smirked.

"Hey, Wolfa. Heard your speech. Nice."

Wolfa lowered her ears. She held back a growl and spoke to the other soldiers.

“Get prepared, the Kadrimans could attack at any time.”

The crowd gave some curious glances at Lonnie, but then they all moved to put their old armours on. Wolfa jumped down from the catwalk and landed in front of the trio.

“I wasn’t expecting to see you guys ever again. I thought you were done with this.”

She couldn’t hide the contempt. They defected the Horde, months before, they ran away like cowards.

Kyle shrugged.

“We heard that the princesses were in trouble and we thought we might help.”

But Wolfa kept staring at Lonnie, who was staring back at her in turn, smirking. Now she had crossed her arms over her chest.

“So Catra’s not giving orders anymore. She put you in charge? Did you finally manage to get in her pants?”

Wolfa snarled, grabbed her by her shirt and pinned her to the wall.

“Don’t you dare, Lonnie, none’s gonna stop me from killing you this time!”

Lonnie’s smile widened.

“Oh, you didn’t? Poor, little cub.”

Wolfa was pushed away from Lonnie by Rogelio. They roared at each other, Lonnie touched Rogelio’s shoulder.

“Relax, Ro, she doesn’t have it in her. She’s still the stammering, little, weak cub she’s always been.”

This time Wolfa clutched her throat and Lonnie widened her eyes, grabbing her arm while she was struggling to breathe. Rogelio

tried to punch her but she grabbed his fist mid-air and squeezed it, making him whine in pain.

"If you're staying, you're going to follow my lead and fight against the Kadrimans like the other soldiers." Lonnie's face was becoming blue, Rogelio fell on his knees, trying to pull away the hand from her grasp. Kyle intervened and started punching her back. She barely noticed. "Otherwise, run away as fast as you can, Lonnie, because if I catch you none will save you."

She let them go and pushed Kyle away to distance from them, trembling in the effort to keep calm enough not to kill them. She heard Lonnie coughing while walking away, and couldn't hold back an amused sneer.

"Meet you in the classroom in ten minutes, soldiers" she said before leaving.

Troubles

Chapter Notes

> Thank you for your support guys! I will try to update more often, but I can't promise I will actually do it because, you know, life... anyway, I hope you'll enjoy this little chapter. Baaaad things will happen soon, so... was that a spoiler? Maybe.

“Lonnie! Rogelio, Kyle!” Adora smiled widely and walked to the trio that had just entered the room where they were taking a break and eating something. She hugged Lonnie, who didn’t look too happy about it, then Rogelio, who said something she didn’t understand, as always (was his right hand broken? It looked broken) and Kyle, who was the only one to hug her in turn. “What are you doing here? When did you arrive?”

“I told them we were in trouble” Scorpia grinned, hugging them in turn. Lonnie looked ever more pissed off.

“Put me down, Scorpia!” she grunted.

Adora watched her and Catra share an awkward, I’m-not-too-happy-to-see-you-again glance, then they both looked away.

Bow came closer.

“Hi! You came to help us?” he smiled. Lonnie glared at him.

“No, to kill you. Of course we came to help, you jerk!”

He laughed.

“I swear, you guys from the Horde are a blast! Your false aggressiveness is so funny!”

Adora let out a nervous laugh, put her hand on Bow’s shoulders and gently moved him away from Lonnie.

“Eh eh, it’s not false, Bow, trust me. Anyway, we’re happy you’re here. We need all the help we can get.”

Lonnie glanced somewhere at Adora’s right and, looking in that direction, she saw Wolfa stare at Lonnie. There was something weird in her expression, she looked both smug and angry. It was probably because of their past, though, nothing to worry about.

“Scorpia told us everything. Just tell us what we can do to help” Kyle said. Adora smiled at him.

“Ask your commander, not me.”

She could swear she saw him gulp and pale a little bit. He gave Wolfa the quickest glance before looking at Adora again. Oh, so they already knew that she was in charge...

“Ehm…”

Lonnie turned to face Wolfa, an annoyed expression on her face.

“Come on, Wolfa, give your orders, if you can.”

Adora tensed. Wolfa was still staring at Lonnie, but her eyes had just become ice-cold, like her voice.

“It’s ‘Commander Wolfa’ for you, soldier” she basically snarled, but in a low voice. She looked like a bomb about to go off, and it made a shiver run down her spine.

Lonnie rolled her eyes.

“Do you really think that your little show changed anything? You’re still a loser, cub.”

Adora watched Wolfa clench her fists, saw the shirt lift on her back, her tail tense and her ears lower.

“Lonnie...” Adora tried to warn her.

“What?” she laughed. Then she spread her legs and raised her fists, nodding once at the commander. “Come on, cub, show me what you’re capable of.”

Wolfa growled. Bow screeched and put himself between them, spreading his arms to keep them separated.

“Are you guys out of your mind?! We are under attack! We could all die and you waste your time fighting each other? We’re on the same side!”

Wolfa glared at him.

“Hey, she’s the one being a bitch, don't look at me!”

“I just want to get even, cub!”

“Stop calling me that!”

“Why? It’s what you are, a dumb, weak cub.”

“YOU TWO, SHUT UP!” Glimmer shouted. They all stared at her. “Lonnie, stop mocking her, you’re not kids anymore. Wolfa, why does she want to get even? What have you done to her?”

Wolfa snorted.

“Of course it’s my fault, because I’m the big bad wolf…”

“Are you kidding me?” Lonnie snorted. “You broke Rogelio's hand and choked me!”

So she was right, it *was* broken.

“Wolfa!” Glimmer blurted out, probably because the girl in question was wagging her tail with a smug face.

“Why did you do it?” Adora asked, cautious. Wolfa glanced at her, and she looked annoyed now.

“Because she deserved it. Rogelio tried to punch me and I reacted.”

“He was trying to save Lonnie!” Kyle protested. When Wolfa set her eyes on him, he stepped back, visibly frightened.

“Save?” She laughed. “Come on! If I wanted to kill her, she’d be dead already.”

Rogelio roared something. Had to be related to his angry and frightened expression.

Wolfa snorted.

“Listen, I’m sorry I broke your hand, but you put yourself in the middle. It’s your fault if you didn’t calculate the risks. Next time, think twice.”

“Wait,” Catra intervened, “you understand what he says?”

Wolfa blinked.

“Of course. Don’t you?”

Catra furrowed her brows.

“Not a single word. Like everybody else.” She gazed at Lonnie, and she nodded in confirmation, still angry but a bit bewildered now. Wolfa shared a glance with Rogelio, who shrugged.

“Wait, you guys always talk to him!”

“Yeah but… I mean, we just guess what he wants to say…” Kyle said, rubbing the back of his head. “You know, just because we have known each other since forever.”

Wolfa seemed shocked. She stared at Rogelio.

“And you know they can’t understand you?”

He roared something, quite a complex speech it seemed, nodding and moving his sane hand now and then.

“Oh. That’s… typical, actually. I would have done the same.” Wolfa sighed then. Lonnie narrowed her eyes.

“Wait, what did he say?”

Wolfa didn’t look enthusiastic about talking to her, but she answered anyway.

“That sometimes you don't get what he means, and it’s frustrating, but he doesn't want to be a burden for you so he just shakes it off and keeps trying. He sees his incapacity to speak like us like a weakness, and he can’t hide it, so he does the only thing he can do: he says you’re right even when you’re not.” She looked back at him as she finished, so she didn’t notice that Lonnie’s eyes were becoming glassy. Adora had never seen Lonnie cry, not even when they were kids. Well, she wasn’t exactly crying now, but she was about to… and her face was full of regret. “You could've told me” Wolfa said to Rogelio. “If I knew, I would’ve helped you.”

He frowned and roared again.

Wolfa sighed.

“Right…” she gazed at Lonnie and sighed again. “It’s your fault.”

Lonnie widened her green eyes while Rogelio roared again.

“My fault?!”

Wolfa shrugged.

“Okay, maybe he didn’t say exactly that…” Rogelio nodded furiously. “Mh, okay, okay... he said he didn’t talk to me because of our… contrasts” she referred. Then she looked Lonnie right in the eyes. “Anyway, you are going to defend the east side. The others have already taken the tanks and the robots, you’re on your own.”

Adora tensed.

“Wolfa…”

The Commander looked at her, a warning stare in her yellow eyes.

“What?” she spat.

“Maybe you should…” Wolfa was lowering her ears, “assign them to another squadron as support…” The commander wrinkled her nose, showing her fangs for a second. “...seen that the Kadrimans are so dangerous, you can’t expect them to fight them without a tank or...”

Wolfa emitted a low growl that reverberated through her chest.

“Do you think I’m stupid, Adora?”

She stayed silent then, and so Adora realized she was actually waiting for an answer. *Okay…*

“Of course not, but you’re sending them to die!”

Wolfa’s ears lowered even more. She looked more offended than angry now.

“Do you really think I would do such a thing just because me and Lonnie hate each other?” She shook her head. “The east side has four squadrons already, they will have their back” she added in a lower voice. Adora regretted her intervention so much that she blushed. “Whatever you may think about me, Adora, I’m not a murderer” she said before marching outside the room.

“Wolfa, wait!” She ran after her and managed to grab her arm just outside the room. While Adora was ready to defend from a punch or a kick, because she was sure that she would turn abruptly, snarling, Wolfa simply immobilized and eyed her. Adora let her go and lowered her arms.

“I’m sorry. I didn’t mean…”

Wolfa snorted.

“Don’t lie, you said exactly what you meant.”

Adora sighed. Okay, maybe it was true.

“I’m sorry. I just got that impression.”

Wolfa smirked, but the tiny smile didn’t touch her eyes.

“Better. Look, I get it, okay? You don’t know me yet. But they, even Lonnie, are under my responsibility now, and I would never risk one of my soldiers’ life if it wasn't necessary, not even hers. If I wanted her dead, I would tell her and face her in a fight. I might be ruthless, but I’m not a coward.”

Adora felt stupid for thinking even just for a second that Wolfa could send Lonnie to die instead of killing her in person. How could she? Maybe because Hordak used to send people to die to Beast Island. *Yep.*

“You’re right. I was stupid, Catra always says I’m dumb and she’s right…” she muttered, and Wolfa, incredibly, chuckled.

“She hardly isn’t.”

Adora laughed in turn, doing her best to ignore the jealousy that her tone awakened.

“Yeah. Lately, at least.”

“I HEARD YOU, ADORA!” Catra’s voice came from inside the room.

Adora grinned.

“Why do I keep forgetting about your super-hearing?”

“BECAUSE YOU’RE DUMB!”

Adora laughed, Wolfa did too, softly, then scratched the back of her neck. Adora was about to invite her to go back with her inside the room when the whole building was shaken by a massive yet distant explosion.

Their stares met.

“They’re here” Wolfa said. And then she shouted: “Catra, Azeria, Bow, you three idiots, with me! Hordak, protect the princesses. Everyone else, stay hidden!”

War is a monster (and so are you)

Chapter Notes

TW: violence, killings

Catra ran next to Wolfa, both of them following the noises. Wolfa's heart was beating like a drum, and not only for the adrenaline of the imminent battle. She was alone with Catra, without Adora. Not that it changed anything, but not having the pressure of her jealous stare on her was much better.

They exited the building, heading to the battlefield. The Kadrimans' ship loomed above the Fright Zone, huge and shimmering in its black living metal. Still distant, their tanks and robots shoot continuously.

"Rogelio, idiot, jerk, go there" Wolfa ordered pointing at the spot where many cannons were shooting. She then glanced at Catra and Azeria as the trio left. "Catra, stay behind me. If you get a scratch your sometimes-very-tall-and-magic girlfriend will have my head."

Catra scowled at her.

"I can handle a battle, Wolfa."

"Hey, you made me the Commander, now you follow my orders." It was weird to talk to her like that and she blushed while doing it, but Catra didn't look impressed.

"Ah, shut up! Let's go, we're losing time!"

Wolfa grabbed her wrist, then withdrew her hand like she'd burned her palm. *No touching. Bad idea* .

"Catra, wait! Please, don't put yourself in danger. Please."

Something in the way she said it to her made her fierce expression falter. Catra sighed and nodded, then motioned her to go first. “Thank you” Wolfa murmured before starting to run, her heart beating even faster now. She caught the glimpse of Azeria staring at her with a weird expression on her face, but she didn’t have the time to think about it now. The Kadrimans, the war. *Koli* . That bastard, she would make him pay. From a distance, though.

They reached the squadron that was showering the Kadrimans’ robots with powerful blasts from the tanks. Those black spider-like things were continuously coming from the spaceship, that was hovering in the air, not too high. Wolfa went next to Octavia, who was barking orders to the soldiers that were firing with the tanks.

“Situation?” Wolfa asked.

“We’re fucked, that’s the situation, cub.”

Wolfa gritted her teeth, but forced herself to keep calm. Keeping calm included grabbing Octavia by her armor and forcing her to look in her eyes, showing her her fangs. Octavia looked, to say the least, alarmed.

“I know you never liked me, *Force Captain* , but this is a life and death situation and I don’t have time for your bullshit. How many soldiers have *you* already lost, Force Captain Octavia?” she snarled.

Octavia was pale and her tentacles looked floppy.

“Two, Commander” she answered. Wolfa let her go.

“I’ve always known you’re incompetent. Azeria, take the lead” she said, and as she noticed that Octavia was about to protest, she plowed on: “Give support to the front line, Force Captain.”

Octavia widened her only eye.

“Are you sending me to die?!”

“I’m sending you to fight and protect your soldiers as you should have done since the beginning!” Wolfa shouted. Then she pointed at the soldiers that were fighting with staffs and stun-batons against the alien robots. “Now go there and show me that you’re not the coward I think you are!”

Octavia seemed conflicted (she probably wanted to punch her in the face or snap her neck), but she marched to the forefront anyway.

“Wolfa…” She turned her head and met Azeria’s stare. She looked anxious. “I’ve never led a troop before, maybe it’s better if…”

“You know how to fight an army of robots better than them. Stay here and give the orders” Wolfa told her, her heart rate accelerated. Azeria widened her eyes.

“Where are you going?”

Wolfa sneered.

“I need to borrow a tank.”

Wolfa’s plan, apparently, was to drive a tank (she let her do it, it was still fun) to a decent distance from the only alien close enough (Trali) and shot him from there while staying far enough not to risk their life: the tank was actually driven by a robot and Catra was having a blast driving it through the Horde’s controller.

Wolfa was right next to her, close enough for Catra to feel the warmth spreading from her body, slightly bent over her shoulder to look at the screen that showed what the tank’s camera saw. If Catra wasn’t that concentrated on her task, she would find that proximity a little too much. But she was just having so much fun with that tank.

“Ah ah, you’re dead, alien asshole!” she sneered as Trali became visible. The alien was with his four arms spread, his eyes shut, as if he was praying some asshole alien divinity to move the robots and kill them all. “Bye bye, jerk.” Catra pushed the button that made the tank shoot. Trali snapped his eyes open, looking right in the camera, but too late: the explosion tore his right upper arm apart and Catra, even if a bit nauseated, rejoiced. She shot again, but the Kadriman, even gritting his pointed teeth in the effort and with that bloody stump, jumped high, so damn high, and landed on the tank. The camera stopped functioning.

“Shit!” Wolfa growled. She grabbed her wrist, suddenly so close to her face that it was hard to bring her eyes into focus. Catra blinked, watching her swallow, her dilated pupils drowning in the pale-yellow of her irises, up there. Her firm hold on her wrist was yet delicate, and it tightened, for a moment. Catra could almost hear Wolfa’s heart beating furiously. But hers wasn’t. Not for her.

“Wolfa…”

The commander nodded weakly, panting.

“I know.” She let go of her wrist, stepped back. “I’m sorry.” She cleared her throat, because her voice had become raspy. And then she turned and trotted towards the nearest squadron, and Catra followed her with a sigh.

Idiot. Stupid meathead dumbass. Idiotic jerk with a tail. What the hell was I thinking?!

Wolfa gritted her teeth, going on insulting herself as she approached the closest soldier, who was controlling one of the tanks, checking how it was going just to distract herself and, most importantly, not look at Catra. She could feel her cheeks burning,

her stupid heart was still beating too fast. She was so close… how could she let herself get so close to her? *You brainless fool. Pointless, dumb, daft idiot.*

"Commander" the soldier hailed her. Wolfa nodded towards his controller.

"Don't get distracted. Go on."

He nodded and kept pushing the buttons to make the tank shoot. Koli, she could see him on the camera, was too distant to get hurt. That bastard. She really wanted to kill him… she watched him tear one of their robots apart with his bare hands. She swallowed, remembering how quickly he got rid of her. The feeling of the blade in her guts… she shivered and forced herself to concentrate.

Then the Kadrimans' ship started moving, and it started moving towards them. Wolfa lowered her ears.

"We need to get away from here… SOLDIERS, RETIRE!" she shouted. She grabbed the soldier's controller and tapped furiously on the screen while talking to Catra: "Go away, find a safe place! I got this."

But Catra had found another abandoned controller and she was using it to do the same thing she was doing: bombarding the spaceship with the tanks' cannons.

"I'm not losing all the fun, Wolfa" she grinned while shooting the ship again and again. Wolfa swallowed, narrowing her eyes to see better, but it didn't seem that their blows had damaged an inch of the ship. Or, better, they did, but the kolundrio kept regenerating itself, making their efforts useless.

She let go of the controller and grabbed Catra's arm.

"We need to go."

Catra stared in her eyes and Wolfa lost a heartbeat.

“You would stay if I wasn’t here.”

Wolfa swallowed.

“I… n-no. No, it would be a useless suicide. Please, Catra, I need you to stay alive. Let me protect you, just this once.”

And as Catra nodded, even though with some hesitation in her eyes, they ran away from the forefront, following the squadron. Other squadrons had retreated, and they found themselves surrounded by injured and frightened soldiers. She could see Azeria command her soldiers in the distance while throwing knives at a robot that had broken their defenses. She swallowed back a shiver of worry.

“Their robots are too many, and those aliens are immortal!” Octavia said.

Wolfa glowered at her, anguish cooling her heart.

“Wrong. One of them is already dead, She-Ra killed him, I didn’t see him on the battlefield today. One dead, three to go. Koli lost one eye and Trali one arm.” She looked at the spaceship, heading to the point where they were a few minutes before, probably driven by Siali and following the controller’s signal. Then she let her eyes roam on the battlefield. They were losing. Using the robots wasn’t enough. She swallowed, preparing herself to give the order, freezing inside. She watched many of her soldiers in the eyes and activated the microphone on her chest.

“I know you’re scared, and you’re right. We’re losing, but if we retreat inside the buildings, they’ll slaughter us. There’s only one thing left to do” she said out loud so that everyone could hear her. She really didn’t want to give that order, but there was no other way. She stretched one arm, pointing it at the forefront. “We go back down there and we fight for our lives.” She clenched her fist, her voice more firm. “Those bastards won’t have us, they won’t take our home! If our robots aren’t enough then we will be! It’s just three of them! And three morons can’t defeat us, because we

are Etheria!” she shouted. The soldiers growled their newfound bravery. “Avoid their robots, attack the Kadrimans, all together! Now we fight, warriors, now we win this battle! Are you ready to kick those alien asses?!”

“YES!” the soldiers and officers shouted, even through the badge. Wolfa showed her fangs in a ferocious sneer and howled, and they ran all together towards Koli and Siali as the ship fired their old post, blowing it up.

Wolfa watched them run towards death, sinking in the guilt. She turned and met Catra’s stare.

“Stay here” she told her, but Catra shook her head.

“I’ve never avoided a battle in my entire life, Wolfa, I’m not starting today.”

She couldn’t say she didn’t expect that reply.

“I must go there, Catra. I gave the order.”

“Hordak gave the orders when we conquered Salineas, but he didn’t go on the battlefield.”

Wolfa clenched her jaw.

“I’m not Hordak.”

Catra smirked.

“Neither am I. That’s why we’re going to kick some alien asses today.”

And with that fierce grin on Catra’s face, Wolfa really couldn’t do anything but sneer in turn.

Saying they would kick their asses and actually doing it were two very different things. The spaceship was continuously bombarding them and even if they kept trying to reach the Kadrimans, their horrible robots kept keeping them at distance. Trali was so damn close, they could see him *sweating* , but there were like twenty little, deadly robots between them and him. And they kept regenerating themselves. Catra was slashing the bots like a fury (why did she have to be so damn *gorgeous* when she was fighting?!), claws and fangs and feral growls, and she was doing a great job, really, but it wasn't enough. Wolfa had "borrowed" a cannon from one of their robots and she was now shooting blasts at the alien bots, gritting her teeth in the effort of wielding the big, heavy weapon. She tried aiming at Trali, but he smirked and moved one of his three hands. Ten robots converged on her cannon and dismantled it before she could even realize it, then they attacked her. Wolfa snarled, falling under the sudden and incredible weight of those little bots. They were kind of squishy, but also bloody solid and their "legs" were pointy, sharp, and they were cutting through her armor. She punched and kicked them, harder and faster when she heard Catra let out a shriek, but they were so many and they were starting to wound her.

She didn't want to die, not like this, not knowing that she wasn't even capable of keeping Catra safe. Wolfa howled of pain and desperate rage and used all of her strength to stand up and shake them off of her. A few robots stabbed her legs and torso with their pointy legs, and she growled a yell, grabbed them, ripped them off of her and tore them apart with the pure rage she was feeling. Panting, she realized that Catra had managed to get rid of the robots before her and that she was facing Trali now. Fear froze her heart. Catra was fast and nimble, but damn, Trali was parring every attack and he was smiling as they fought. That same smirk that Koli had given her before stabbing her.

But Catra wasn't alone like she had been.

Wolfa kicked the robot that was running to her and rushed to tackle the alien, and fell on the ground with him. But she was prepared and jumped standing immediately, as Catra took advantage of his fall to jump on him and slash his back. Trali shouted as the deep wounds started bleeding, and Wolfa couldn't hold back a sneer.

"I'm afraid you asked for this, you bastard" she growled before kicking his head, as hard as she could. He let out a weird, brief and high-pitched sound, but he didn't pass out.

"Aaargh!" he shouted while trying to bend his arms enough to grab Catra, but she blocked the closest two arms under her knees and the other against the ground with her weight, pushing. Wolfa met her victorious stare.

"Looks like we have a prisoner."

But then Catra lowered her ears, because Wolfa's eyes were *so cold* , as they'd never been.

"I will show no mercy. Not this time."

For the first time, Wolfa saw a glimpse of fear in Catra's amazing eyes. And she saw her hesitate.

"I'm not asking you to do anything. Leave him to me" Wolfa added, feeling a bit guilty, a horrible person… but that's what she'd always been, right? A merciless soldier. That's what they raised her to become. Well, they'd made a good job.

Catra gulped and lowered her eyes on Trali. He was staying still now, he wasn't even trying to wriggle free from her hold anymore. He was panting, and his grey blood was wetting the ground, flowing like a river from the wounds. Wolfa met his light-blue eyes, full of hate, like the tired smirk he was giving her.

"Go on, little Etherian. Kill me, what are you waiting for? Or you don't have it in you?"

Wolfa swallowed.

“I wish you were right” she murmured. “But I’m just trying to understand how to kill you. Stabbing your chest doesn’t work, so what should I do? Behead you? Burn you alive?” Her cold voice had an effect on both Catra and Trali. Catra widened her eyes, and Trali’s smirk disappeared.

“You’ll pay for this. Koli will make you.”

He looked so sure about it that she believed him. And… she had killed before. But while fighting, never like that, never a helpless victim. She found out that it was kind of hard, even if she hated and feared him, even if he was a threat. He was half dead already, she could just let him bleed out, but that would be just cruel, and a coward choice. She wanted him dead, she should have the guts to kill him. She stepped closer. She knew she had enough strength to pull his head off, but could she live with it?

“Wolfa” Catra said, and she looked in her eyes, drowning in their colors, finding a safe place there. “Trust me, you would regret it. You’re not like that. Don’t do it.”

Wolfa stared at her, confused, not knowing what to do. Trali was too dangerous to keep him alive…

Something flew between her and Catra, who jumped away from Trali, hissing, her tail puffed. Wolfa turned abruptly, meeting a weary, bloody and panting Azeria, who was lovering her right hand. Wolfa blinked, looked at Trali. The hilt with the half-moon was sticking out of his temple. He wasn’t breathing, he wasn’t moving although his eyes were still opened. Wolfa stepped back and stared at Azeria, her eyes wide opened. She couldn’t help but wonder how many Horde soldiers did she kill like that, without thinking twice.

The warrior stared back at her, and there was something so similar to fear in her eyes that it confused her.

“Why?” Wolfa just asked. Azeria seemed somehow comforted by that question.

“He was dangerous” she simply said. Wolfa found herself blushing. Azeria was damn right, and strong enough to do what had to be done. Unlike her, apparently. Azeria came closer and, making her heart stop somehow, cupped her face in her hands. “I’d rather do it myself than let you loathe yourself for doing it in cold blood.” Wolfa widened her eyes. Azeria was too damn close, and they were still fighting a war, there was absolutely no time for that, and what the hell was she saying, and why was she touching her face?! Azeria smirked at her and her heart seemed to escape her ribs. “I like it that you’re still innocent.” And then she left, quick as she came, without giving her the time to tell her that no, she wasn't innocent at all, she was everything but innocent, she’d killed people and she’d done bad things… but Azeria was already far, already fighting again.

“Wow” Catra commented, smirking. “ *That* was definitely *something* .”

Wolfa looked at her, finally. She’d been staring at the far silhouette of Azeria fighting for at least two minutes straight. Catra was almost becoming jealous. Wasn’t she giving all her attention to her? She laughed internally.

“Shut up!” Wolfa growled, blushing. Catra chuckled and decided that, no, she and Wolfa couldn’t be friends and trying to push her towards Azeria would be a huge mistake. Azeria was frightening, by the way. Catra knew that she was an experienced warrior and everything, but seeing her kill Trali like that? It’d been terrifying. She didn’t even hear her approach them. Seriously, if there was someone she feared in their party, that one was Azeria. She definitely wanted her to be by their side.

Catra turned when the umpteenth shot from the spaceship blew way too close to them. She was pretty sure that Koli and Siali knew that Trali was dead, as she was sure that Siali was driving that flying monster. And… oh, it was… what the hell? The spaceship flew over them and lowered above the Fright Zone… it was landing over the buildings!

Adora!

"We need to go there!" Catra shouted before running towards the buildings where she grew up, followed by Wolfa.

The ship's landing was making part of the buildings collapse, so they ran around the old forge to avoid the dangerous corridors. Wolfa was running right next to her. It was really a good thing that she knew that place as much as Catra did.

Running fast as they did, it didn't take long before they reached the spaceship. As it landed upon the laundry's huge block, making its roof collapse, their only chance to reach Siali was to enter the compound. They were about to do it when someone called out Wolfa's name. They both turned to see that Wolfa's three friends were running towards them, wearing their old Horde's armours. It was clear that they'd just joined the fight.

"What the hell are you doing here?" Wolfa immediately said.

"We came as we heard that those aliens were attacking our home" Ophid said. *Home* . They still called it that. She never did. Adora had always been her home, not the Fright Zone.

Catra saw Wolfa lower her ears as the three came closer.

"Bow said you were here" Tauro added.

Kara nodded towards the huge, black spaceship.

"Thought you might need some help with that thing."

Catra looked at Wolfa, who was clearly conflicted.

“Do as I say, and stay safe. They’re dangerous and hard to kill” she finally said, and her friends smiled widely. Ophid cracked his knuckles.

“Ah, finally! I need some action.”

Wolfa clenched her teeth, then glanced at Catra, so she noticed that she looked worried, and a bit shocked.

“Guys” Wolfa said, and met the soldiers’ gazes. “Catra’s safety is the priority.”

Catra was about to protest but Wolfa glowered at her. “Your glowing girlfriend will kill me slowly if you even get a scratch, so shut up.”

Catra was well aware that Wolfa was right, and she also knew that that one wasn’t the real reason why Wolfa wanted to keep her safe. Anyway, protesting would just be a waste of time.

Kara rolled her eyes.

“‘kay, Wolfie.”

Wolfa started to walk inside the building, but Kara sprinted to grab her wrist and stop her. “We missed you, you little piece of shit.”

Catra saw Wolfa struggle to hold back a smile.

“I missed you too, bunch of meatheads. Now stop wasting my time, I have aliens to kill.”

The laundry’s block was full of an acrid smoke that made Catra’s eyes water. She heard Ophid hiss and Kara try to hold back a cough as they walked as silently as they could through the corridors. They couldn’t see or smell much, so they kept moving very cautiously towards the ship, even because those bastards could walk through walls, so they had to keep an eye on every bloody shadow in the smoke, and with the wobbling lights, damaged by the ship’s landing probably, it was unnerving. The

only upside in all of that was that Adora, Scorpia, Perfuma and Sparkles were two blocks away from there, far enough to be safe from the Kadrimans. But they had to kill Siali anyway, while, hopefully, Azeria and the army were taking care of Koli on the battlefield.

“Why the laundry?” Tauro asked in a whisper.

“Well it’s one of the largest blocks” Ophid answered. “And that ship is huge.”

“The training hall is larger” Kara objected. “And not that far.”

“But there are cannons on the roof. They can’t know that they’re so old they don’t work anymore” Catra intervened.

“How would you know?” Kara asked “None was allowed up there.”

Catra turned to give her a smirk.

“Did you guys always do what they told you to do?”

Kara raised her split eyebrow.

“Did you ever?”

Catra held back laughter and went back checking the twirling, grey smoke. Just in time, because Wolfa had stopped and she was about to stumble on her. Her large shoulders were tense, her ears raised and she kept moving them around. Catra did too. There was *something* , indeed. The lowest sound, like… light, cautious steps.

“Ring formation, Catra in the middle” Wolfa whispered quickly, and Catra found herself surrounded by the four of them. She felt weirdly protected, as she’d never felt before with anybody that wasn’t Adora, and it was comforting, confusing, frustrating, humiliating and good at the same time. But protesting would just put them all in danger, so she kept her mouth shut and concentrated on the surroundings. The rumor had stopped. They

stayed there like that, in perfect silence, for so long that she lost the sense of time. Siali was somewhere, waiting for the right moment to stab one of them to death. Because that would happen, since they were stuck in the narrow corridor that led to the laundry. Kara and Ophid were the closest to the walls, the most exposed.

Catra heard Wolfa's low, nervous growl.

"We need to get to the laundry" she said with the faintest whisper, and Wolfa nodded slowly, her ears still raised to catch any sound.

"On three, we run. One, two…"

BOOM!

Catra coughed. The air was hot and smelled like burned metal. She shook her head, blinking in the smoke. *Shit* . She managed to stand up, shook her head. Gah, she hated bombs. When she wasn't the one dropping them, at least.

She saw something moving in the smoke, a dark figure… could be anyone. She looked around. There were concrete shreds everywhere, the wall at her right had been blown up. That's when she realized that Ophid had been buried by the collapsed wall.

"Shit!"

She rushed to take the concrete debris off of him. He moaned, hissing weakly, then looked at her with his red eyes.

"Where are the others?"

"I don't know."

Catra was trying to help him to stand up when a bad, bad feeling made look up, through the hole in the wall. There, Koli was sneering, holding his bloody dagger, and walking to them. Catra gulped. Why was he there? Did he kill Azeria? Oh, she was so proud of herself for ripping off one of his stupid eyes. She would gladly finish the job.

She dragged Ophid as far and as fast as she could, then she grasped a piece of concrete that looked like a pointy stone and she was about to face Koli when Wolfa appeared from the smoke growling and tackled the Kadriman, throwing him away from her.

"Tauro, take Ophid to safety!" Kara yelled a second after, backing up towards them as she was trying to avoid Siali's dagger. Tauro, who was helping her against the Kadriman, grunted while parring a blow with his hooves.

"You can't face him alone!"

Catra flexed her muscles and jumped, using Tauro's shoulders as base to kick Siali's dumb face and make him falter. Kara took advantage of it to shoot him with her stun-baton.

"She's not alone. Go!" Catra said to the bull-boy, who gave her a grateful nod and ran to grab Ophid and carry him on his large shoulders to take him away from there, ignoring his protests.

From that moment on, Catra and Kara fought side by side, kicking and punching the tall invader as fast and as hard as they could. But Siali was a damn good fighter, unfortunately and he kept blocking, parrying and ducking their combined attacks. He even managed to cut Kara on her right arm, and he used her temporary distraction to attack Catra. She jumped and used the wall to push herself behind him, but he turned as if he knew what she was about to do already and punched her mid-air, thrice before she could even touch the ground. He would've gone on if Kara didn't electrocute him from the back, even though the electric shock didn't immobilize him as it should have. Siali turned and gave her

a backhander that threw her on the ground, a couple of metres away from him.

Catra kicked his legs, making him fall, then she jumped upon him and slashed his armed hand with her claws, making him lose his grip on the dagger. She managed to make four deep cuts on his face, making him shout, before that Wolfa was thrown against her. The combination of the commander's weight and the thrust that Koli had provided was enough to push her violently against the wall, away from Siali. As they hit the concrete, Wolfa let out a loud yelp. She immediately rolled away from her and stood up, but she let out another wail and moved all her weight on her left leg. Catra coughed, standing up in turn. She tried to use the badge to call for help, but it wasn't working anymore. And Koli had just helped Siali to stand up again.

"Catra run!" Wolfa said, glancing at her. Her voice was hoarse, her armour was dented, broken, and she was panting. And she looked scared, which sent a shiver through Catra's spine. "Please, run away. Gather the others and protect the princesses. I and Kara will give you some time."

She was asking her to leave them there to die. She could read that sad, resignated awareness in her light-yellow eyes.

Wolfa and Kara didn't stand a chance against Koli and Siali. But, maybe, with her, they could win.

"Nonsense. I'm not counting on *Dumbface Octavia* to defeat these assholes. *We* will end this war *now* ."

Wolfa looked desperate.

"Catra, *please,* I…"

But they didn't have time to say anything else because the Kadrimans attacked again. Koli disappeared through the wall and reappeared right next to Wolfa and kicked her broken leg, making her yell and fall on the ground, and as Kara attacked him with

Siali’s dagger to save the commander Catra had to avoid a shower of punches.

But as he was kicking her and she was busy trying to grab his leg and block another punch, she just didn’t see his fourth hand aim at her jaw.

And then everything became black and silent.

Save your enemy

Chapter Notes

> TRIGGER WARNING: TORTURE, BLOOD, DEATH
> Please don't read this chapter if you find this kind of content disturbing. In the notes at the end of the chapter I'll write a short summary of what happened here.
>
> P.S.: I'm so sorry for taking so long to update!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Go! Run, Kara! Run away!"

Kara gave her one last, anguished glance, then she sprinted towards the corridor. Safe, away from the Kadrimans, who were surrounding them now. Wolfa snarled, showing her fangs, covering Catra with her own body. Koli stopped walking, close, but far enough to be out of her reach.

"Look what we got here" he murmured. Wolfa growled. She tried to stand up but her leg didn’t move. Siali was closer now, and she snapped at him, uselessly. Her heart was racing. They were surrounded, there was no escape. Catra was motionless, she was injured. They were doomed. But she wouldn't go down without fighting. As Siali tried again to come closer she grabbed his ankle and pulled with all her strength, managing to make him lose his balance. Then she pulled again, dragging him closer and used her good leg to push herself upon him and punch his face, one, two, three times, as fast as she could. She was about to jump away when Koli intervened by grabbing her arm and pulling her up with a jolt. She tried to react using that sprint to kick his face, but he parred with one hand and punched her with the other two, rapidly, alternating the blows, and as she parred one he struck with the other, leaving her no other choice but to take the blows. Siali was getting closer to Catra.

"No!" she shouted, growling, and let Koli dislocate her shoulder to kick Siali's legs. But Koli hit her back so hard to make her fall on her knees, breathless. Koli was quick to immobilize her by clenching her wrists and raising her arms behind her back. The shoulder protested, but all she could see was Siali crouching next to Catra, his dagger in his hand again. He looked right in her eyes.

"Nice try, Etherian. But useless, as always." He nodded towards Koli, and she felt a sudden pain on one side of her head, and then it was dark.

"They took them! We need to help them!" Kara drifted on the floor and stopped just before falling against Tauro. Azeria threw one last knife, shutting off a robot, and stared at her.

"What?!" she asked, dread freezing her veins. Kara looked just as terrified.

"I think they… we have to be quick! They’re gonna kill them! Come on!" And she rushed away. Azeria ran and easily surpassed her, heading to the spot where Wolfa and Catra should have been. But there was nothing there but signs of a fight, blood stains and their smell.

"No… no… we... we have to tell Adora, we’re taking them back! Why didn't you stay with them?" she yelled at Kara.

"I couldn’t do anything but get killed! I was unarmed and Catra passed out! We needed help!"

Azeria would stay there yelling at her, but there was no time to lose. She started running again, flashing through the Fright Zone's corridors until she found the room where the princesses' were hiding.

Wolfa blinked, shut her eyes and opened them again. Wherever she was, it was dark, so dark she couldn't see literally anything. She wasn't even sure her eyes were open. All she could tell was that she was tied up to some sort of chair, her arms behind her back, her wrists distant and secured by something metallic. Her head and her left shoulder hurt. Her right leg was a knot of pulsing pain, but she could tell that her ankles were tied, too. She took in a deep breath. Nothing good could come from being tied up to a chair, not in that situation. But that was secondary. What she cared about now was something else. Someone else.

"Catra?"

Silence. She sniffed the air, but she couldn't smell her. She was alone. Her heart started beating faster. Where did they bring Catra? Was she hurt? Was she even alive?

Wolfa pulled and jerked at the chair but it didn't move. It was like trying to move a tank with her bare hands.

Also, that place smelled like Kadrimans and the silence was terrible. All she could hear were her own breaths. She blinked again, or, at least, she thought she did. No, she wouldn't just stay there, she had to do something!

“HEY! WHERE ARE YOU, COWARDS? SHOW YOURSELF, LET’S PUT AN END TO THIS!” she shouted, as loud as she could be. Then she raised her ears, waiting to hear anything. But there was no sound. Not a single one, a step, a voice, nothing.

“IS THAT SO? YOU TIE ME UP AND YOU DON’T EVEN SHOW THE DECENCY TO FACE ME?” she laughed “I ALWAYS KNEW YOU WERE WIMPS, BUT I THOUGHT YOU’D AT LEAST HAD THE BRAVERY TO FACE A TIED UP WOMAN!”

This time, something happened. She had to narrow her eyes in the sudden light, and discovered that she was indeed sitting on a black-metal chair inside a tiny room… that was *changing* . The walls were moving, changing shape, inclination and dimension. It made her sick and she had to close her eyes for a moment. When she opened them again, she was facing Catra, sitting a couple of metres away on a chair just like her and tied up with that same black-metal. Her nose was bleeding and there was a purple bruise on her left cheek. She looked really, really angry, and scared, and now that she was looking at her she seemed even more frightened. Wolfa felt pure rage (and fear) ignite her heart.

“You caught her, too…” Catra murmured, and someone chuckled.

Wolfa turned her head and saw Koli stand there, a bit closer to Catra than to her. Behind him, the spaceship’s walls looked like a weird and ever-changing mass of black-metal.

“Of course. This annoying creature tried to fight us. Poor, little thing.” Wolfa met his sympathetic glance. And gritted her teeth.

“Easy to talk, when your enemy is immobilized. Wimp.”

Some muscles on Koli’s face had a quick contraction.

“Fighting you is not something I’m interested in.”

“What do you want, then?” Catra asked, wagging nervously her tail on her side. Those chairs had a low back, and they didn't have

any holes, so it was actually quite uncomfortable to have a tail at that moment. Wolfa's was bent to her side, too.

"She-Ra."

Wolfa saw Catra clench her jaw.

"Yeah, I got that when you asked me where she is five times. Why do you want her?"

"Why should I tell you?"

"Maybe she can help you. Maybe there's no need to fight."

Koli stayed silent for a moment.

"Oh, I don't think that she would give us her powers willingly."

Catra narrowed her eyes.

"You can't take She-Ra's powers. You're not a First One."

Koli snorted, and started walking between them.

"What do you think She-Ra is?" He didn't wait for Catra's answer. "It's a software the First Ones put inside a living being. They chose someone, a particular kind of person, and made the software recognize only that kind. See, anyone could be She-Ra, without that block. Anyone could use magic." He stopped and he stared at Catra. All Wolfa could see was his back. "We want to evolve, Etherian. We want to use magic. And She-Ra is the key. We collected a lot of datas from our recent samplings, but we need to access the software to crack it. And the software is inside her."

Wolfa heard Catra hiss.

"You want to kill her!"

"I'm afraid there's no other way to access the program. And now, you're gonna tell me where She-Ra is, or I must make you suffer,

Etherian.”

“If you want She-Ra…” Wolfa said, gaining a surprised stare from both of them. She focused on the Kadriman, who had turned to look at her. “...you’d better not hurt Catra. If she gets another scratch, cube or not cube, magic or not, She-Ra will destroy you and your spaceship. Trust me. Or trust what happened to Prime.”

She reciprocated his cold stare for a long moment, letting him read the truth in her eyes. She wouldn’t let him hurt Catra again, no matter what. Koli came closer to her, tall enough to make her neck bend too much to keep looking in his only eye. A dangerous smile curved his black lips.

“Then you, my little, annoying creature, will tell me where She-Ra is.”

Wolfa averted her stare from him, only to look at Catra, behind him. She was looking at her with her (gorgeous) eyes wide open. Wolfa knew what she was thinking. Yes, it would be so easy to just tell Koli where Adora was hiding. She would finally get rid of her. Catra would mourn her but, eventually, she would move on. And, maybe, she would have a chance.

She laughed interiorly. Sure. The truth was that Catra would hate her and probably kill her out of revenge. And, most important, if Adora died she would be unhappy. Plus, she owed Adora a favor. And, actually, she would never forgive herself if she betrayed her, not now, not even if she hated her… but did she, actually? Not anymore, to be honest. Adora was trying to be her friend even knowing her feelings for Catra. And she not as dumb as she thought she was. And she was important. Much more than she could ever be. Moreover, she took an oath, didn’t she?

Wolfa went back looking at Koli.

“In your ass, moron. Stick one hand or two inside and look for her.”

Koli looked surprised, and then angry. Very angry.

“How dare you talk to me like that? I’m a king, and you are nothing!”

So that story was true…

“You’re not my king, though. I serve Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, and She-Ra. And over my dead body will you hurt my people.”

His face tensed with rage, but his voice and demeanor were calm.

“We’ll see about that.”

He stepped closer and punched her right in the face, one, two, three, four times, hard enough to make her almost lose her senses. Wolfa growled and spit blood against him; he was way too tall to hit his face, but it stained his tunic. She saw two of him now, and her thoughts didn’t seem to follow a straight line anymore, but she was still quite happy with the result. Thinking about it was at least a way to ignore the fear and the pain. Her heart was racing again. But she tried to reassure herself: *better me than Catra* .

Koli grabbed her chin and leaned over to look her in the eyes.

“Are you ready to tell me where she is?”

Oh, it would be perfect to spit at him now or, even better, bite his stupid face, but his hand was almost crushing her jaw and she couldn’t do anything but mutter a “fuck you”. His stare became even colder.

“Come on, little thing. I don’t want to break you.”

She let out a nervous laughter. He let her face go and distanced a little bit.

“I’m sure you’re enjoying it.” It was quite hard to speak, honestly. Her face was swelling and every movement hurt. Also, she couldn’t properly open her right eye now.

“You know what?” She met his stare, saw the sneer form on his face. “You’re right.”

And then he was punching her again, but on her stomach also, this time, face, stomach, again, and again, until she was running out of air and he had to stop, or he would kill her. Wolfa coughed blood, her body uselessly trying to curl up, shaking. Someone behind her grasped her hair and forced her to look up at Koli again. She didn’t hear Siali approach.

“Stop it!” Catra shouted, again, probably, because she wasn’t able to listen to anything while he was hitting her. “You won’t get anything by torturing her!”

“I’m sure you’re wrong. She will talk, or you will. Anyway, I will get what I want.”

“Catra” Wolfa managed to say. She met her horrified stare. “It’s okay. Don’t say a word.”

“I… I can’t just watch them do this to you…”

She looked desperate, and somehow it soothed her soul. Catra seemed to really care about her, now. It was enough for her.

She smirked at her.

“I’m fine, kitty. Horde soldier, remember? Pain doesn’t scare me.”

She didn’t have the chance to look in her eyes anymore, because Koli put himself in between and crouched in front of her. Then he wrapped two of his hands around her broken leg, and he squeezed. She tried to hold it back. She really tried. But then her mind went blank and all she could do was scream.

“Where is She-Ra?” he asked while tormenting her wound. He let go enough to make her catch a breath, and she moaned, panting. Another squeeze, another yell. “Where is she?”

Wolfa just stayed silent. She was shaking, sweating, her heart seemed about to explode. She had to keep herself focused, ignoring Catra's furious and desperate protests. Koli nodeed towards Siali. She felt his hands on her tail and she froze. She forced herself to breathe, knowing what was about to happen. *Keep calm. It's just pain.*

Siali bent the end of her tail, hard, fast. The crack echoed in the room, then her wail and scream, Catra's "no!", Koli's question. The pain spread to her whole spine, and she almost passed out. She didn't answer. Siali moved his hands and bent her tail again, slowly this time, until it broke again, and she howled in pain. Koli clasped her face again. She shivered, breathing fast as the feeling of being completely helpless dug into her belly.

She could barely open her eyes, her face was swollen, and she could taste her own blood on her tongue.

"Leave her alone!" Catra was shouting. But all she could see, fogged and unstable, was Koli's cold eye.

"There's no need for you to suffer again. Tell me where she is, and this will end."

A part of her wanted to. If she'd listen to it, she would just let out the sobs she was holding back and tell him where Adora was, because she could feel that her body was screaming at her to make him stop, to save it from all those damages, from all that pain. But that part of her was weak and coward, and she had never listened to it, not even once in her whole life. She smirked, as she could, at least.

"Are you tired yet, wimp?"

Catra was shaking, she couldn't stand what she was witnessing. How long had they been torturing her? One hour? Two? She'd lost the sense of time in that room. If they'd keep beating her like that, they would kill her. Catra's throat was aching for all the times she'd growled and shouted at them, but they were simply ignoring her insults and protests.

Wolfa was covered in her own blood and she was trembling and weeping, she was still screaming, weakly though, but she didn't say anything to those bastards. For a moment, at the beginning, she had really thought she would just deliver Adora to them. What a fool. That girl was clearly ready to die to protect Adora, and now Catra was torn between the need to save Wolfa and the need to keep Adora safe. She kept choosing Adora at every scream and wail Wolfa let out, but it was breaking her into pieces.

All she could do was watch them hurt her. She didn't love Wolfa, but damn, she cared about her, and watching her suffer like that was a torture for her too.

And what was worst, was the awareness that Adora would come and try to save them. She had to stay away, she shouldn't risk her life, but Catra knew that Adora would come to save her. And she would get herself killed.

"How long do you think you can resist?" Koli was saying, holding up Wolfa's chin. She was breathing heavily, her face was almost unrecognisable.

"A-as long as it-t takes…" she whispered. Catra's heart clenched. She knew Wolfa was loyal and, maybe, she was resisting just to hold to her oath, but then again, Koli was questioning *her* at the beginning, not Wolfa, and that idiot had made sure that he gave all his attention to her instead. She should've been the one who was being tortured, not Wolfa. If she was suffering, it was her fault.

Koli slapped her face again, making her head turn with violence. Catra tried again to break the shackles that kept her stuck on that

chair, but that bloody metal was indestructible.

He motioned to Siali, who drew his dagger and handed it to him. Catra widened her eyes.

“No! Don’t you dare, you bitch!”

Koli gave her an amused glance and it made her rage blow. She wriggled and tried again to break the chair itself, uselessly.

Siali grasped Wolfa’s hair again, making her yelp and expose her throat. Catra felt her eyes fill with tears of anger and frustration.

“NO!”

“You can save her.” Koli touched Wolfa’s throat with the tip of the blade, and her breathing became quicker. Catra saw more blooded tears escape her swollen, closed eyes. “You know what I want.”

Catra stared at Wolfa, even if she knew she couldn’t see her.

“D-don’t” Wolfa murmured, her voice weak, hoarse. She coughed blood and Catra’s tears fell on her cheeks, hot and heavy. “I l-lived for n-nothing, I’m happy to die f-for something… someone.”

Catra had to use all her strength to hold back a sob.

“Hold on, it’s gonna be alright…” she managed to say. Koli tilted his head.

“I doubt it” he said. Then he nodded toward Siali, who put his filthy hands around Wolfa’s head, keeping her still. Why…? And then, when Koli grabbed Wolfa’s left ear and stretched it with horrible violence, making her yelp again, she understood. She watched with horror as he put the blade of the dagger against the ear. Wolfa tried to fight Siali’s hold.

“No!” she cried for the first time. Koli was still.

“Then tell me where She-Ra is.”

More tears flowed down her cheeks. Catra watched her clench her jaw. She wouldn't blame her if she'd tell them. She almost hoped she would, at that point.

When Wolfa spoke again, her voice was full of rage, but also of fear.

"Fuck you."

Catra closed her eyes and shivered, her ears pressed against her head as Koli moved further the blade and Wolfa screamed with all her breath. It lasted way longer than it should have, that bastard took his time to make her suffer. Catra was about to vomit. She almost did when she heard a wet sound, and Wolfa's sobs became louder. She opened her eyes again. She had to look away: half of Wolfa's left ear lied on Wolfa's lap, stained with blood.

"Look what you've lost" Koli was saying. He sounded almost bored. "Was it worth it?"

Wolfa didn't answer, this time. She was sobbing uncontrollably, trying to wriggle away from the piece of ear, but she couldn't move.

Koli took it and threw it away, and she calmed down a little bit. She was bleeding a lot, though, and her head was tilted towards the wound. Suddenly, she passed out.

Catra was feeling numb. She'd lost all of her energies. She watched Koli slap Wolfa, again and again until she gasped and gained consciousness again.

"She won't tell you anything" Catra murmured. Koli met her stare. "Stop it, please."

The Kadriman sighed. He went back looking at Wolfa.

"Where is She-Ra?"

Wolfa gazed at him, as her swollen face let her do. She looked dead tired. Catra'd already seen that look on her face, many times, and she felt new tears fall from her eyes because, this time, Wolfa looked sad, not only exhausted. She didn't really want to die, she could see it in her still tensed body, in the tears that kept escaping her eyelids. She knew that look. She'd seen it, that same, exact expression, on Adora's face.

"You're the d-dumbest son of a bitch if you thought I would ever tell you." Wolfa coughed again, glanced at the dagger, then looked at Koli again. "You can't defeat her, trust me. Leave Etheria while you still can."

Koli clenched his jaw.

"I won't ask you again."

Wolfa smirked weakly.

"Good. I'm tired of hearing your stupid voice."

Koli bent over her, looking in her eyes.

"You've been a problem since the very first moment. It's time to get rid of you."

"NO!" Catra shouted, but it was too late. Koli sunk the dagger's blade deep inside Wolfa's chest, slowly. She gasped, her eyes widened a little bit, her mouth opened.

"I've studied your anatomy, you know?" Koli said. "I learned a fun fact: if your lungs are pierced, you die drowning in your own blood. Guess you're going to show me how that works."

He drew back the blade and Wolfa's body collapsed. She started coughing blood, her breaths were short, fast, *wrong* . Catra started sobbing.

"YOU BASTARD! YOU'RE GONNA PAY FOR THIS! I'M GONNA KILL YOU!"

Koli grasped a handful of Wolfa's hair, looked at her agonizing, for a moment, then let her head fall again.

"It's funny how fragile you can be."

"YOU WON'T GET AWAY WITH IT!" Catra continued shouting in tears. Wolfa's breaths were becoming weaker, her body was shaken with convulsions. "No… Don't give up, Wolfa, hold on!"

But Wolfa was gasping for air, she coughed blood again and her body was shaken violently before that she laid still. Catra's sight faltered.

"Hold on…"

BOOM!

The Kadrimans' spaceship tilted as a loud explosion blew off one side of it.

BOOM! BOOM!

Those blows were…

"No no no no… go away, dummy…" she murmured, shutting her eyes, but the tears rolled down her cheeks anyway. Then he felt Koli's closeness, and met his stare.

"You owe me one eye… it's nice that I get to pick a color today. Siali, take off the turquoise one and use her as a shield against She-Ra."

Koli moved to grab the cube and Siali was holding two daggers now. He smirked at her, walking towards her. Her heart slowed its rate, then beated faster.

"Looks like you'll be my first kill here" he said. Catra hissed, tried to wriggle free from that chair once again, hurting herself uselessly. Siali was right before her now and he pointed his

dagger at her. “Your friends are going to find two little surprises here…”

Chapter End Notes

Catra and Wolfa get captured by Koli and Siali. The Kadrimans brutally torture Wolfa to get informations about She-Ra's location, but Wolfa doesn't tell them anything and Koli stabs her to the chest when he understands that She-Ra and the others are coming to rescue them.

Thick skin

Chapter Notes

TW: blood, violence, death, PTS

Hordak made the tank turn and shot again, making another big hole in the Kadrimans' ship, away from the four heat sources he could see on the screen. Entrapta's device was working, because the kolundrio didn't reform.

"That's enough, let's go!" She-Ra shouted, and then she jumped inside the ship followed by Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, Azeria, Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle, Kara, Tauro and Ophid. He jumped off the tank and ran after them, turning on the cannon around his right arm.

The spaceship was entirely made of kolundrio, with wild angles and spiked parts everywhere. She-Ra was the light that guided them through that dark place without hesitation. He glanced at the trackpad. The room where they were keeping Wolfa and Catra was right there. Behind a solid wall of kolundrio. He stepped further, next to She-Ra, who nodded at him, fierce determination in her luminous eyes. He pointed the cannon at the wall, making sure that none was behind it, and shot. The kickback was strong: he had enhanced his weapon to make sure that it was powerful enough to kill those bastards. The wall was blown away with a stinging smell of burned metal, and they all entered the room.

There was no time to think.

Both Catra and Wolfa were tied up to large chairs made of kolundrio. Wolfa was… Hordak growled and aimed his cannon at Koli, who was activating the cube. *Not this time* . Hordak shot and hit his arm, destroying it together with the cube. The Kadriman screamed and had to defend himself from Azeria, Kara, Ophid and Tauro's combined attack. Hordak turned to see that She-Ra was sword-fighting Siali with Scorpia's help, and Siali was defending himself using two daggers. Glimmer was touching Catra's

shoulder, and she teleported her a few steps away, finally free from the chair. She showed some bruises and there was dry blood under her nose, but beyond that, she seemed to be just fine.

Wolfa, on the other hand…

Hordak made sure that his soldi… *friends* were enough to face Koli and Siali. Koli had just fallen down, Azeria was stabbing him and Kara was using her stun-baton on him while Ophid was impaling him with his staff, and Siali was just being cut in half by She-Ra, so he ran to Wolfa.

She couldn't be dead. Not her, not his Wolfa.

Glimmer appeared next to her before him and covered her mouth with her hand. He gasped too, seeing what they did to her.

"Adora!"

Adora turned and met Catra's eyes. She shivered watching the bruises and the blood on her face. Had they arrived one second later, Siali, who now laid dead, split in two halves on the black floor, would have killed her. She had stopped him just in time. She ran next to her and lowered her gaze on Wolfa's motionless body. They were all gathering around her.

Adora gasped, shocked, horrified. She kneeled next to Wolfa.

"Maybe you can save her" Catra murmured, hugging herself and with her voice shook by the horror to see that broken body. Adora wondered what she'd had to witness, and hate burned again in her chest. "She did it for us" Catra sobbed, covering her mouth then. Adora glanced at her, shocked. Wolfa got herself tortured to

death *willingly* ?! *To save Catra* , she guessed. *And they wanted me* .

She focused on Wolfa again, noticing the missing half of her left ear. Adora gagged back a puke, closed her eyes to concentrate as she put her hands delicately over Wolfa's body. She let go of the hate, she didn't need it now. What she needed was love. Gratefulness. Will.

She felt the power flow from and through her, and heal every damage (there were so many…). It left her exhausted, and as Wolfa's body was cured, she switched back to her normal form, panting and weeping. She gazed at Catra, who was staring at Wolfa expectantly, like everybody else. She dragged her closer and hugged her tight.

"I'm sorry" Adora whispered. She held back a sob as Catra hugged her in turn. "It's my fault…"

She felt her shake her head and caress her back, but she was trembling.

"It's their fault, not yours" Catra said in a whisper drenched with hate. Adora distanced to look in her eyes, and Catra looked angry, sad and resigned at the same time.

"Wake up…"

Adora turned. Azeria was kneeled at her side, caressing Wolfa's face and weeping. She sniffed and whispered again. "Come on, Wolfa, you can do it. You're stronger than them!" Her voice shattered. Wolfa was pale and motionless. She wasn't breathing. Azeria put her hand on her chest and started pushing, again and again. "Breathe! Come on!"

Adora shivered, feeling cold. She lowered her gaze as Azeria continued trying to reanimate her. Catra wrapped herself in her arms, letting out only muffled sobs, and she held her tight.

Adora glanced at Azeria again, she was now trying mouth-to-mouth. She then straightened her back and pushed against Wolfa's chest again.

"Come on!" she almost shouted. "You can't let them win! Don't give up, please, don't give up!"

Wolfa coughed and curled up, coughing again and trembling. Her tail was curled between her legs and she was panting, ears flat.

Adora gasped, unbelieving. She did it! She was alive! She found herself smiling and glanced at Catra who was still too shocked to cheer like the others were doing. Azeria was now sobbing and smiling at the same time, Glimmer was hugging Bow, and Tauro, Kara and Ophid were hugging each other. Lonnie let out a sigh of relief and leaned her head against Rogelio's shoulder, who was roaring something cheerfully and high-fiving Kyle. She crossed Hordak's relieved gaze, and smirked at him. He nodded at her, giving her a grateful stare as he put his open hand on his chest, over his heart. Adora blushed slightly, because Hordak saying "thank you" was weird and totally unexpected, but still she grinned at him and focused again on Wolfa. Her heart clenched again, now that she could think properly about what she'd endured to keep her and Catra safe. She felt so touched, so full of gratefulness that she felt the need to hug her. But… Azeria was just stretching her hand to touch her shoulder and, as she did, Wolfa snarled and curled up even more.

Everyone silenced.

She was still panting, still shaking. And weeping, Adora realized, and her right arm was wrapped around her chest and her left fist was clenched and pressed against her ear. It was still cut, even if it was a scar now, not a wound. Even She-Ra's healing power had their limits, apparently.

Catra laid down in front of Wolfa, curling up in turn, leaning her face on her own bent arm and evidently trying to make her look at her, but she didn't try to touch her.

“I know it still hurts, but it’s going to pass” she murmured, her voice so soft that it brought tears to Adora’s eyes. “Just breathe. You’re okay now. You’re safe, they’re dead.” Wolfa’s breaths slowed down a bit. “We’re here with you, don’t worry. It’s over.”

It took some time for Wolfa to calm down completely. It was clear that she could still feel the ghost of the pain, but her breathing was almost normal now and she opened her eyes and tried to sit up, but she grunted and pressed her hand on her chest.

“Easy” Catra said. Wolfa looked at her, her eyes wide open. Her huge and pitch-black pupils made her stare look weird.

“Are you okay? What happened?”

Catra chuckled with incredulity.

“Me?! You’re the one who got…” her voice faded, as her smile. Adora saw her become paler and she gently squeezed her shoulder. Catra glanced at her, smirking tensely.

Adora met Wolfa’s distressed stare.

“Thank you” she murmured, and Wolfa blushed a bit and averted her gaze.

“I owed you” she muttered, shrugging. “And now I owe you another one, I guess.”

Adora smirked.

“Not really. I mean, I might have healed you, but it was Azeria who literally breathed you back to life.”

Wolfa widened her eyes, gasping.

“She did *what* ?!” Then she turned, her cheeks red, and Azeria blushed in turn. Adora sneered and gained a nudge from Glimmer.

“I’m sorry, you weren’t breathing and…” Azeria began, but then she ran out of words, apparently. They just stared at each other for a while, then Kara snorted.

“Oh come on, Wolfie, I know that look. Just kiss her already.”

Azeria widened her eyes. Adora didn’t think that Wolfa’s face could become redder than that, but it did.

“Are you out of your mind?!” Wolfa shouted, then she stood up and faltered, but Kara held her, scowling at her at the same time as everyone else was standing up in turn, Adora included.

She helped Catra, who sighed and looked at her. Then she moved to kiss her, surprising her.

“I’m tired of being saved by you” Catra muttered, and Adora giggled.

“If you keep getting yourself kidnapped by scary, tall aliens…”

Catra slapped her arm.

“It’s not my fault!”

Adora’s smile widened.

“My *cute* damsel in distress…”

Catra hissed and pushed her away with a kick.

“Gah! Sometimes I wonder why I want to marry you…”

Adora was about to burst into laughter for her predictable reaction, but then she realized what Catra had just said. And Catra did, too, because they stared at each other, their eyes wide-open with surprise and incredulity.

Glimmer cleared her throat, a smile on her face, her eyes sparkling with amusement.

“I hate to interrupt, but we should really go back home now. And set fire to this ship, just in case…”

Catra looked at her immediately.

“Can I blow it up?” Her eyes were shimmering with anticipation, and Glimmer laughed.

Adora was still lost in that thought. Catra wanted to marry her. Like a real couple. She wanted to make it official. She wanted to have children with her (that song kept echoing in her mind). It was terrifying and beautiful and amazing and exciting and… possible. Their future, the one she’d dreamed of, was right there in front of them. And they could have it.

“Yes!” she said abruptly, feeling tears in her eyes.

“Actually, I think that…” Bow was saying, but then he shut up seeing her expression, her stare fixed on Catra, who looked a bit confused now, one ear up and the other one lowered.

“Yes” Adora repeated. “I want to marry you.”

Catra raised both her ears now, then lowered them as her gaze became soft, glassy, surprised.

“Really?” she murmured and, when Adora smiled letting those tears of joy run down her cheeks and nodded, she smiled in turn and jumped on her, kissing her as Adora held her tight.

Wolfa leaned on Kara, feeling a weight on her cut ear. She wasn't brave enough to touch it, but she could tell that half of it was still missing. Apparently, She-Ra couldn't regrow amputated parts of the body.

She watched them kiss, and their friends rejoice. It still hurt, but she couldn’t hold back a tiny smirk on her face.

"Are you kidding me? Now you're okay with this?" Kara scowled her. Wolfa glanced at her and smirked weakly. She was exhausted, she really needed some rest. She nudged at her anyway.

"Don't be jealous. We work much better as friends than as lovers."

Kara rolled her eyes.

"I swear, sometimes you're so annoying I just want to choke you…"

Wolfa chuckled and averted her gaze, meeting Azeria's, but the warrior blushed and looked away. Wolfa sighed. She didn't have the strength to face her now.

She felt a pressure behind her nape and turned, realizing that Hordak was staring at her while standing next to Scorpia, who was smiling wildly and wiping tears from her eyes while looking at Catra and Adora. Queen Scorpia. It was simply ridiculous. And yet… maybe she could give her a chance. She'd spent an embarrassing amount of time with Catra, and she had a crush on her, so what? They shared that pain, at least. It was something they could talk about sharing a drink.

She wanted to be part of that group, really, this time. She couldn't get over Hordak's lies, not yet at least, but everyone else had just been nice to her, so there was no need to push them away. She wanted to learn to smile like Catra and Adora were smiling. Actually, all she'd ever wanted was to be happy, to be accepted, to be loved, and that's exactly what those jerks were doing.

Her eyes fell on Azeria again, and she looked surprised.

Wolfa smirked at her, blushing a little bit. Azeria widened her eyes with incredulity, then she literally saw them fill with tears and she had to face the wildest smile she'd ever seen. Wolfa blushed, her

heart accelerated. Okay, maybe they could just try to hang out, someday? Take it slow?

Tauro bumped gently his right hoof against her shoulder.

"Hey boss, can you walk?"

Wolfa gave Azeria one last glance and looked at him.

"Sure. I’m just slow."

Ophid sneered. He seemed to be just fine, now. Thanks to She-Ra, for sure.

"That ain’t new, girl!"

Wolfa glared at him and tried to pull his hair, but he ducked laughing. Then he backed away and stuck out his forked tongue. Wolfa couldn't help but laugh softly.

"Jerk!"

"Bitch."

She widened her eyes in fake shock, gasping.

"You, lurid snake! You'll regret this!"

He raised one eyebrow.

"No, if you can't catch me!"

And then he ran away, fast and laughing. She wanted to, but as her eyes followed him, they also focused on the chair where Catra had been tied up, and her smile disappeared, leaving its place to a small gasp and a missed heartbeat. She had to lean more on Kara, who looked up at her with worry on her face.

"Wolfie…"

"I'm fine I j-just… I need t-to get out of here…" she managed to say, her mutilated ear pulsing painfully and flashes of what she'd been through flashing in her mind. She couldn't walk anymore. She barely noticed Hordak was approaching, but she heard his voice and the memories slowed down a little, letting her stare focus on him.

"Wolfa… I can carry you, if you let me" he said in a low voice that reverberated in her chest. She felt her eyes fill with tears. She knew what she wanted, but she also knew she didn't trust him anymore. He had betrayed her. He had lied to her. He had used her faith in him, her love for him for his purposes.

"S-stay away from me!" she snarled, and she hated how weak and desperate her voice sounded but still, she could barely breathe in that moment. More flashbacks came to torment her, and she started panting. Glimmer came closer as Tauro aimed his horns at Hordak, forcing him to back away.

"I'll take you to Bright Moon, okay? You need some rest" she said softly, and all she could do was nod and give her a grateful stare.

Elastic hearts

Glimmer drew back her hand as they appeared in the castle. She doubted that Wolfa wanted any physical contact right now.

Wolfa looked around, and she seemed lost. The guards' barracks were all empty and the room looked enormous and cold.

"O-okay… I'm fine now. Thanks."

Glimmer would never get used to the vulnerability in her voice. Wolfa was hugging herself, her tail between her legs and her ears lowered. Actually, she wanted to hug her, and maybe Wolfa did need a hug, but still she was convinced that touching her without her permission would be a huge mistake, even if her intentions were good.

Wolfa sat on her bed, and Glimmer had the chance to notice that she had decorated it already. There was a picture on the wall behind it, the one that showed all the Horde's cadets, and a 'W' roughly carved into the headboard with a knife, probably. She imagined her doing it out of boredness, and she smirked.

She sat next to her, and Wolfa didn't seem too uncomfortable with it.

"How are you feeling?" she tried to ask. She kind of knew what torture brought, all the time that needed to heal completely, if that ever happened, so she knew that it was way too soon to even hope for her to get through that, but she couldn't find another way to start a conversation with her.

Wolfa shrugged, keeping her stare on the floor.

"I told you, I'm fine." Yeah, sure. Her head was still slightly tilted to the left.

"Okay. But if you want to talk about it…"

Wolfa looked at her, she seemed surprised.

“Why would I ever want to talk about it?!”

Right. Horde guy.

“I know they taught you to hide it when you’re not okay,” she tried again, remembering what Adora told her about hiding being the best thing to not show weakness, “but it’s not a weakness, Wolfa. You went through a lot, and it’s okay if you want to cry, rant, talk, or just eat tons of ice cream.” Wolfa looked more and more horrified by her words.

“T-there nothing to talk about.” Wolfa shivered and looked away. “They won, I lost.”

Glimmer widened her eyes.

“Lost?! You’re alive! You resisted, you saved Adora and Catra!”

Wolfa shrugged again.

“All I did was get me and Catra caught and barely manage to take some time.” Now her voice was harsh, full of contempt, and Glimmer realized that it was for Wolfa herself. “I didn’t save Adora, she came and killed them by herself. Or you did. Anyway, she didn’t need protection at all.”

Glimmer stared at her, speechless, for a few seconds, starting to realize something.

“It wasn’t useless, Wolfa” she said softly, and Wolfa looked at her with such a tensed expression on her face that she felt her stomach crunch. She spoke slowly, giving her the time to absorb her words. “If you told them where we were hiding, they would’ve bombarded us and killed us. The only reason why we survived is because you gave Entrapta the time to finish the device that… *disturbed* the kolundrio and stopped it from reforming, and that’s why we managed to break into the ship without having to deal with their robots and take them off-guard. If you didn’t resist,

we'd be dead. You didn't save only Adora and Catra, you saved us all."

Wolfa didn't look completely convinced, but the regret and rage in her eyes were fading away slowly.

"You're wrong, Glimmer" she murmured, and suddenly she looked very, very tired. "I failed. I didn't protect Catra, I let them take her prisoner, and she saw everything they…" Wolfa's voice weakened and Glimmer felt a shiver run down her spine and the feeling of having a cold stone in her stomach. "I couldn't save anyone. Not even myself."

"Wolfa, please, listen to me" she tried to say, but Wolfa averted her gaze.

"I did. I just don't agree with you" she whispered, and she could hear the tears in her voice.

Maybe it was just too soon to talk to her.

"You're just tired now. Get some rest, tomorrow will be better" Glimmer forced herself to say. She hoped she was right, because Wolfa looked sadder than ever. The former Horde soldier nodded weakly, but her eyes were filled with tears.

"I know what you're thinking, Glimmer." Their stares met again, and Glimmer swallowed back the surprise those words awakened, because she thought Wolfa wanted to end that conversation, and instead… "And you're right. I hate my whole life, now." Wolfa's voice broke and Glimmer widened her eyes. Yes, she guessed she could feel something like that considering what had happened since Bow's birthday, but the tears that rushed down Wolfa's cheeks were completely unexpected, mostly because she looked so fragile in that moment that all she wanted to do is hug her tight. "It was useless, worthless, *I* was worthless. I lived for Hordak, for Catra, for the Horde, and I never really had them. I lived for nothing. I thought that dying to save someone, someone like Adora, could be… *something* ." Glimmer could just listen to

her, unable to think, let alone reply to her. It was just too much, too many horrible thoughts turned into words. "I wouldn't be totally useless. In the end, I was useful." An empty smile tightened her lips. "But then she proved me wrong. Again. Like when I thought that she didn't care about Catra, she proved me wrong. When I thought Catra hated her, they both proved me wrong. When I thought she hated me at last, she proved me wrong." Wolfa was basically sobbing, and Glimmer was too astounded to react. She really didn't expect her to give her a… what was it? A confession? A rant? A cry for help? Wolfa let out a bitter, harsh laughter, weeping. "That's what I learnt. I am always wrong. I thought it was finally over and…" Her voice faded away as she pointed at herself, shrugging and biting her lower lip in the effort to hold back the sobs. "Guess I wasn't born to be a hero like her."

"Wolfa, you can't…"

"But it's okay, you know? It's okay. Dying gives you a weird perspective of your future." Wolfa looked at her and Glimmer shut her mouth, because her stare was different now. She was still sad, but also determined. "I don't want to be useless anymore. I don't want to live for something that doesn't even exist anymore. I don't want to live for people who don't love me back like I love them." Love, she was talking about love now. Okay, it was weird to hear that word come from her mouth. Not that she didn't feel love, it was obvious that she did, but she didn't think she would ever hear her say it out loud like that. It was confusing. But probably Wolfa was hella confused at the moment, so Glimmer simply tried to keep up with her. "I died, but I'm alive now and I don't want to waste my second chance." Her voice was stronger now, and her eyes were lit with a passionate and cheery light that looked totally inappropriate, considering the tears that still wetted her face and the breakdown she almost had a second before. "So if you're wondering about how bad I feel knowing that Catra will marry Adora, and not me, well, I do feel like shit, but, hey, she doesn't love me. And I would never marry someone who doesn't love me back, so, you know what?" Wolfa shut up long enough to make her think she actually wanted an answer.

“What?” Glimmer asked, cautious.

And Wolfa smiled.

“Fuck Catra.” Glimmer almost choked. “I love her, I’ll always do, but I can’t live like that anymore. I can’t go on like that, or I’ll end up killing myself somehow, like I tried to do fighting She-Ra. And I realized I don’t want to die… again” she added. “I need to be myself, not a soldier. I want what you have, Glimmer, what all of you have. I want a real life.” Her eyes became glassy again. “I was raised to be a soldier. Teach me how to be a decent person. Please.”

Glimmer was overwhelmed. She gasped, finding it hard to reply to her.

“B-but you are a decent person, Wolfa! Everything you said proves it! I can’t… I can’t believe you’re so… You kept all of this hidden inside of you all of this time?”

Wolfa frowned.

“You thought I was just a jealous bitch?”
“No! I mean… maybe, sometimes? Sorry, but…” Glimmer grinned and Wolfa chuckled.

“It’s okay. That is exactly what I meant! How do I become a normal person? I don’t want to hide my feelings anymore, it sucks! It only makes it worse! And I don’t want to be an asshole, just to clarify.”

Glimmer laughed, unbelieving.

“Well, you could start with Azeria? She, you know…”

Wolfa blushed and looked away, but she was smiling.

“I-I know.” She rubbed her face then with a sigh. “I’m a mess…”

Glimmer decided that, maybe, Wolfa could handle a hand on her shoulder. The girl tensed a bit, but then she relaxed and Glimmer smiled, relieved.

“Nah, these things take time and…”

Wolfa gave her a skeptical stare.

“I was a jerk to her.”

Glimmer couldn’t really deny it.

“Well, she threw a knife to you.”

Wolfa laughed, a throaty, hoarse laughter that made her smile.

“Yeah…” Wolfa then clearly held back a yawn. She kind of looked exhausted, actually, so Glimmer stood up.

“Take a nap. Whatever you need, you just have to ask, okay?”

Wolfa raised her eyes on her. She looked calm now, or maybe she was just too tired to feel anything.

“Okay.”

Glimmer smirked at her and then disappeared leaving behind her just some sparkles. Wolfa’s eyes were closing as if they had their own will, but there was yet one thing she had to do.

She stood up and walked to the bathrooms. Keeping her stare low, she reached the basin and grasped it. She took in a deep breath.

One.

Two.

Three.

She looked in the mirror.

She blinked, feeling as if the air was being pulled out from her lungs.

She looked terrible, paler than the usual and with dark circles around her eyes, and her hair was a mess. And a piece of her was missing. Her vision trembled and became confused. New tears sprung from her eyes. She touched the mirror, there where the other half of her right ear should have been. And suddenly she was assaulted by the memories of Koli cutting it as Siali kept her still. The pain, the terror, the absolute helplessness she'd felt…

She crumbled to the cold floor, curled up, covering her head with her hands and so touching the absence on her ear, shaking and sobbing while that devastating remembrance kept repeating in her mind.

"I can't believe they're going to get married!" Bow shouted even if he was trying to whisper, and Catra turned to glower at him as they walked the Fright Zone's corridors, or what was left of them.

“What will I wear? I only have one dress, and it’s black!” Scorpia panicked. Perfuma looked at her.

“Relax” she smiled, “we will wear matching dresses. And they won’t be black.”

“I will wear a suit” Catra said, and Adora snorted.

“Obviously.”

“And you’re not allowed to marry me like She-Ra, just so that you know it. Even if your hair is better that way.”

Adora widened her eyes and stopped walking, so Bow stumbled on her. Not that she noticed. She seemed about to say something, and Catra looked confident about her next reply, but then Adora closed her mouth and gave her a smug sneer.

“You like She-Ra, don’t you?”

Catra lowered her ears and wagged her tail with sharp movements.

“I never said that!”

Adora’s smile widened.

“But you do.”

“I don’t! You’re definitely too tall and… blonde!”

Adora laughed, then she started crooning: “Catra likes She-Ra! Catra likes She-Ra!”

“Gaaah!” Catra hissed distancing from her while Bow, Glimmer and everyone else laughed. “Shut up! The only good thing is your new tiara!”

Adora froze, then her eyes shimmered.

“You noticed it?”

“Yeah but, I mean, it’s clear that the heart on your chest is more visible, so it’s more important” Bow intervened, gaining a glare from Catra.

“Really? Because if you get hit on your head, you die, but if you get hit on your chest, you might survive. I can show you.”

“Is there a rank? You put me on your feet, Adora, what does that say about me?” Glimmer said. Adora stepped back.

“Relax guys! There isn’t a rank! Catra kept saying that my tiara was stupid, so it was just natural to… you know, wear hers instead, together with Mara’s, and, Bow, you wear a heart on your chest every day, I just copied it, and Glimmer, you’re on my feet because that symbolized the fact that you can fly, basically, or you soon will anyway - did you notice that your wings are growing?”

Glimmer tried to look at her own back.
“Really?”

“Yes, they’re so cute!” Bow smiled. “Still tiny and pink, but a little bit longer.”

Catra was raising one eyebrow.

“I never noticed you had wings, Sparkles.”

“That’s because you need to come to the steam grotto with us!” Bow shouted. Then he turned to look at all of them. “Hey guys, what about a group vacation to Mystacor?”

Catra gasped while everyone else was cheering.

“Mystacor? No, thanks.”

Glimmer wrapped an arm around her shoulders and Catra tensed, scowling at her.

“Forget what you know about Mystacor! You don’t know the best part of that *amazing* place!”

“The hidden chamber where this idiot” she said pointing at Adora “decided to suicide?”

“Hey! I decided that sacrifice was a possibility, not to suicide!”

Catra glanced at her.

“It’s the same thing.”

“No” Glimmer said. “I mean, not that chamber. Trust me, Horde scum, you’ll love it!”

“Guys, I didn’t want to suicide…”

Glimmer laughed.

“We know it, Adora, relax, Catra is just overreacting as usual…”

“What?!” Catra’s tail was puffed and she darted away from Glimmer. “I’m not overreacting! She was not dying in *your* arms, Sparkles!”

“I couldn’t just let the Heart destroy Etheria, Catra, we’ve talked about this already.”

Catra snorted, arms crossed on her chest.

“Of course not, because She-Ra always has to be at the forefront and save everyone, even if there’s an alien that can stop her magic with a stupid cube!”

“Is this what this is about?" Adora asked, surprised.

"Yes!" Catra shouted. But her eyes were glimmering with tears. "You knew I didn't want you to come and save me! You must stop risking your life for me!"

Adora looked to be out of words.

"Catra, I… can't" she murmured. "I love you. I will never leave you behind."

Catra sighed, her voice softened.

“I know” she said, lowering her stare and her shoulders. “Guess I’m just…” she sighed and glanced at the group: everyone was staring at her, and everyone looked away pretending they weren’t. Idiots. She looked back at Adora. “I can’t stop thinking about…” a knot in her throat stopped her from finishing that sentence. The brutality she had witnessed was like a burning behind her eyes.

Adora widened her eyes, then she just grabbed her and dragged her between her arms, hugging her tight and sinking her fingers in her hair. Catra sunk her face in her neck, breathing in her scent, clinging to her new jacket, and forgot everything else.

Scorpia glanced at Perfuma, who nodded towards the corridor. They all walked silently past the couple, leaving them some space. As they were far enough for at least Adora not being able to hear her, Scorpia bent towards Perfuma.

“I think that they both need your meditation sessions, anyway. Maybe you could try to ask Wolfa, too?”

Perfuma smiled, but she looked tense, somehow.

“Wolfa? Ah ah, yeah, the same Wolfa that hates you and is mean to you?”

Scorpia frowned.

“Do you know another one?”

Perfuma sighed and put her arm around her right pincer.

“Why do you care so much about her? You know that I’m totally in when it’s about forgiveness and healing paths, but she was never your friend, Scorpia. She calls you ‘crab’...”

“I know, but… I don’t know! I can’t explain it, I just feel that she doesn’t really want to hurt me. She wasn’t always like that, you know? We actually were friends, when we were children, we were assigned to the same team! Then she found out I was a princess and she kicked me out, but before that…” Scorpia gazed down. “We were really good friends. And I just can’t forget those years.”

When she looked at Perfuma again, she was staring at her with so much love in her eyes that she gasped.

“You have the purest soul and the biggest heart, Scorpia, and I’m the luckiest princess ever.”

Scorpia felt her eyes fill with tears as her unbelieving heart drank those words. Perfuma caressed her cheeks and reached for a soft kiss.

“I’ll talk to her” she then said. “Don’t worry, we’ll fix everything and she’ll realize how stupid she was to push you away.”

“I think you’re wrong” Scorpia said, and Perfuma frowned, confused. Scorpia smiled at her. “You're not the luckiest princess ever. I am.”

After all, a group vacation was what they actually needed, so eventually everyone accepted to spend three days in Mystacor with their only mission being some well deserved relaxation.

They went back to Bright Moon, all together, even Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle, as Mystacor was closer from there. Wolfa'd been there alone all day long, and Azeria was so worried that her tail was huge and she couldn't stand still, despite the Queen's reassurances.

"Azeria, she looked really tired, she probably just slept all day. Relax."

"But what if she needed something?"

Glimmer sighed.

"She just slept, trust me. And she can take care of herself, in case you didn't notice."

"I know very well, Your Majesty…"

"Oh come on, you're not on duty, just call me Glimmer!"

"Okay, *Glimmer* , but one thing is taking care of yourself when you're just traumatized by your childhood and your heart is breaking, and one thing is taking care of yourself when you're traumatized by your childhood, you heart is shattered and you've been tortured to death and mutilated!" she whispered talking fast as they were climbing down the skiffs they used to go back home.

Glimmer stared at her, blinking.

"I talked to her, Azeria. Trust me, she's stronger than you think." A weird smirk curved the Queen's lips, like if she knew something new, a secret. "You'll see it by yourself."

Azeria followed her and Bow inside the castle with a strange feeling in her guts, with Adora and Catra at her side. It still smelled like blood and burned metal. Even from there, the damages were evident. She sighed.

“It’s going to take a while to rebuild everything” Bow said, mirroring her thoughts. Adora stepped next to him, wrapping his waist and leaning her head on his shoulder.

“Not with She-Ra. And Entrapta’s robots.”

Azeria watched Glimmer hug Bow from the opposite side.

“It’s gonna be a cakewalk.”

Azeria crossed Catra’s gaze, and she didn’t look as positive as the others.

“Go find her” Catra told her in a low voice. “You’re right, she shouldn’t be alone.”

Azeria nodded, her heart in her throat. She made one step towards the barracks and she froze, sniffing the air.

“Whoa, what’s this smell?!” Bow asked.

“Did you guys leave a corpse somewhere?” Lonnie spat. “Something’s rotting.”

Azeria turned to face the entrance with a wry smile on her face.

“Ehm, guys, it’s better if you…”

“Like, really, it’s awful!” Kyle exclaimed. “It’s like that time when I forgot the wet uniforms in the basket for a week…”

Azeria shared an amused glance with Catra, who was looking at the entrance in turn.

“Seriously, Kyle?” Lonnie looked at him. “It wasn’t just one time, you did it at least five times!”

Wolfa cleared her throat, and they all gave a start and realized she was there. Oh, yeah, her fur and hair smelled like ten wet dogs, but the sea’s water still wetted her hair that was now shiny and pulled back, showing her face and falling in soft waves

around her neck. Her head was tilted to the right and her ears were lowered, but she was slowly wagging her long tail and there was the hint of a cocky smile on her face that made Azeria's body *burn* . Also because she was wearing nothing more than her uniform trousers and the bands around her chest, so her abs and muscled arms were right there in front of her.

"I saw the skiffs from the beach" she said. "I thought I might welcome you back home with my personal flavour. It's called 'don't wash the wolf'."

There was an entire second of astonished silence, then they all burst into a surprised and amused laughter, and Wolfa smiled widely, and that was the most beautiful thing she'd ever seen.

"You're not coming with us to the steam grotto!" Glimmer said.

Wolfa cocked one eyebrow.

"What's that?"

"A very wet place" Bow explained. "With a lot of steam and pools."

"Oh, well, guess you'll have to bring some nose pincers then."

"Pools?! Sparkles, what made you think that I would ever like a place like that?" Catra spat. Glimmer shrugged.

"The water is warm and it's really relaxing!"

"It definitely is" Adora said looking at her fiancee. "I fell asleep on Glimmer the first time."

Catra's tail puffed.

"You did *what* ?!"

Both Adora and Glimmer laughed.

"Oh come on, Catra! Don't be dramatic!"

“Are you jealous?” Adora laughed.

Catra looked so upset it was funny.

“I’m not jealous. I just don’t like water.”

Adora laughed harder.

“Oh, come on! Me and Glimmer are like sisters!” she said putting her arm around the Queen’s shoulders, who smiled and looked up at her.

“Do you really think that?”

Adora gazed at her.

“Sure.”

Glimmer’s eyes… well, they *literally* sparkled.

“I’ve always wanted a sister!”

Catra snorted.

“That’s because you never shared your bed chamber and literally every moment of your life with at least twenty people.”

“Agreed. And siblings suck, anyway” Wolfa grumbled. When they all looked at her, she shrugged. “Mine, at least.”

“Mine are awesome!” Bow said.

Glimmer smiled.

“And it’s about time that you introduce them to us, Bow.”

“Yeah! I mean, maybe? They’re always so busy, I don’t know if they can come here.”

“We will go to them, then” the Queen said. “But now, Wolfa, *please* , go to dry your hair! I don’t know how long I can stand

this… odour.”

Wolfa’s hoarse, throaty laughter made Azeria shiver.

“It’s stench, Your Majesty, call it by its name. You know I like the truth” she said while walking away. Azeria caught Adora staring confusedly at Wolfa’s fur, as if she didn’t expect her back to be partially covered with those surely soft, thick, white and grey hairs. Maybe Catra’s wasn’t. “Welcome back to Bright Moon, anyway. Not you, Lonnie.”

Azeria turned her head to look at the former-soldier in question, who sighed and rolled her eyes.

“Bitch!”

“Scumbag!”

Lonnie widened her eyes, and her tone increased as Wolfa kept walking away through the corridor.

“Fuckface!”

Whoa, they taught fancy words in the Horde.

“Wanker!”

Both Adora and Catra were holding back laughter, and Scorpia seemed conflicted, as if she didn’t know whether to laugh or try to calm them down (Wolfa’s voice was pretty calm, actually, it was Lonnie’s face that was becoming red and the veins on her neck were like thick ropes now). Kyle and Rogelio were both blushing.

“Okay, enough…” Azeria heard Glimmer say, the shadow of a laugh in her voice. “Wolfa! Remember what you said about not being an asshole?” she shouted. Wolfa slowed down her pace, then she turned and looked at the Queen from a distance, an apologetic smile on her face as she shrugged.

"I can make a few exceptions to that rule, Your Majesty." And then she started walking again, faster, disappearing from their sight. Azeria snorted and shook her head. Ah, that girl. She was madly in love with her, and that was absolutely nothing she could do about it.

Adora had had the time to have a shower with Catra, and that shower lasted way longer than strictly necessary, but, oh, it was *amazing* , and surprising, since Catra clearly liked hot water if she was with her, and then they had taken a nap, alone in their bed, tired but content. They defeated the Kadrimans, they didn't lose anyone else, and there it was again: peace. Adora sighed, feeling her whole body so relaxed that she was sure she could melt if she wanted to. Catra was curled up against her side, holding her left arm like a blanket around her waist, purring quietly. The love of her life, the woman she would soon marry. A smile curved her lips as her sleepy stare wandered on the purple folds of the tent that surrounded their bed. Her wife. She would be Catra's wife, and Catra would be hers. She never thought that could be possible. Growing up together, all along, she thought they were friends. Very close friends, but still, just friends. She felt something different when she was with her than when she was with Lonnie, but she thought that it was just because Catra was her best friend. She knew her since before, and their bond was different, special. She never realized how different it was, though. Not until *that* day.

How dumb of her. She held back laughter. Looking back now, she should have known. The flutter of her heart every time she looked at her, the feeling of being complete only when Catra was at her side, of being safe, even when they were fighting one against the other…

“Hey, dummy…” Catra bent her neck and looked at her, her eyes shining in the dim light, a soft smile on her lips. “I can hear your brain clicking. What’s going on?”

Adora stared back at her.

“Nothing. I’m just…” she sighed, then she smiled. “I’m happy. We’re engaged, and it feels like a dream! Considering where we came from, what we’ve been through, it’s just… amazing. I’m still trying to get my head around it.”

Catra chuckled, then climbed on her and placed a kiss on her lips.

“I know, it’s crazy. If someone told me, like, last year, I would never ever believe them” she giggled, and Adora laughed in turn.

“Same.”

“But I’m happy we did it, Adora.” They locked gazes again, and she felt it: pure, unmistakable, strong love. She definitely knew what it was, now. “Even if it was clearly thanks to me. If I’d been waiting for you, I would have grown old. And dead, probably.”

Adora slapped her back.

“Hey! I did my part, too!”

Catra arched one eyebrow.

“Uh uh, which part? Try to die, you mean?”

She slapped her again, but on her ass this time, laughing.

“No! I… well, okay, maybe you’re right.” She burst again into laughter and Catra followed her. Then she hugged her, leaning her head on her chest.

And there they stayed, together, enjoying each other’s warmth, listening to each other’s breaths, until they fell asleep with soft smiles on their faces.

Friends again

Chapter Notes

> This is my favourite part of the story, tbh. Enjoy and, if you feel like it, leave a comment! I need your feedback! <3

She had to admit it: Mystacor was better than she remembered. Maybe because it had been funny to watch the horrified expressions on the sorcerers' faces when they had arrived there, all together, Emily included. 16 people, Melog and a robot ready to party in that sort of temple. Probably the worst day of their life.

Catra giggled. Castaspella's expression was *priceless* .

"Glimmer, you could have at least warned me you were coming here with *all* of your friends..."

"Half of them aren't here, actually, auntie… Don't worry, you won't even notice us. Right, Bow?"

Bow grinned at the sorceress.

"Yeaah… we will be super-discreet. Silent and respectful."

Count on it, Arrow Boy…

She felt Adora's stare on her and looked at her. She put on the most innocent expression on her face.

"What?"

Adora raised one eyebrow.

"I know what you're thinking. Don't."

Catra kept on that innocent mask.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

“Catraaaa…”

“What? I didn’t do anything! We’ve just arrived!”

“We’re here to relax.”

She snorted.

“As if you knew what that means.”

Adora frowned.

“I can relax! I did!”

Catra sighed and went back looking around.

“Yeah, sure, we’ll see.” She noticed that Wolfa was staring at Castaspella, who didn’t look too happy to see her.

“You did it again, Glimmer? Look, I’m happy you’re making *a lot* of friends now, but you’re making friends with literally *all* of your enemies…”

“Former enemies” Glimmer corrected her. “And we killed many of our enemies, I’m not befriending *all* of them. Just the ones who are actually good people.”

Castaspella didn’t look too convinced. She glanced even at her, but as Catra arched one eyebrow she looked away.

“Your father was coming to Bright Moon, now he’ll…”

“I know,” Glimmer smiled, “we met him on our way here. It’s all right, aunt Casta, relax. We just need a break. It’s been… a long week.”

Mpf, that’s a huge understatement, Sparkles.

Castaspella seemed convinced, at last. She smirked and turned to lead them to the palace.

“So, what do you plan to do, first? The beach?”

“Exactly!” Glimmer teleported herself high enough to place a kiss on her aunt’s cheek, and that seemed to soften her.

“Okay then, you know the way. See you later?”
Glimmer smiled at her.

“Sure.”

She left them alone. Catra heard Wolfa let out a little sigh of relief, and eyed her out of curiosity, but, for once, Wolfa wasn’t looking at her, but at Glimmer.

“How is there a beach here? Is there a lake?” she asked.

Both Glimmer, Bow and Adora grinned, confusing Catra and, evidently, Wolfa too.

“You’ll see.”

Apparently, the beach was the edge of that floating island, and the sea was made of clouds. Wolfa stared at that sight in awe. It was the weirdest and coolest thing she’d ever seen. They could literally touch the clouds. Like, real clouds, fluffy, pink-white and moving like real waves on the shore. It was incredible.

“So, what do you think?” Bow asked her. She blinked, realizing she was staring at the beach with her eyes wide open, and gazed at him. He was smirking at her.

“This is sooo cooool!” Tauro yelled behind her, then he ran screaming excitedly to the clouds and started jumping right there

on the shore when the soft waves touched his hooves. Wolfa chuckled, nodding towards him.

"I think he expressed perfectly what I think about this."

Bow cheered.

"Yes! I knew you would like it!"

She eyed him, surprised.

"How?"

"Well, everyone does, actually, but you kind of like the sky and everything up here, so I thought…"

Wolfa didn't even try to hold back a smile.

"I said I like the stars, pinhead, not the sky."

"Pinhead? Seriously, *Wolfie* ?"

She frowned.

"Ah, I wouldn't… don't call me that. Kara used to do that when we… you know, spent the night together. I don't want to associate you with *that* ."

Bow's face reddened at once.

"Oh my… I didn't know it! You should have told me!" he squeaked.

Kara's crystalline laughter filled her ears one moment before she wrapped her shoulders with her left arm. Wolfa felt her body tense, and not in a good way. She swallowed and blinked and forced herself to breathe. *I'm safe. It's just Kara.*

"Don't you worry, boy, I still call her Wolfie, and we don't really fuck anymore. Unfortunately."

While Bow was almost passing out from the embarrassment, Wolfa turned her head to meet Kara's amused stare.

"First, you're being gross. Second, *you* left me."

Kara shrugged.

"Of course. I didn't want to hear you calling me Cat…"
"OKAY" Wolfa stopped her, blushing a bit. "We spoke about this two years ago, don't bring it back."

Bow was slowly and silently walking away in the meantime.

"Hey, you started it. I was just replying."

Wolfa sighed and freed herself from her arm.

"See what you did?" she said pointing at Bow, who was far enough now to pretend he couldn't hear them. "You made him run away. I'm trying to make friends here."

"Are we not enough for you anymore?" Ophid asked, but he was sneering. Thanks to She-Ra's healing power, he didn't have even a scratch to remember him about the battle against the Kadrimans. Wolfa scowled at him.

"You're my worst nightmare."

Both him and Kara burst into laughter. She left them there and moved closer to the clouds, but away from Tauro, who was still jumping and laughing enthusiastically, but together with Rogelio and Kyle now. She crouched and reached out, touching that cold mist, making it twirl around her fingers. She smirked. It was the most delicate and crazy thing she'd ever done in her life. It was weird to find out that her touch could be so dainty, gentle enough not to make the mist move, if she wanted to.

She drew back her hand, a comforting feeling warming her stomach. Maybe she could actually do something else other than fighting.

Was that new hope that made her move her stare to the opposite side of that incredible beach, right there where Scorpia was putting down a red towel, next to Perfuma's. The ex Horde's robot they kept calling Emily for some reason was with them too but, fortunately, Entrapta and Hordak were quite distant and... analyzing the clouds? Probably, seen the weird devices they were using, pointing their antennas to the 'waves'.

Okay. It was time to grow a pair and do it.

She took in a long, deep breath and then walked to the Queen of the Fright Zone. Perfuma noticed her first, since Scorpia was turned. Wolfa took a second to look at her massive back muscles. She'd never stop envying them. Like, seriously, she was huge. Scorpia'd always been one of the tallest cadets, even when they were kids, but there had been a moment between eight and nine years old when Wolfa had hoped she would reach her. That didn't happen, obviously, as she'd reached her actual height when she was fourteen and Scorpia was already taller, back then. But, even if Wolfa had spent twice as much time as Scorpia training, her muscles seemed to have reached their maximum volume. She was pretty satisfied with them… as long as she didn't look at Scorpia, at least.

The bug in question turned abruptly, probably because she'd noticed Perfuma's wary expression. Wolfa locked eyes with her before stopping two steps away from that mountain of muscles.

She hesitated for a moment, because, hell, it was hard to do this, but…

This is strength, too.

She bowed her head, as composed as she could be. Then she straightened her neck, and then bent it back to look at her face. Scorpia's black eyes were wide open in a shocked expression.

"Your Majesty…" No, that didn't sound right, not now. "Scorpia" she corrected herself. Perfuma, behind her, was astonished as

much as her girlfriend. Wolfa was pretty sure that she wasn't the only one who was staring at her now, but she didn't turn to find out if she was right, giving Scorpia all her attention. "I am a jerk. I was mean and offensive to you with no reason, and I really, really regret doing it. We were best friends…" Oh, she remembered how funny it was to spend her time with her, running around in the Fright Zone, that Scorpia knew better than anyone else, hiding from the superiors when they stole the contraband food from the elder cadets, or when they just trained together (Scorpia let her always win). "You were my best friend, and I just… threw you away." *I won't cry, I fucking won't cry in front of everyone* again … "It was stupid and I just took advantage of your… *goodness* to make you a scapegoat for what I was going through with Lonnie and Catra and I-I hate it. I'm sorry, Scorpia. I really am."

Scorpia was speechless, completely astounded. But Wolfa knew her, and, as a soldier, she also learned how to anticipate the others' moves. But she did nothing to avoid Scorpia's bone-breaking hug. On the contrary, she did what she never did with anyone: she hugged her back, and that made a new and weird and pleasing sensation burst inside her chest. She heard Scorpia try to speak, but she also literally felt her muffled sobs, more than hearing them. Wolfa shut her eyes (she really refused to cry again), and tightened her grasp around her huge torso.

"Also, I know you're not a crab."

That was enough to make Scorpia laugh through the sobs and let her go. Wolfa eyed her with an uncertain smirk on her face.

"I can't believe you just… I mean, I knew you still cared about me, and I wanted to do something but I just… and then you…" Scorpia pointed at her with her pincers, clearly unable to finish a sentence. Wolfa chuckled.

"Okay but breathe, Scorp."

“And now we’re friends again! I’ve been waiting for like ten years for this moment! And I never thought you would just… Wolfa what… why now?”

Scorpia looked *really* distraught. She sighed.

“I just… you know, I died.” She shrugged while Scorpia paled, but it had been a terrible idea to say it out loud again. She had to blink repeatedly to hold back the tears. *You’re alive now. Breathe* . “It changes things. Perspective.” Wolfa looked in her friend’s eyes, which were rapidly filling with tears again. “I realized how much I had lost, how much time and energy I had wasted, and I decided I don’t want to do it anymore. So…” She scratched the back of her neck. “I don’t know if that makes any sense but…”

Scorpia hugged her again, squeezing the air out of her lungs.

“I really need my ribs, Scorp…”

“Oh, sorry, sorry, I just… eh, guess I'm just getting a bit emotional here” she said, stepping back and rubbing the back of her head. “Did I hurt you? I didn't mean to hurt you! Do you want to lay down here with us? Do you have your towel? I can lend you mine, I will just sit…”

“Scorp…”

“... with Perfuma. It’s not a problem, really. I promise my towel is clean, I took it from the laundry…”

“Scorpia…”

“Oh, maybe you want to go for a walk? I’m good at walking. We could just…”

Wolfa couldn’t hold back laughter anymore.

“Scorpia, breathe! I brought a towel, yes, thanks, I’d like to stay here. Just relax. There’s time.”

Wolfa let her backpack swipe down her back and crouched to take out her horrible purple towel. The only ones that Bright Moon seemed to produce. She grimaced.

"Gah, I hate this color…"

"It fits you very well, actually" Perfuma said, gaining a stare from her. "You look good in the guard's new uniform."

"Ah, I feel actually very stupid with that jerkin on, but Glimmer was immovable about the colors, so…" She shrugged and landed her ass on that stupid towel. "I'm sure that if it wasn't for Adora I had to wear those silly helmets, too." She glanced at Adora, who was laying down a few metres away from her, next to Melog and Catra, who seemed to have fallen asleep there, bathing in the sun. Her tail was slowly and lazily swaying, though, so Wolfa doubted that she was actually sleeping. The familiar aching pressure weighed on her heart, but she welcomed it with calmness, like an old enemy turned to a friend: there you are, I know you, you can't hurt me anymore. Glimmer and Bow were laying next to them with very satisfied and relaxed smiles on their faces. Moving her stare a bit she noticed that Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle were sitting in a circle together with Ophid, Tauro and Kara, and they seemed to be throwing something in the middle of the circle. Ophid's dices, probably. Hordak and Entrapta were still distant, still enthralled by their studies. And then there was Azeria. She was sitting alone on the shore, distant, hugging her legs, a hand playing lazily with the cloud that kept touching her bare feet, her long and fluffy tail laying on the ground, motionless, and her long, tapered ears lowered. She imagined how it could have been, when she had saved her with mouth-to-mouth. How soft her lips were, what they tasted like… Wolfa blushed violently and looked away. No. Bad, bad idea. One step at a time. But why was she lonely down there? She glanced at her once again, then Perfuma asked: "Are you okay with her? With Adora, I mean", making her look at her.

"Oh yeah, sure." Then she sneered. "I mean, it's not like I can do anything about it, and I still can barely stand her presence, but…"

“I can hear you!” Adora said without opening her eyes. Wolfa gazed at her, satisfied.

“It’s not my fault if you’re annoying.”

This time Adora snapped her eyes open and lifted, weighing on her elbow. Wolfa caught the hint of a smile on Catra’s face, and sneered again.

“I’m not! Am I annoying?” she asked then, turning to look at Glimmer, who sighed.

“Wolfaaaaa! I was *almost* asleep, was it really necessary?”

“She started it.”

“You didn’t answer me!” Adora insisted.

“Right now, yes, you are, a lot!”

Adora gasped and Wolfa laughed. “You too, Wolfa!”

Wolfa laughed harder.

“I know, I know…”

It was actually funny being there, a lot more than she expected. And it helped her not to think. That day alone in Bright Moon had been a challenge, to say the least. Even if she had basically passed away on the floor, and there she had slept for the next five hours, she had woken up trembling with cold and after a nightmare she’d rather forget that involved Koli, Catra and a knife. She shivered at the memory.

“Are you okay?” Scorpia asked, and only then Wolfa realized that her and Perfuma had been watching her all along. She lowered her eyes and nodded.

“Uhm-uhm. I’m fine.” Scorpia didn’t buy it, and neither did Perfuma, but they didn’t ask anything (maybe because it was

pretty clear what she'd been thinking about).

Think about something else, come on… oh, right!

"Oh, Scorpia, before I forget… thank you for not taking me down when I… uh, when I attacked you princesses. You could beat me in a fight when you were seven, I can only imagine the split second it would take you to knock me out now."

Scorpia blushed a bit.

"Yeah, I didn't want to hurt you… But it wouldn't take me one second. Three, at least."

They laughed together, as they used to, and it was the most heartwarming thing Wolfa had done in years.

"Yeah, because you only throw tanks at me…"

"Adoraaaaa!" Perfuma whined. "Not again!"

After spending the morning on the beach, they all eat something before moving to the steam grotto. If Azeria hadn't been that stressed out, she wouldn't have gone with the others, but she *really* needed to relax. She'd never been this tense before. Wolfa was avoiding her and she felt like she'd lost her only chance to build a real bond with her. But what was she supposed to do? Let her die? Waste precious time and ask someone else to make the mouth-to-mouth and risk brain-damaging her? No. Whatever the consequences, she'd made the right thing. Even if Wolfa would never talk to her again. At least, she was alive.

The problem was, now, that Wolfa wasn't in the steam grotto with the others. They were all there, even her friends from the Horde, but she was missing. Azeria went next to Glimmer.
"Your Majesty…."

Glimmer sighed.

"Oh please, Azeria, once again, it's just Glimmer!"

"Okay, Glimmer, have you seen Wolfa?"

Glimmer took a look around.

"Ehm, no. Maybe she doesn't want to… you know, *stink* ?"

Considering how she'd enjoyed everyone's reaction to her smell in Bright Moon, Azeria highly doubted that the Queen was right.

"Maybe she's in trouble…"

"Here? Nah, impossible. Mystacor is super-safe!"

"Not that safe…" Adora mumbled, stretching her back. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"It was just one time, Adora!"

"Still, it happened."

"What?" Catra asked.

"Shadow Weaver followed us here" Bow explained.

"Not Shadow Weaver," Adora corrected him, "a shadow she summoned."

He shrugged.

"Whatever. She tricked Adora and almost took this place…" He jumped on the pool's edge, one fist in the air. "But She-Ra defeated the shadows with the incredible power of her sword and

brought back the moons' light, saving the day!" he shouted, making Glimmer and Adora laugh. Catra crossed her arms and rolled her eyes.

"Of course."

Azeria took advantage of the moment to check her back, seen that all everyone was wearing were bandages, and noticed the brown stripes on her skin, and the lack of fur. That's why Adora was curious about Wolfa's fur. Azeria was pretty sure that only wolves had it, since she, just like Catra, didn't, but she couldn't be completely sure about it since she hadn't met many like them.

She was about to leave to look for Wolfa when she smelled and heard her before anybody else. She turned her head, watching her walk inside the grotto. She gulped. Her white hair was tied up, and her muscles contracting at her every movement made her sweat. Every time she watched her cut ear her stomach knotted at the thought of what she had had to endure… But, honestly, it made her look even tougher than she already seemed, and that had quite an effect on her.

She watched her bump her fist against Ophid's, who was already in one of the pools with Kara and Tauro. Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle were next to that same pool, about to go in, and they froze locking eyes with Wolfa. She glared at Lonnie, who tensed.

"There's room for everyone" Kyle tried to say with a smile, and it almost sounded like a question.

Rogelio said something, too. Wolfa looked at him, then at Lonnie again. Kara reached out and touched Wolfa's hand.

"Hey, you said you wanted to make friends."

"Not with her" Wolfa said in a low growl. Azeria glanced at her tail, noticing it was tense. She couldn't see it from there, but she was sure that the fur on her back was standing on end.

“Don’t worry, cub, I’m..” Lonnie was saying, but she was interrupted by Wolfa’s loud growl.

“I did warn you, Lonnie, don’t call me that! I’m not in a very patient frame of mind these days.”

Lonnie raised one eyebrow.

“Oh, poor, little doggie.” Azeria noticed that Scorpia was approaching. “Those big bad aliens hurt you too much?”

Wolfa gave a start and Azeria lowered her ears. How could she tell her something like that after that she’d seen her conditions when they found her?

“Hey!” she shouted, just at the same time with Kara’s: “You’re crossing the line, Lonnie!”

Wolfa looked at her, and she seemed surprised.

“Don’t you dare talk to her like that again or you’ll have to deal with me, girl” Azeria continued, glaring at Lonnie. Rogelio roared something, only Wolfa knew what.

“I knew that coming here was a bad idea…” Kyle murmured.

Lonnie looked back at her.

“I’m not afraid of you.”

“Because you’re the dumbest idiot ever!” Wolfa said. “She would chop you into little pieces before you even struck a first blow. You’re not even worth her blades.”

Azeria stared at her in disbelief, but Wolfa’s feral eyes were fixed on Lonnie, who snorted.

“The fact that you like her doesn’t mean I wouldn’t kick her ass in a fight, cub.”

Azeria studied Wolfa's face, and her heart jumped in her chest seeing her blush a little.

"Oh please, Lonnie, you can't fight me, much less her."

"You caught me off guard, that is all."

Wolfa snorted this time.

"Sure. Like that time you *fell from the catwalk* and broke your wrist, right?"

Lonnie blushed and looked away.

"You know what? It's a shame that you'll never be with Catra, you two are perfect for each other" she hissed before marching out of the steam grotto with her fists clenched. Wolfa clenched jaw and gazed down, shaking her head. Scorpia leaned a pincer on her shoulder, but Wolfa jumped away from her, then she stared at her with her eyes wide open, blinking and panting.

"Sorry, I didn't mean to startle you…" Scorpia was saying, but Wolfa stopped her.

"It's okay, it's not your fault. I'm just nervous. And conflicted, because I really want to smash her face now, but I also don't want the sorcerers to kick us out of here, so…"

"I mean, she would deserve it" Catra cut in, coming closer (turning her head, Azeria realized that everyone had moved closer, actually, and Adora still looked ready to pounce on someone, to put an end to a fight, probably). Rogelio protested with a roar. "But you wouldn't solve anything."

Wolfa looked at Catra right in the eyes, with no hesitation, even if she still looked sad when she gazed at her. Then she looked at Glimmer, who smirked at her and nodded, and Wolfa sighed. She nodded once.

"'kay, I'll look for her and bring her back. But I can't promise I'll get her here in one piece."

Rogelio roared with a worried expression on his face. Ophid shrugged.

"Yeah, maybe it's better, bro" he said.

"Wait, you understand him, too?" Adora asked, and Ophid looked at her as if she was dumb.

"Of course I do. Why are you all so surprised about it?"

"Because we don't!"

"Well that's your problem, not mine."

Wolfa, in the meantime, nodded towards Rogelio, who walked side by side with her out of the steam grotto roaring something while she was sniffing the air.

"It's not my fault if she's a jerk to me!" Azeria heard Wolfa say to him while they were going away. She sighed. Should she go with her? If Wolfa wanted it, she would simply tell her… and it was clear, at that point, that she didn't really want her around. She had just fooled herself, in Bright Moon. Maybe Wolfa felt some kind of respect towards her, but nothing more.

Gloomy, the warrior headed towards an empty pool and sank her tired body in that warm water, closed her eyes and tried to resign while letting the steam fill her lungs.

"Look, we hate each other and that's perfectly fine with me, okay? But we're ruining the others' vacation and that's just rude."

Lonnie kept glowering at her, her buff arms crossed on her chest.

“I’m not pretending we’re friends, cub.”

Wolfa swallowed back the urge to choke her. *A decent person. Just be a decent person* .

“I’m not asking you to do it. All we have to do is go back to the steam grotto and avoid each other. Is just as easy. You don’t look at me, I don’t look at you, we don’t even have to stay in the same pool! You want to hang with Kara, Tauro and Ophid? Do it. I’m okay with that, it’s their choice, not mine. Just don’t talk to me, as I won’t talk to you. Okay?”

Lonnie thought about it for a while. Rogelio roared to her, and she understood his plea even without her translation.

“Okay” she sighed. “Let’s go, then.”

Wolfa kept her promise and didn’t talk to her, not even as she led them back to the grotto. She left them in the pool with her old pack and headed towards… she didn’t really know where to go. Glimmer was grinning at her, so she would go to her but… She noticed Azeria floating alone in another pool. Why was she alone? She felt that strange fear clench her body...

Then someone grabbed her by her waist and lifted her effortlessly as she let out a startled growl.

“WOLF-BOMB COMING!” Scorpia yelled before tossing her in the pool where Glimmer, Bow, Catra and Adora were bathing. She found herself in the water as the Best Friends Squad’s screams and laughters filled the steamy air before she could even yell. When she emerged, her hair covering her eyes, her ears flat (and filled with water), and a really, really annoyed expression on her face, Scorpia was laughing her ass off together with them. She stopped as she saw her face, looking a bit worried.

“Please, tell me you’re not mad at me already! Oh no, you are, oh no, I ruined everyth…”

Wolfa suddenly reached out of the pool, the grabbed her claw, pulled with all her strength as she lifted one foot to put it on Scorpia's belly and use it as a fulcrum to make that mountain of muscles lose her balance, and as she saw her widen her eyes and she felt her weight on the leg she lowered and used the grasp on her pincer and her leg to kick her backwards into the water. The pool almost emptied as Scorpia fell into it, and the splashes wetted the floor

around it and, of course, all of them.

Wolfa sneered as she stood up, hands on her hips, watching Scorpia come out of the water coughing.

"You'll agree with me that the temperature of the water is perfect, isn't it, Scorp?"

Scorpia burst into laughter, and Wolfa chuckled, greeting the surprised stares that Catra, Adora and Bow were giving her. Then she pounced on Scorpia, fake-fighting and laughing with her on the other side of the pool. And forcing herself not to look at the other pool, the one that was occupied by Azeria. Strange things were happening inside of her. She was scared, she was terrified, and impatient at the same time. She knew she should wait, because she wasn't sure that what she was feeling for her was something more than admiration and respect… and at the same time she knew it was. Because she had admired and respected other people before, but her heart had never jumped in her chest like that, she'd never felt that warmth spreading from it… it only used to happen with Catra. But now, it wasn't only with her that it happened anymore. And that frightened her.

That night, when she curled up on the beach, under her blanket, she fell asleep with a little smile on her lips and a huge decision in her mind.

Of fear and bravery

Chapter Notes

The moment I've been waiting for since I started to write TBBW has finally come!!! :D
Enjoy! <3

The first rays of the rising sun awakened her. Azeria blinked and yawned, covering her mouth with her hand. She stretched her back and tail, squealing slightly. She opened her eyes and all she could see were fluffy, pink clouds around her. Well, she slept in worse places.

But not even that breathtaking sight was enough to erase the emptiness she'd started to feel the day before. She had watched Wolfa laugh and play with her friends, and of course she was happy for her… but still. She couldn't stop wanting her to at least look at her, just once. A glance, a smirk, anything. But Wolfa ignored her like she wasn't even there. So maybe she should just leave, go back to Plumeria. That was the home she chose for herself, and she actually missed her little house in the woods. Bright Moon was beautiful, and serving as Royal Guard had been an honor, but, honestly, she did it only to stay next to Wolfa. It was useless, now. Wolfa had everything she needed. *Everyone* she needed.

She stood up and packed up her things. She had watched Adora drive the skiff they'd used to go there, so she knew how to use that thing, it wasn't hard. She walked as silently as she could amongst the people sleeping, heading towards the gates. She had just left the beach when she heard something move behind her. She turned abruptly, ready to fight, habit, but the surprise of finding Catra in front of her made her adrenaline vanish. Catra raised her hands.

"Hey, relax. I just heard you walk away. Where are you going?" she whispered. Azeria swallowed, shot a glance behind her and

then grabbed her hand and dragged her further away from the beach. No human could hear them where they were a moment before, but now she was sure that not even Wolfa could.

“I’m going home. There is no use in staying further.”

Catra furrowed her brows.

“Don’t.”

Azeria frowned. She didn’t talk to her since the Crimson Waste, why was she doing it now?

“Why should I stay?” she objected. “It’s clear that Wolfa doesn’t want me around…”

“Are you out of your mind? She does, you idiot! She’s just going through a lot, you need to give her more time!”

Azeria snorted.

“She didn’t need time to make it up to Scorpia or to fight Lonnie. Come on, Catra! Not everyone is as lucky as you and Adora.”

Catra clenched her jaw.

“Lucky? You think we’re lucky?! We fought for what we wanted, literally, and if you don’t fight for her, then you don’t really want her, Azeria! She’s… vulnerable now, can’t you see it? She’s clinging to Scorpia because she feels safe with her!”

Azeria arched one eyebrow.

“How would you know? You barely talk to her. You don’t know her.”

“I don’t talk to her because I don’t want to hurt her.” Catra shook her head, sighing. “I can’t be her friend, I’m not the right person. She wants more from me, and I can’t give her that. I know it, she knows it, you know it, everyone knows it, and yet she’s staying.

She’s even becoming friends with Adora! She’s strong, Azeria, but she’s not made of steel. None of us is. Have you noticed how she keeps that ear low?”

Azeria let out a trembling sigh, drinking in everything Catra was saying. She didn't think she was actually watching Wolfa so attentively.

“Of course I did” she murmured.

“As I told you, she’s going through *a lot* . Maybe she doesn’t show, but she is. Trust me. I have some… experience. And I was there, I saw what they did to her...” Catra’s stare told her everything about that day, and she had to struggle with a shiver. “If she went to Scorpia it’s because she needed her old best friend, because, *maybe* , she needs a lot of hugs, and safety, and good memories. Give her some time. Stay, Azeria, because, if you leave, you’ll lose her.”

“Okay” she murmured, mesmerized by how easily Catra seemed able to read Wolfa. Catra smirked.

“See?” she said. “We former Horde guys can be quite unpredictable, uh?” And she punched her shoulder. Azeria had to let out a chuckle, but she kept looking at her in astonishment.

Catra left her there, wondering how that girl could be the same one who almost led the Evil Horde to conquer all Etheria.

Scorpia was 100% sure that Wolfa was just pretending to be playful and happy. She could tell by that *something* in her eyes, by the way her shoulders were always rigid, by the fact that she never *really* wagged her tail. It wasn’t like she could just go and

tell her: “Hey, I think we should talk about the fact that some really bad guys tortured you to death, because I feel like you haven’t dealt with that yet”, though, and that’s why she was playing along and letting her act like her left ear was intact and her soul wasn’t scarred. But she could tell that it wasn’t real, and she had no idea of how to deal with that.

What could she do?

Ask her if her ear hurt? Definitely not.

Ask her about that nightmare that had made her yelp and pant during the night? Not a chance.

Casually slide into the conversation the Kadrimans topic? Mmmh, no, no.

What, then? She wanted to help her. She really did.

“Are you even listening, Scorp?”

Scorpia blinked, focusing again on Wolfa pale-yellow eyes. Oh.

“Ehm… no, sorry, I was… thinking. What were you saying?”

Wolfa rolled her eyes.

“I didn’t say a word. Your girlfriend was talking.”

Oh, crap! Scorpia looked at Perfuma, and smiled at her. She didn’t seem annoyed, just a bit worried.

“Are you okay?” she asked her, and Scorpia nodded and widened her smile.

“Me? Yes, sure! Why shouldn’t I be okay? I’m getting a good tan and having a good time!”

Perfuma didn’t believe her, of course.

“What’s wrong?”

“Nothing!”

“Scorpia…”

“I’m fine, I swear!”

“No, you’re not.”

“I am! I’m perfectly fine. Never been better.” She glanced at Wolfa, who was frowning, a dubious expression on her face.

“Did I do anything wrong?” she asked, her voice faint. And there it was, that *something* in her eyes. She didn’t know what it was, but it made her stomach clench.

“You?! No, no, absolutely! Really guys, I’m fine. Just relax, enjoy the beach.”

“Wolfa,” Perfuma said, alternating her gaze between them, “could you please give us a minute?”

Wolfa seemed somehow saddened by that request, and Scorpia was about to ask her to ignore it and insist when she leapt up, pretended to smile and walked away. Scorpia turned her head and faced Perfuma.

“She got upset!”

“She will survive. What’s wrong, Scorpia?”

Perfuma had never been this harsh. It almost frightened her. Scorpia glanced at Wolfa to make sure she was far enough.

“I’m worried for her!” she then whispered. “She’s not okay, but I don’t know what to do to help her!”

“It’s just this?”

“Yes!”

Perfuma relaxed finally.

“Okay” she sighed. “I guess we can…” Perfuma voice faded and her eyes widened. Scorpia frowned, and she had to turn her head to see what had silenced her girlfriend. And what she saw made her gasp.

Wolfa was scared.

She was walking up and down an empty spot on the beach, away from everyone else. Ophid, Tauro, Kara, Rogelio, Kyle and Lonnie were at the steam grotto actually, so the beach seemed much larger that day. And she felt fear.

Wolfa eyed Catra and Adora, who were uselessly trying to catch Glimmer, who kept teleporting herself away from them, or very close, enough to place a good kick on their asses before disappearing again, and they were all laughing. She slowed her nervous pace and a little smirk curved her lips. Catra grabbed Bow and held him hostage, threatening to scratch his face, but still laughing.

“That’s not fair, Horde scum!”

“Admit it, Sparkles, you lost! Again!”

“Face my wrath then!” Glimmer teleported right next to Catra, hugged her and… kissed her cheek. Catra hissed and wriggled free from her hold, letting go Bow in the process. And then she wiped her face as if something horrible stuck to it. Wolfa chuckled softly. Glimmer was laughing so hard that her face was red and she was falling on the ground.

“Sparkles! You’re the worst!”

“It’s called winning strategy, Horde scum!”

Something warm and reassuring filled Wolfa’s chest, even when Adora went to Catra, grabbed her face and kissed her. She was actually surprised by how good she felt watching happiness fill their eyes with love and the air with laughs. She looked away though, just because she was starting to feel like a voyeur and she didn’t want them to catch her staring. And she saw Azeria, sitting alone next to a big stone, staring at her. Azeria’s eyes darted away immediately, but too late.

That good feeling was still warming her chest. The nervousness was almost gone, enough to let her think straight, even if that fear was still there. She breathed in the clean, fresh air, and walked to her.

As Azeria noticed, she widened her eyes and stood up. She opened her mouth to say something, but she didn’t give her the time to do it. Wolfa stepped in front of her, grabbed her arms, leaned over and pressed her lips against her mouth, closing her eyes.

Wolfa’s heart was a war drum right before the battle.

Flowers, moss, and the particular scents of that place. Her lips, so soft, velvety. Azeria was holding her breath, but as she moved her hands from her arms to her face, scratching softly the back of her so-damn-soft ears, caressing the whole length of one of them then, feeling the cold gold of her earring, and sinking then her fingers in that silky mass of her brown hair, Azeria gasped, shaking. Wolfa licked her upper lip and deepened the kiss, and she could almost hear the warrior’s heart beat as fast as hers. Their tongues met and she let go a low moan, and she felt Azeria give a start. She touched the fox-girl's fangs, feeling on the tip of her tongue their sharp edge, her body on fire.

Wolfa had started that kiss, and she ended it, too. She detached from her, panting, as Azeria was doing. She looked confused, scared, and unbelieving.

Wolfa licked her own lips, looking in her luminous, orange eyes. Her vertical pupils were so dilated that they seemed round.

"I know that it might sound like a contradiction now", Wolfa said, noticing how raspy her own voice sounded now, "but can we just take it slow? I'm not… I might need some time to… sort some things out and…"

Azeria's fingers pressed gently against her lips. Her stare was still filled with incredulity, but a tiny, hesitant smile was lighting up her pretty face.

"Of course *we* can." She said it like that was the most beautiful word in the universe. Then she snorted a laugh. "You just took me off guard, I never thought you…" Azeria sighed. "You're a beautiful mystery, Wolfa."

Wolfa blushed, because none had ever associated the word 'beautiful' to her. She swallowed and licked her lips again (they still tasted like her).

"I'm a mess, Azeria. And…" she sighed, dropping her hands, even if her hair and ears were so silky that she'd touch them all day long. Her heart rate accelerated again, because now she was scared. She was scared that Azeria wouldn't accept it, like Kara, and that she would lose her even before she'd ever had her. "There's something you need to know before… I mean, not that you ever acted like you were jealous, but…"

Azeria cupped her face, silencing her, and trapped her stare in her eyes. She looked so serious now…

"I know you love Catra, Wolfa, I don't expect you to stop loving her. And I'm really sorry if that brings you pain. I wish I could do something to…"

"It doesn't" Wolfa interrupted her. "Not anymore. But you need to know that I do love her, and I don't think I can ever change that. Not even if… if I f-feel… s-something for you." Wolfa was still scared, because it was still damn hard to believe that she could

love someone else beyond Catra. But she had always chosen bravery over fear, and she wouldn't stop doing it.

"You *feel* something for me?" Azeria whispered, her eyes wide open. Wolfa drank her look, letting herself admire those delicate, gorgeous features for the first time, maybe.

"I might… you make me feel… *things* I thought I couldn't feel for somebody *else* …" Azeria's eyes were filling with tears, and she would think she'd said something wrong if she wasn't grinning. "But I just… I n-need some time to… are you really not jealous? How's that even possible?" she babbled, just because she was about to panic.

Azeria smirked.

"I never said I'm not."

Wolfa stared at her.

"But you don't look jealous."

Azeria sucked in the air between gritted teeth.

"Well I… do you really want the truth?" Wolfa nodded.

"Always."

"Okay, well… I am jealous. But Catra is smart and funny, and I get why you care so much about her. And she… are you sure you want the truth?"

Wolfa was starting to get nervous, but she nodded anyway.

"Okay. I can tell that she only has eyes for Adora, that's why I'm so calm."

Wolfa furrowed her brows and, after staring at her long enough to make her panic, she sneered.

"You little profiteer…"

“Hey! I’m not a…”

“You’re a vixen, after all, what did I expect?”

Azeria slapped her arm, laughing, and she held back laughter.

“And you can’t call me ‘little’! I’m older than you, other than faster.”

Wolfa snorted.

“Faster! Pft! You can’t prove it yet! How do you know how old I am, anyway?”

Azeria winked at her.

“I have my sources.”

She frowned again.

“Those three traitors!”

“Just one of them, actually. Not that I’m telling you who they are.”

Wolfa gave her a wolfish smirk.

“We’ll see about that” she said while watching her blush. Except that she blushed in turn, finding herself staring at her longer than expected. Azeria reached for her hand, and she let her take it between her slender fingers.

“Do you want to sit here with me?” Azeria asked. Wolfa let herself look at her a little longer, then she smiled.

“Yes.”

As they sat one next to the other, her gaze escaped to the rest of the beach and she found out that *everyone* was looking at them with their eyes wide open. Many of them averted her gaze immediately, but Scorpia started jumping in place, her claws joined in front of her mouth and her eyes bigger than they’d ever

been, and Bow was basically her mirror. Glimmer was smiling widely at her, and she smirked in turn before lowering her eyes.

"We have a public" she murmured. She glanced at Azeria, who was smiling at her, relaxed and happy.

"I think none expected you to kiss me. I didn't, for sure."

"Glimmer knew."

Azeria arched her eyebrows.

"Really? You… oh. Oh! That's why she… I should've known" she mumbled, slapping her face. Wolfa laughed.

"Why? What did she…"

She didn't have the time to finish the question because the Best Friends Squad joined them. Well, Glimmer and Bow joined them, but they dragged Catra and Adora there, too.

"Sorry to interrupt, but we heard everything and I'm soooo happy for you!" Glimmer said right before hugging Wolfa, who widened her eyes and held back an instinctive growl.

"You heard *everything* ?!" she gasped, and Glimmer grinned. Out of the corner of her eye she saw Catra blush a little and Adora look away, and she felt her own cheeks in flames.

"Yeah, here it's different, the clouds make the sounds travel faster I think… I'm not sure, you should ask Entrapta. Anywayyyy, I'm so proud of you!" And with that, Wolfa wished to fall down into the sky and crash to the ground. She covered her face.

"Oh please, don't…"

"Why don't we just leave them some time alone? It's embarrassing…" Adora tried to say.

" *You're* embarrassing, Sparkles. Just let her breathe."

“Come on, guys, let me gloat! I kept the secret all these days, I deserve it!”

Wolfa had to look at her, but she still kept half of her face covered with her knees and arms.

“Thanks for that” she mumbled. “Now fuck off, please.”

Azeria slapped her arm again.

“Wolfa!” she scolded her, but Glimmer was laughing.

“You ruined it with that ‘please’, I’m sorry. You frightened me for about one minute before I realized that you’re a good girl.”

Wolfa lowered her ears.

“Don’t say that. I’m nasty and scary and evil.” She managed to say it very seriously, making them all laugh hard.

“Sparkles is more dangerous than you, Wolfa!” Catra said laughing. Wolfa narrowed her eyes, sneering victoriously.

“I could say the same about you.”

“Not really.”

Catra stuck out her tongue and she burst into laughter.

“I didn’t come here only to gloat, by the way” Glimmer said, and Wolfa looked at her, noticing that she was alternating her gaze between her and Azeria. “I wanted to tell you that you don’t have to come back to Bright Moon, if you don’t want to. You’re free from your duties.” And now Glimmer looked in her eyes. “If you want to go to the Fright Zone now that you’re friends with Scorpia again, I completely understand it. I know that that is your home, not Bright Moon. Or Plumeria…” She looked at Azeria, and Wolfa did, too. Her ears were low, now, and she looked conflicted. “Wherever. What I mean to say is that you don’t have to be Royal Guards anymore, if that’s not what you want.”

Azeria moved her eyes on her, and they stared at each other for a moment.

“I will follow you wherever you want to go” Azeria said. Wolfa swallowed back the emotion that those words awakened. She could read the truth in her eyes. She turned her head and gazed at Scorpia, who was clearly listening but was also keeping distant. Scorpia smiled at her. Wolfa turned her head again and looked at Azeria.

“Thank you. But I’d rather know what *you* want to do” she told her. Azeria lowered her ears more.

“I don’t care where we live, Wolfa, as long as you want me with you” she murmured. And Wolfa had to blink repeatedly to dry her eyes. Okay, she wasn’t prepared for that. She had to breathe in a lot of air to swallow that sentence.

“You don’t have to decide now” Bow said. Wolfa could swear that his eyes were heart-shaped for a moment. “Just think and talk about it.”

“Yes, and…” Glimmer intervened again “Just in case you still want to be Royal Guards, I’ve lost General Juliet…” They all saddened. Wolfa shivered remembering how Ruli had killed her. “...So I kind of need a new general. There could be two. Just saying.” She winked, even if her smile was still stained by the sadness. Wolfa looked into her purple eyes.

“I’m sorry I couldn’t save her.”

Glimmer sighed.

“I’m just happy you two and Melog made it out alive.”

She actually didn’t, but she wasn’t in the mood to point that out, so she just lowered her stare and cleared her throat.

“I’ve had enough commanding soldiers, by the way, and I’m definitely not good at it, so…”

“Are you kidding me?” Both Catra and Azeria said, and then they shared a glance. Catra plowed on: “You were great as a commander.”

Wolfa stared at her.

“We lost. I’ve made a mess, I got you and me captured...”

“Seriously, Wolfa?” Catra stopped her, towering over her now that Wolfa was sitting and she was standing. “I saw you run at the forefront to protect your soldiers, I saw you save many of them from the robots. I’ve never seen an officer care so much about their soldiers. And we got captured just because you stayed there and fought the Kadrimans yourself to protect the others!” She pointed at her own chest. “I have never done anything like that when I was commanding the Horde, let alone Hordak, or any Force Captain. If you had ever to become Bright Moon’s General, Sparkles should kiss your boots. And you…” As Wolfa was trying to remember how to breathe, Catra aimed her finger at Azeria. “You are the best warrior I’ve ever met and you act exactly like her, so, Sparkles, prepare yourself, you have four boots to cover with worshipful kisses.”

Glimmer looked half happy, half pissed off.

“First of all, I’m the Queen and I’ll never kiss any boots. I don’t know and I don’t want to know what you’re used to doing with Adora but that’s not something I like to do…”

“GLIMMER!” Adora shouted, blushing. Catra didn’t even flinch.

“Second, I agree with everything else.” And she looked at them again. “But I don’t want to push you. Please, choose freely, I just want you two to be happy, even if that means losing my only two guards left. I’ll hire others. Not that they’ll be as good as you but…”

Azeria snorted, smiling.

“We got it, Glimmer. Thank you.”

“Yeah” Wolfa managed to say. “Thank you.” And she looked at Catra, who rolled her eyes.

“Now don’t act weird, I still think you’re a stinky dork.”

Wolfa burst into laughter.

“That’s actually quite accurate.”

Connections

The Best Friends Squad was far enough for the misty air to make their silhouettes blurred. Azeria let go of Wolfa's hand and caressed her face, making her widen her gorgeous, lupine eyes, and then the soft, wavy, white hair behind her nape.

She leaned over and kissed her again. Now that she could do it, she wouldn't miss any chance to taste those velvety, sweet lips of hers. And Azeria was sure she would never get tired of doing it.

She felt Wolfa smirk and push her gently away. Azeria opened her eyes as she distanced from her… whoa. Her *girlfriend* . Was it even real?

"Are you going to kiss me so often?" Wolfa asked, amusement in her voice and eyes. Azeria rubbed her soft hair and she saw her wag her tail out of the corner of her eye.

"I would be crazy if I didn't."

And in that moment Wolfa's stare changed, darkened.

"Why me, Azeria? I'm not one who deserves… any of this" she whispered. Everything, from her fragile voice to her lowered, asymmetrical ears, broke Azeria's heart. She cupped Wolfa's face way too quickly, startling her, but she ignored the sudden glimpse of fear in her eyes.

"Don't you even try to think that, Wolfa. You do deserve to be loved. Why wouldn't you?"

Wolfa opened her mouth, then she blinked, shrugged and shut it again.

"I just… I just can't believe that someone like you… I mean, I'm nothing special, I'm not…"

Oh, hell!

“Wolfa, the fact that you can’t turn into a eight feet tall warrior doesn’t mean you’re not special.” The sarcastic glance that Wolfa gave her made her roll her eyes. “You might not be *that* special, but isn’t that great? In case you didn’t notice, being She-Ra is a burden. Look, I don’t know Adora very well, but I’ve been watching her and everyone knows what she’s been through. I’m happy that you’re not She-Ra. And why would you even want to be She-Ra? You don’t need it! You’re strong, you don’t need that power!”

Wolfa clenched her jaw and glanced away.

“I don’t feel strong” she murmured before stepping back and turning. “But I do feel lucky” she added then, before she could say anything, looking at her over her shoulder with a smirk that melted her. “Go now, vixen. Go to the steam grotto with them.”

Azeria frowned. She’d be damned if she could understand that girl.

“Aren’t you coming with me?”

“It’s better if I join you later. I don’t want to be forced to stay in the water too much to avoid offending everyone’s sense of smell.”

Azeria hesitated. Wolfa was still keeping her left ear way too low, but she was also smiling slightly… and, maybe, she just needed some space.

“See you later, then.”

Wolfa smirked.

“Sure.”

“See? That’s how you do it! You don’t just wait three years and spend those three years kicking your love’s ass… OUCH!”

Bow darted out of the pool to avoid Catra’s unsheathed claws.

“I swear, Arrow Boy, if you say something so dumb again…”

“Why do you have to be so mean?! You look *so cute* , you shouldn’t be… AAAH!” Catra had jumped out of the pool and now they were running around the grotto, making everyone laugh.

“She won’t kill him, right?” Glimmer asked. Adora tilted her head watching her girlfriend chase her best friend *very* slowly (for her standard speed) and with an amused sneer on her beautiful face.

“She could’ve done it three times already, so…”

Glimmer gave her a nudge, and when Adora looked at her she realized she was sneering.

“So, are you more relaxed?” At her questioning stare, Glimmer explained: “Now that Wolfa and Azeria are together.”

Oh.

Adora thought about saying that nothing had really changed. Wolfa still loved Catra, after all, she said it pretty clearly. And she had never been *really* jealous. That’s what she’d like to say. Not that she was capable of lying to Glimmer.

“Definitely” she spat out, and Glimmer laughed with her then.

Catra managed to throw Bow in their pool in the end. He emerged coughing.

“You could’ve killed me!”

“I should’ve, you mean.”

Bow pointed a finger at her.

“Mean kitten.”

Catra hissed, lowering her ears and swaying her tail and Bow yelled, hiding himself behind Glimmer, who laughed again. Catra looked really pleased with herself now. And hot. Damn, if she was hot with that smug expression on her face.

“Hey, Catra…” Catra looked at her, and her smirk softened. Adora motioned at her with her finger. “Come back here, please.”

She narrowed her eyes, but she slid back inside the pool and walked in the warm water to her. She was about to say something, but Adora grabbed her by her waist and dragged her close right before kissing her passionately. Surprised at first, Catra then kissed her back with that same energy.

“You’re really cute and sweet, but, seriously, take a room” she heard Glimmer say, and she had to interrupt the kiss to laugh.

“We were in the middle of something here, Sparkles.”

“Yeah, everybody noticed.”

Catra rolled her eyes.

“Don’t play the innocent girl, Sparkles. Remember that I can hear every noise at night, and you and Arrow Boy here make *a lot* .”

Glimmer blushed and widened her eyes while Bow stared at Catra in horror.

“WHAT?!”

Adora laughed.

“I must admit that even I can hear you. Bright Moon’s walls should be thicker…”

Glimmer’s face was so red it was alarming.

“We need to soundproof our rooms.”

Adora nodded.

“Definitely” she said together with Bow.

Catra would have loved to stay with Adora, Glimmer and Bow, but all that water was starting to make her feel uncomfortable. She knew exactly why that pool made her feel like that, but she didn’t want to think about it. It was stupid and nonsense, she was safe. And the light there was steamy and purplish, and everyone was happy and relaxed. And yet… the pool was about as large as the one… *Stop thinking about it. You’re safe now. He’s gone* .

“Ehm… I’m going for a walk. I’m sick of feeling like a drenched mouse” she said before climbing out of the pool. Adora looked at her worriedly.

“Is everything okay?”

Catra smiled at her reassuringly.

“Yep. I just need to dry myself.”

Adora smiled back at her.

“Okay. Do you want me to come with you?”

“Nah, enjoy your bath. And make sure to annoy those two idiots.”

They shared another smile, then Catra walked away, ignoring Glimmer’s cheerful insults.

As she was exiting the grotto, she met Azeria, who was walking in. Alone. She noticed it, but she wasn’t surprised that Wolfa didn’t follow her there, considering what happened when her fur met water, so she just kept walking.

Actually, she needed some time alone. She needed to think.

She and Adora would soon marry, and that was something that kept amazing her. It was still hard to believe. It was hard to believe that it was real, hard to believe that she was actually allowed to be that insanely happy, hard to believe that she could see that same happiness shine inside Adora's eyes when she looked at her, hard to believe that they really made it, that they didn't die that day, that they could grow old together. It was never something she had allowed herself to hope for. They were raised to fight a war. When she imagined their future, back in the Horde, she wouldn't go past their twenties. She could see Adora sit on Hordak's throne with her at her side… but she'd always thought their lives would end on a battlefield. That they would die fighting, together, side by side. It had almost happened. Almost.

But they were here, now, alive, in love, happy. About to marry each other. Damn. *About to get married* .

She found herself on the shore. She didn't even realize she got there. Not that she minded. That place was amazing. Plus, there was none there… no. There was definitely someone, because she just heard a muffled sob. And another one.

She followed that sound, finding its source trying to hide herself behind one of the rocks: Wolfa was crouched, sobbing almost silently, a hand over her cut ear. Catra felt her stomach clench. Maybe she didn't hear her approach, but how could she leave her there to cry alone? She'd been there. She knew exactly what she was feeling, and being alone to face that was just… the worst. So she sat next to her, even if it was probably a bad idea. Azeria should be there, not her. Did they fight? No, Azeria looked just fine when she met her just a few minutes ago. It was probable that Wolfa had simply found a way to stay alone, to cry freely.

In fact, she gave a jump when she realized that she was there.

"Don't worry, I won't tell anyone" she told her before she could panic about it. Wolfa did seem to relax a little bit. She wiped her

tears, holding back the sobs.

“Why are you here?” she asked in a hoarse whisper.

“Oh I don’t like water, so, you know…” Catra answered, shrugging. Wolfa glanced at her. A little longer than she expected.

“You’re stressed out” she said then, surprising her. Catra’s tail swayed nervously.

“How would you know?”

Wolfa smirked, a bit sadly.

“I’ve been watching you for years, remember?”

“That’s… creepy.”

Catra met her gaze, then they both laughed. Wolfa weakly, though. The more Catra looked at her, and her cut ear, more memories of what Koli and Siali had done to her kept stabbing her mind. Wolfa had to notice, because she lowered her stare and tried to repress a shiver.

“I’m sorry you had to witness it” she murmured. *Seriously?!*

“No, I’m sorry you had to endure it!” she spat. “If I could kill them right now, I would. It’s a shame they’re dead already.”

Wolfa tilted her head for a moment.
“Not really. I’m not sure I could face them. I rather not see them ever again.”

“Right.”

There they stayed, sitting side by side, watching the pink and purple clouds surrounding them, enjoying the perfect silence. Until Wolfa turned her head and looked at her.

“You know, I had a blast fighting together with you. But I do hope it was the first and last time.”

Catra smiled and snorted.

“Same. I can’t wait for Entrapta to build that enhancer so that we can shield this planet. I’m sick of being attacked by aliens.”

Wolfa laughed softly.

“Yeah, and… I’m really happy for you and Adora. Seriously, I… You deserve this. Happiness, I mean. Both of you.”

Catra stared at her. It was going way better than she expected. Maybe they could be friends, after all. Wolfa looked sincere, she was even slightly wagging her tail.

“I’m glad you said it. I was afraid you and Adora would end up fighting for me like two idiots…”

They laughed together.

“Well, that was the risk” Wolfa said while laughing.

“It would have been so embarrassing!”

“And useless.”

Catra agreed with a nod, but Wolfa didn’t seem bothered by it. Her eyes fell on her cut ear once again, but she looked away before that Wolfa could notice it.

Silence fell again like a warm sheet above them.

“You know I… talked about it, to Adora. And Perfuma. It helps” Catra said after a while, gaining a glance from Wolfa, who sighed then and hugged her own legs. “I was thinking that, maybe, you could talk to Azeria.”
“Mh.”

Catra glanced at her. Wolfa’s left ear was lower than her right one, again.

“It’s scary, and it sucks. And it hurts. But it helps.”

Wolfa looked back at her.

“I’ll try” she said, eventually. Then she smirked. “You shouldn’t stay here with me.”

Catra shrugged.

“Why not? You’re not gonna bite me, are you?”

She managed to make her laugh again.

“That’s not what Adora fears.”

“Or Azeria.”

Wolfa blushed and hid a smile.
“*Touché*” she murmured.

“So,” Bow said, smiling widely at her, “how do you feel about the wedding?”

Adora covered her face with her hands and sank deeper into the pool.

“Panicked.”

Glimmer laughed and wrapped one arm around her shoulders.

“Breathe! You can make a plan and follow it strictly! You can study the whole ceremony and… hey, you know that *I* ’ll be celebrating the marriage, right?”

Adora suddenly stared at her.

“Really?”

Glimmer grinned at her.

“Of course! I’m the Queen!”

“Adora, do you know how a wedding works?” Bow asked, and Adora smirked at him.

“Not really.”

He sighed, then he swam to hug her from the opposite side.

“Alright, don’t worry, we’re gonna tell you everything about it. But don’t panic, there’s no need. It’s a beautiful thing and we’ll be there for you all along.”

“Yes, and you can get prepared at Mermista and Sea Hawk’s wedding, by the way” Glimmer hinted.

“Right! We’ll make sure that your wedding is absolutely perfect Adora, don’t worry.”

Adora couldn’t be more grateful to them, and she felt really touched, but still…

“I’m just afraid that… I don’t know” she sighed. “Guess I’m just nervous.”

“And it’s perfectly normal” Bow reassured her. “I’m nervous, too! But I can’t wait to see you and Catra to formally become a family.”

Then she realized it. Bow was right. Catra had always been her family, but now… now she would become it *officially* . Just the two of them, a whole family. And all of their friends would be there to celebrate it. It brought tears to her eyes.

“I will need help, guys. What am I supposed to wear?”

They shared a glance. And she knew that that glance meant that they would spend hours making her try so many different outfits

she would probably fall asleep at some point and they'd keep dressing her while she slept.

"Well, you're not *supposed* to dress in any way" Bow said.

"But you probably want to wear something formal" Glimmer added.

"And white" Bow nodded. "Usually, it's white. But you can wear any other color if you like."

Adora frowned.

"So, I *am* supposed to wear something specific."

"No!" Bow exclaimed. "I mean, you could wear a dress, a suit, a shirt, an armor if you're into it!"

"But it should be white" Adora insisted, trying to understand. Sometimes, she still felt like she didn't belong to that world. The world outside the Fright Zone. But then again, she *loved* that world, she just needed to learn some things, yet.

"It's not like it should be white" Glimmer explained. "People usually wear white outfits at their weddings. But if you want to wear… I don't know, red? Go for it. Grey? Do it. Although, I might suggest liliac as it would…"

Bow cleared his throat and Glimmer looked at him.

"What? I was just…"

"We talked about this, Glimmer, you won't push for them to wear your favorite colors."

She rolled her eyes while Adora was wondering *when* the hell did they talk about it.

"Fine. But it's not fair."

Adora couldn't help but smile.

"Why?" she asked, and Glimmer gave her one of her pissed off glances, arms crossed over her chest.

"Because Bow's favorite color is white. He's advantaged."

Adora laughed while Bow shrugged smiling.

"But I'm not trying to make her wear white!"

"No, you just told her that everybody does."

"Because it's true!"

Adora laughed again.

"What if I wear gold instead?"

They both looked at her.

"All gold?" Bow asked, then he wrinkled his nose. "Kitsch."

"Not all gold! White and gold."

Glimmer raised one eyebrow.

"Like She-Ra?"

Adora gulped. Images of how she'd seen herself in the future she wished flashed through her mind. She didn't want to wear *that* dress, but maybe she could start from it.

"I mean… if it wasn't for She-Ra, I wouldn't be here. I'd probably be leading the Horde. Or maybe we'd be all dead because Hordak would have succeeded and Prime would've destroyed Etheria. And that's just what I am. I am She-Ra. And Mara was She-Ra, and… I told you I talked to her, and she pushed me to fight for my happiness… I don't know. Maybe me and Catra would've ended up together anyway, at some point. If we survived. But not like this. I like where I am now, and I'm here because I am She-Ra. So, why not? I don't want to be eight feet tall at my wedding, Catra would get a neck ache to kiss me…" She laughed and Bow and Glimmer

followed. “But I really like those colors. They make me feel good, now.”

She looked at her best friends now. They were both smiling at her.

“Gold and white it is, then” Bow said.

“You could just say you like those colors, you know?” Glimmer laughed.

Bow gave her a nudge while Adora was laughing with her.

“Why, I enjoyed the explanation! It was really deep and sweet.” He squeezed her, making her smile. “What do you think Catra will wear?” he asked her then. Adora frowned.

“Oh… burgundy, probably? White isn’t really her color.” She shivered remembering the clothes Prime had made her wear. Both her friends hugged her tighter.

“I’m sure she’ll come out with something really cool and… sexy” Glimmer said, and Adora gazed at her with one eyebrow raised.

“I’m sorry?”

Glimmer blushed and looked away, looking angry now.

“Not that I ever noticed how she keeps exposing her thighs and chest just to catch your attention, Adora…”

She blushed a little (was that the reason? Really???).

“But you did notice!”

“Glimmer, is there anything you want to tell me?” Bow asked, a worried frown on his face.

Glimmer was blushing even more. Adora was flabbergasted. Glimmer *liked* Catra?!

“Ah, stop looking at me that way!” Glimmer shouted. “Adora, I’m not attracted to your fiancéé, don’t worry. Bow, don’t be silly.”

“I am a little bit worried, tho…” Adora mumbled. Was it possible that *everyone* was attracted to Catra?!

Glimmer looked her in the eyes.

“Adora, please, listen to me. I might…” She sighed, still blushing. “In the past, I might have thought about it a couple of times.” Adora (and Bow too, she was sure about it) widened her eyes, shocked. “But I can assure you…”

“What?!” Adora shouted. “I thought you hated her!”

“I did. I really did. But I’m not blind, Adora.”

“What is that supposed to mean?!”

Glimmer looked so sorry, and it made it even worse.

“It doesn’t matter, I mean, I’ve never *really* wanted to do anything but punch her in the face! I just noticed how good she looks. That is all. Did it ever happen to you? Or you? Bow, don’t you try to tell me you didn’t like Perfuma and Sea Hawk!”

Adora looked at Bow and saw him blush. He did? How didn’t she notice? Why didn’t she ever notice anything!?

“Yeah but… I mean, it’s not like I’m telling Mermista that once I had a crush on her fiancé!”

Adora took a deep breath. Maybe she was just overreacting. It was Glimmer she was talking to, not just anybody. Her best friend. She trusted Glimmer. She knew that she would never do anything to hurt her (on purpose).

Then why did she feel so… unsteady?

“You liked Huntara, didn’t you?” Glimmer plowed on, and Adora’s gaze darted to her.

“How do you…?”

Glimmer smirked.

“Your eyes were literally shimmering when you looked at her.”

Adora felt her cheeks burn.

“Oh. Well… yes, but, it was, like… just that. I liked her looks, but it’s not like I would’ve… you know… had a relationship with her or anything…”

“Yes!” Glimmer shouted. “I know, that’s exactly what I mean! And, if you met her again, would you still feel the same? Would you even want to kiss her?”

Adora had to think about it, because she didn’t even realize she wanted to kiss Huntara in the first place.

“Uhm… no. It’s different now. The only person I want to kiss is Catra.” That was true even back then, she realized… she just didn’t know it.

Glimmer spread her arms.

“See? For me it’s the same. Well, not the *same* same… The only person I want to kiss is Bow.”

Adora stared at her for a while as she thought about it. She was starting to feel better.

“Do you still hate me?” Glimmer asked, visibly frightened. Adora snorted.

“Hate you? Are you out of your mind?! You’re my best friend! I’m just pissed off! Everyone keeps confessing their love for Catra!”

Glimmer widened her eyes.

“Wait, wait! I never said that! There’s a huge difference between love and physical attraction!”

Adora found herself laughing.

“I know, but you guys should just stop looking at my girlfriend!”

“I never looked at her that way, if it’s any consolation…” Bow said, and Adora looked at him.

“Thank you!”

“Aah, you guys are so boring!” Adora turned and met Lonnie’s stare from the pool next to theirs. She, Rogelio, Kyle and Kara were relaxing there together. “It’s not like you can love just one person in your life!”

Rogelio said something in turn.

“Not everyone’s like you, guys” Kara said, looking at the… throuple? “I don’t like sharing, either.”

“It’s not that” Adora tried to say. “I just feel… complete with Catra. I don’t want anyone else.”

Lonnie snorted.

“Boring.”

Adora cocked one eyebrow.

“Catra? Not really, Lonnie.”

Lonnie laughed and she smirked.

Blessings

Catra took the screwdriver and gave it a distracted look. With her other hand, the left one, she was handing Entrapta a tray full of tiny food, from which her friend was eating while studying the Kadriman ship's engine, a huge black crystal surrounded by kolundrio shaped into cogs and pistons.

"... it's just like any other engine," Entrapta was saying, recording her voice, "but the primary source of power seems to be this black crystal. I wonder if it's a runestone… maybe we should try to extract its energy and convey it into someone."

Catra widened her eyes.

"I don't think that we should, actually…"

Entrapta looked at her through her bug-like glasses.

"Why not?"

"Because it's dangerous?"

She probably blinked behind the glasses.

"I would make all the security checks, of course…"

"No, I mean, for the person. You have no idea of what could happen if you put that energy" Catra nodded towards the crystal, "inside a person."

"Yeah. That's why we should do this experiment."

Catra sighed, forcing herself to keep calm.

"Yes, no, Entrapta… you could kill someone. Or make them go crazy. Or super powerful, and so, dangerous."

Silence. Then Entrapta shrugged and turned, going back to tap on her monitors.

"We'll put the energy inside a robot then!"

Catra sighed, weary.

"This won't end well…"

Glimmer, Scorpia and Wolfa entered the brand-new Bright Moon's lab. Wolfa eyed with worry the black crystal, and the kolundrio around it.

"Are we positive that it's safe to have that thing here, uh?"

"Of course… no" Catra answered, clearly pissed, and Glimmer smirked, because she was there doing absolutely nothing and it was the very first time that she saw Catra just stand still. Well, she was actually holding an almost empty tray of food for Entrapta. Which was even weirder. *So* nice of her.

"Have you found out anything, Entrapta?" she forced herself to ask. They went there for that, after all. Not to mock Catra for being a cutie pie. Not. to. mock. Catra.

"Not yet!" Entrapta almost yelled, and Glimmer caught Wolfa giving a tiny jump and shivering. She eyed her. Sometimes she thought she was afraid of Entrapta. But it was just her imagination, probably.

Wolfa was wearing her Royal Guard uniform again. She and Azeria didn't accept to become generals yet, but they didn't leave Bright Moon either, which made her hope for the best. "But as soon as I transfer the crystal's energy inside a robot, we'll find out something, I'm sure about it" Entrapta continued.

Glimmer looked at her.

“You will do *what* ?”

She also saw Catra shake her head with such an exasperated face that it made her almost laugh.

“We’ll have to face a super-powerful killer robot, Sparkles, let’s get prepared.”

“Oh, no, it’s a tiny robot we’re talking about,” Entrapta continued. She mimicked the robot’s dimensions (about the size of a hand) with her hair. “It’s just Roberta.”

“Roberta is the robot?” Scorpia asked.

“Yes!”

“Have we ever met Roberta?” Catra asked.

Entrapta stopped doing whatever she was doing and looked at her. Then she shrugged.

“I don’t know. Maybe. I found her in the Fright Zone. She’s tiny and she likes to collect things.”

Catra arched one eyebrow.

“Things?”

“Yes. Junk, mostly. You know, rusty screws and bolts…” and she went back tapping on her monitors.

Glimmer walked closer to the crystal. A large, black obelisk. It radiated a vibrant, strange energy, she could feel it.

Wolfa was immediately at her side.

“I wouldn’t dare to touch it” she said in her low, growling voice. Glimmer glanced at her, noticing how her ears were flat and her eyes pinned. “That bloody thing is still moving. Look.”

Glimmer did, and she had to admit that Wolfa was right. The kolundrio, even though just faintly, was in a never ending motion, like water flowing through a river, but slow, very slow.

“Mh.” Glimmer looked at Entrapta again. “Bow and Tauro are coming to help you, by the way. And where is Hordak anyway?”

“He said he had stuff to do” Catra answered, still pissed off. “You know how cryptic he is.”

“And Emily?” Scorpia asked.

“With him” Entrapta said. Then she walked with her hair to Scorpia. “Hey, do you want to take her with you to the Fright Zone?”

Scorpia furrowed her brows.

“Really? But…”

“Yes! She’s always happy when she’s with you.”

Glimmer saw Scorpia’s eyes become glassy. And then she hugged Entrapta.

“Thank you! I will miss you so much!”

Glimmer heard a small sigh and turned, realizing that it was Wolfa’s. She noticed she looked conflicted, and felt a stab of guilt pierce her stomach. Maybe she should just kick her out of Bright Moon to let her live her life with Azeria and her friends in the Fright Zone, without the pressure of being in charge as general.

“She’ll never learn not to hug people without asking” Wolfa murmured, though, a little smirk on her face. Behind her, Glimmer saw and heard Catra snort.

“She’s a hugger, you know it.”

Azeria was fidgeting with the small package, her tail still and her ears low. From that gorgeous balcony she could see the vastness of the sea beneath Bright Moon's castle, the ships moving over that blue surface, the sun slowly setting and painting with deep pink and orange the sky and its little puffy clouds. One week had passed since they came back from Mystacor, and it had been the best week of her whole life. Sure, Wolfa was still dealing with what they had done to her, but, after the initial chaos for the coming back of Bright Moon's people, she and Wolfa had had the whole barracks for them only, as there were no guards but them. Glimmer didn't seem so worried about her own security, it seemed. What a fortune.

A noise startled her. She turned and met the tall and (honestly) creepy figure of Hordak standing just a few steps from her, looking so embarrassed and awkward that he actually didn't seem so creepy anymore.

"Ahem… hello, Azeria" he said with his deep voice. She raised her ears. The fact itself that he knew her name was kind of a shock. She thought they were just ignoring each other.

"Hordak" she answered, more roughly than she meant to. Maybe it was because Wolfa did tell her how much he hurt her. Or maybe it was because he had sent his soldiers and robots to kill her friends and family. She couldn't tell.

Hordak seemed distressed.

"I… uh… I was looking for you."

And that was the most surprising thing he could ever tell her. She raised her eyebrows.

“Really?” she asked, genuinely curious now. And also ready to use her dagger, if necessary.

“Yes. I just… I can’t talk to Wolfa, so I thought…”

“I’m not bringing messages between you two. If you wanna tell her something, just go and do it.”

“No, no, she doesn’t want to talk to me and I want to respect her will. I just wanted to say that I’m happy she has you. I know you’ll take care of her.” And with that he left, walking the corridor quickly, leaving her speechless. What was that? *What the hell was that?* Wolfa’s dad’s blessing?

“Weeeiiird…” she hissed out.

“Loop-de-loop!”

Adora laughed again as Swifty flapped his wings and finally landed over Bright Moon’s gardens. She kept laughing as she dismounted, then she hugged him.

“I missed flying with you.”

Swifty held her close.

“I missed it, too. The guys from Plumeria are funny and nice, but it’s not the same…”

Adora moved to rub his nose.

“I couldn’t put you in danger with the Kadrimans. And we did need someone to keep an eye on Plumeria.”

“I know, I know… I just miss the action, I guess.”

Adora rubbed his neck and they started to walk towards the entrance of the castle.

“Well, you missed only the pain, actually.”

He glanced at her.

“Was it that bad?”

She shrugged. Then bumped her fist against his shoulder.

“Nothing that She-Ra can’t stand” she sneered, and he laughed. They entered the castle, which was almost empty. The lack of guards was disturbing.

“So,” Adora continued, “what are you gonna do now?”

“Seriously, Adora? I told you a million times! I’m going to give back the freedom to every horse on this planet!”

“Right, right. So… you’re gonna travel. Alone?”

He shook his mane.

“Unless you want to come with me.”

“Ah, I… you know, we have this wedding thing to do and…”

“Well of course I’m leaving *after* your wedding, Adora!”

“Yes, but, it’s not like I can leave right after my wedding…”

Swift Wind stopped walking and stared at her.

“Catra can’t stand me, isn’t it?”

Adora did her best to erase any expression from her face.

“Why would you think that?”

“She hisses every time she sees me.”

Adora just stared at him in silence until he snorted.

“Fine, I’ll go alone. But if I die, you’ll regret it.”

As Bow and Tauro entered the lab, Wolfa felt safe enough to leave Glimmer alone with them all and asked her permission to go and look for Azeria. She last saw her at dawn, when she kissed her and told her she had ‘a very important thing to do’ before disappearing all day. What this thing was, it was a complete mystery. It was clear that Glimmer knew something about it, but she wouldn’t tell her anything. She just kept trying to hide a sneer everytime Wolfa brought the argument on the table, and it made her suspicious and so damn curious.

She marched through the bright corridors of the castle, following Azeria’s scent whenever she caught a stray of it in the warm air. And then, she found her standing on one of the balconies. Wolfa stopped and just stared at her back, swallowing in the beauty of her curves and the perfect orange of her fur, wetted by the golden sunlight coming from the outside. But it didn’t take long for Azeria to hear or smell her presence. She turned, a smile already showing snow-white teeth, her little pointy canines, and her tangerine irises like scorching flames. She had let her soft hair fall loose, and they were quite wild that day, untamed, like her. She was so beautiful that it hurt. So gorgeous that she almost forgot

why she was looking for her in the first place, for a moment. How did she ignore her for so long?

“So that’s what you were doing instead of working” Wolfa told her, walking closer. Azeria giggled, stretched one arm, grabbed her belt and drawed her even closer. Enough for their bodies to touch. Wolfa started playing with a wild lock of her dark-brown hair.

“No, no, I was really busy actually” Azeria replied, her voice velvety and sultry.

“I’d like to know doing what.”

Azeria smirked and only then Wolfa realized that she was hiding her right hand behind her back. She tried to give a look, but Azeria was faster and moved accordingly, hiding the hand and whatever it was holding from her.

“Wait, wait just a moment” she chuckled. Wolfa looked in her eyes. She looked so amused.

“Why? What are you hiding?”

“Just a gift.”

Wolfa frowned.

“A gift? For who?”

Azeria burst into laughter.

“For you, Wolfa! Who else?” And she finally revealed a package made of white, soft leather, rolled around something and closed with a red ribbon.

Wolfa blinked.

“Me? But… why? It’s not my birthday…”

Azeria snorted.

“I know!”

Wolfa looked at her.

“How? Who told you?”

She rolled her eyes.

“Tauro! What’s the matter? Just open it!”

Wolfa hesitantly took the package from her hands. It was heavier than she thought, and really solid.

“I just realized I don’t know when your birthday is…” she mumbled.

“Because you never asked.”

Wolfa glanced at her, but Azeria was still smiling. And she could recognize the expectation in her eyes.

“Did I miss it?”

“No! Open the bloody gift now!” Azeria laughed.

Wolfa sighed and pulled the red string before carefully removing the white lather… and she found a couple of knives in her hands. But not common knives. Their blades, made of dark-cerulean metal, were curved, like the dark-blue hilts, that looked very elaborated and with a circular hole on top.

“I had them made just for you. They’re very special Halfmoon Claws, the blades are forged from Blue Moon Steel, it’s the best you can find, it’s the most durable and, I mean, it’s just beautiful.”

Wolfa looked at her. She was so astonished she didn’t know what to say.

“Azeria, you shouldn’t have…”

“They’ll match the uniform. I thought you might like to have some extra weapons, beside your staff… Do you at least like them? You don’t have to say ‘yes’, just tell me if you…”

“I love them.”

Azeria shut her mouth, and Wolfa smiled and blinked repeatedly. A gift, with no reason. She made her a gift just because she wanted to. And the gifts were the most beautiful knives she’d ever seen. Halfmoon Claws. She loved their name, too.

“Are you sure? We can trade them for anything else if you…”

Wolfa leaned over and shut her up with a kiss, hot and steamy, that left them both blushing and breathless. Then she smiled at her girlfriend.

“Thank you. I really like your present. I’m afraid you’ll have to teach me how to use them, though.”

Azeria’s face lit up with a wide grin.

“Sure! First of all, you don’t grab the Claws like that…”

All the things you didn't know

Chapter Notes

> Hey :) I already said it on tumblr but I'll write it here too, for those who don't follow me there: I'm so sorry! I know it took ages for this update, it's been a weird time and I just couldn't write. I'm sorry.
> I don't know how long it will take me to update so, again, forgive me. Hopefully, just a week. I really hope it.
> I also hope you'll enjoy this chapter, it was really relieveing for me to get back to writing this story and super fun to add Huntara to the plot. Enjoy! Baci <3

"...I pronounce you husband and wife."

Mermista grabbed Sea Hawk's lapel and drew him into a kiss that made the whole Salineas cheer. Adora made a spring with joy, together with Bow and Glimmer, and they all clapped enthusiastically.

The party was funny. Adora had never seen Mermista smile so much.

At some point she discovered (who told her? She couldn't remember) that the delicious drink she was drinking was 'alcoholic', whatever that meant. All she knew was that her head felt so light and… empty, somehow. ANd that she couldn't stop smirking. Oh, crap. It felt so much like when She-Ra was infected.

"Heeey, Adora, are you okay?" Bow asked as she stumbled upon him. He was holding her in place now, looking *so* worried.

She grinned.

"Perfectly fine!" And then she hugged him. "You're my best friend!"

"Ahem… yes, but you look, you know… drunk."

She distanced from him and the palace swayed. She frowned.

“What does that mean?”

He snorted.

“It means that you need to drink fresh water. Who gave you this?” he asked while taking away her glass. That was empty, anyway.

“Uhm…” She was trying hard to remember who the heck gave her that drink when she was completely distracted. “Catra!” she exclaimed, right before rushing to cling to her fiancéé. Who gave her a confused and amused sneer.

“Are you okay?”

“Yes! Why is everyone asking me?!”

Catra tilted her head. Adora realized in that moment that she was basically holding her standing.

“Because your legs don’t seem to work the way they should. Or your brain.”

“Catra? Did you give Adora a drink?”

Adora turned her head to look at Bow, who was coming closer, handling her glass as if it was some sort of dangerous weapon.

“What?” Adora looked back at Catra. *She is soo gorgeous* . “I was hanging with Entrapta down there, how could I…” Catra’s eyes widened and her hears lowered. “Wait, what was in the drink?” She stared at her now. “Did someone poison you?!”

Catra tried to make her open her mouth but Bow intervened.

“No, she’s just drunk! Relax, Catra, it’s a wedding party! Nothing bad is going to happen.”

She glared at him.

“How would you know? She’s She-Ra! What if someone wants her dead? Poisoning her would be the best way to get rid of her!”

Adora laughed, then snorted, then laughed again.

“I’m fine, Catra! Bow is right. I’m drunk. Like She-Ra.”

Catra furrowed her brows.

“What?”

Adora burst into laughter and then she found herself being actually carried by Catra. But where was she heading? Oh, to the soft, aquamarine sofas Mermista had put around the throne room. So thoughtful of her.

Catra sat down and Adora realized that now she was laying with her back on her thighs, and Catra was looking down at her.

“Are you sure none poisoned you? Entrapta could run some tests…”

Adora reached for her face and caressed her cheek, and Catra silenced.

“Never felt better” Adora mumbled, lost in the sight of Catra being surrounded by all that blue and turquoise, matching her right eye’s color. She had tied up her hair in a tiny ponytail, and the suit she was wearing, dark-blue and white, fit her so well. She watched her lower her ears, her eyebrows almost met. Then she smirked at her, placed her hand over hers and turned her head to place a kiss on her palm.

“Why did you say that She-Ra is drunk?”

Adora closed her eyes, letting her hand fall on Catra’s lap and her head fall back, leaning on the side of Catra’s thigh.

“Mmh… I can’t remember much of it, actually… You should ask Glimmer or Bow. Or Scorpia, I guess.”

“Scorpia?”

“Yeah. The huge bug.”

“I know who Scorpia is, dumbass.”

Adora opened her eyes. And she widened them.

“HUNTARA!” she shouted. Then somehow she was standing up and hugging a very amused Huntara.

“Hey, Blondie. Looks like you’re having some fun here, uh?”

“Oh yes! Hey, have you two ever met? Ah, I know the answer!” Adora turned and grabbed Catra, dragging her closer. “She’s no! I mean, it’s no! Or did you? Whatever! Catra, meet Huntara, the number one badass of the Crimson Waste! And, Huntara…”

“Wait, wait…” Catra stopped her. And pushed her aside. She and Huntara were now staring at each other with the same feral grin, their eyes sparkling with amusement and anticipation. “ *I* am the number one badass of the Crimson Waste, not this big purple lady.”

“ *Tsk* , Kitten, I ruled that place for years. You’re…”

Catra laughed in her face, with her high-pitched laughter, the one she made when she was up to something *bad* .

“Years, and you couldn’t get rid of that lizard? I defeated Tung Lashor in five minutes and took the Crimson Waste in half a day. You were lucky not to be there.”

Adora heard Huntara growl and somehow managed to put herself between them, feeling suddenly much more clear-headed.

“Are you two really fighting for who’s the toughest?”

“There’s absolutely no reason to fight” Catra said, looking at her black nails now. “It’s obvious that I am the best.”

Huntara growled again.

“Really, Kitten? Why don’t you…”

“Huntara?”

Huntara froze, and then she turned, very slowly, enough to let Adora see how tense her muscles were under the blue vest she was wearing. Adora stood on her tiptoes to see who made Huntara so nervous… just to find out that it was just Wolfa. A very elegant Wolfa, wearing beige high-waist trousers, matching blue booths and shirt and a white and turquoise tight. She looked… unbelieving. And a little upset.

“Wolfa.” Huntara’s voice sounded like a roaring thunder, it made her body react and get immediately ready for a fight.

Wolfa lowered her ears. Her tail was still, tense.

“I thought… I thought you were gone” Wolfa murmured.

Adora stepped further, so that she could look at them both.

“You two know each other?”

Huntara’s eyes didn’t move from Wolfa’s. She still looked ready to attack. Wolfa, on the other hand, looked… cautious. Even… sad? But she nodded, giving Adora a quick glance.

“The Horde” she simply said. Of course it was the Horde! Well, it could have been the Crimson Waste as well.

“So what are you going to do, Flea?” Huntara growled, and Wolfa gave a start. “Do you still want to fight me?”

Adora was pretty sure that Wolfa didn’t. The more Huntara talked, the more Wolfa looked distraught and sad.

“I j-just…” she stammered indeed, and Adora felt the urge to put a hand on her shoulder, to which Wolfa reacted with a jump and a

low growl… that she evidently regretted one moment after. Out of the corner of her eye, Adora saw Azeria come closer, her dress floating around her like ocean waves, and Huntara clench her fists.

"Why don't we just… take a deep breath and relax a bit?" Adora tried to say, looking at Huntara now. Whatever she drank, it was gone. She felt completely lucid. "Whatever happened in the Horde, is the past. We're all on the same side now."

Azeria had joined them now and was just standing at Wolfa's side, silent.

"Or, maybe, you two could just talk about it" Catra suggested. "If the big purple lady here can stop looking as if she's about to cut Wolfa's throat. Just saying."

Huntara finally moved her stare on Catra, who just stared back at her, looking completely relaxed, even bored. Damn, if she loved that woman.

"I trusted you" Wolfa murmured, looking now into Huntara's eyes, and the Strongest of the Crimson Waste faltered slightly and swallowed.

"It's not my fault if you didn't listen, Flea. I told you Hordak was the bad guy."

Much to her disbelief, Adora saw Wolfa's eyes fill with tears. And then she realized that she didn't really know why she was so surprised every time she saw Wolfa cry in public. She did it quite often, actually.

"I had never been outside the Fright Zone, how could I believe you? You knew how much he meant to me." Wolfa said with a quiet, melancholic anger that made her feel utterly uncomfortable. "I was nine, Huntara. And you were… my hero. And you left me behind."

There was unmistakable regret painted on Huntara's face now. Her body relaxed, though. She even made a tiny step towards Wolfa.

"I had to go" she murmured, and she looked tired now. Older than she actually was. "I couldn't let you stop me. It was my only chance…"

Adora looked behind Huntara and met Catra's stare, wondering if she was feeling the same as her. Leaving her behind had been the most painful decision she'd ever made. And she was afraid that Catra could still feel left behind, that the old rage could blaze again… but Catra gave her a little, apologetic smirk. And Adora started breathing again. And, as he cleared his throat and caught everyone's attention, she realized that Bow was still there, right behind her.

"Huntara, you left the Horde because you realized that what Hordak was doing was wrong, right?" he said, grinning, as if his smile could be enough to calm them down. Bow was just the best. "Wolfa, now you know that she did the right thing. And I think you were friends before she left? So, what's the matter? You can still be friends! You both think that Hordak did terrible things! Why are you even fighting?"

Wolfa and Huntara shared a glance, then Wolfa clenched her jaws and looked at Bow.

"I never meant to fight her. I just needed to hear from her… I just need to know if she's ever even cared about me. Because I did about her, a lot!" she finally growled, showing her fangs. "You trained me in the first place! You taught me how to survive in the Horde! I looked up at you! I wanted to be just like you! But then…" Wolfa blinked repeatedly to stop the tears from falling, gritting her teeth. She shook her head and snorted. "Then you ran away. Then you showed yourself a coward."

Huntara growled.

“I couldn’t stay anymore, Wolfa! It shouldn’t be so hard to understand for you now!”

“I do understand, I know you made the right choice, but I missed you, you jerk!” Wolfa shouted, a few tears finally running down her cheeks. Huntara stepped back as if Wolfa had just punched her face.

“Flea…”

Wolfa sighed and shook her head.
“You know” she murmured, her voice low and sad again, “as usual, I was wrong. I thought you were the strongest, the bravest… But you don’t even have the guts to tell me the truth now.” Adora kept alternating her gaze between them, incapable of interrupting that talk, astonished by how Wolfa was talking to Huntara, as if she was so ready to forgive her, but Huntara had just missed the opportunity. “Or to say anything at all. You left the Horde to be a better person… I hope you’re proud of who you became.” And then Wolfa turned her back to them, slightly touched Azeria’s arm and started walking away with her. Adora looked at Huntara, who seemed flabbergasted, literally open-mouthed.

“Huntara” Bow said, and the tall woman gazed at him, looking completely lost. “Maybe you should just tell her that you’re sorry.”

She narrowed her eyes.

“I had to leave the Horde.”

“She just wants to know that she means something to you” Catra cut in, ears flat. Guilt stabbed Adora’s heart once more, even now. “You might not be sorry for leaving the Horde. She’s proud you did, now. You did the right thing once, do it now: tell her what you feel. Trust me, I know how hard it is. But you owe her. Just because she’s spent all this time hoping you’d come back to her. She still does, trust me, or she wouldn’t have talked. She’d just attack. And you know that.”

Huntara was turned, but Adora could tell how hard Catra's words hit her. She was quite impressed, too. Catra seemed to know Wolfa pretty well, now.

Finally, Huntara stopped staring at Catra and darted towards the grey tail disappearing in the crowd.

"Wow" Adora muttered. She opened her mouth again, but found herself out of words. "Wow" she simply repeated.

"I hope they don't end up fighting" Bow commented. Adora glanced at him.

"I don't think they will. Mermista would kill them if they tried."

"Flea! Wait!"

Wolfa stopped walking, and Azeria stopped in turn. She met her worried stare.

"I can get rid of her, if you want" Azeria told her. But, as tempting as it was to see her girlfriend fight and kick Huntara's ass, she didn't want to ruin Mermista's wedding party.

"There's no need. But thanks, anyway." She had just the time to smirk at her when Huntara joined them. As Wolfa nodded towards Azeria, she walked away, leaving them alone.

Wolfa faced her. She honestly couldn't hate her, she knew that Huntara had had no choice. But still, she felt sad for losing her.

"Flea, I… I'm sorry" Huntara said, her deep voice resonating inside her chest. "I don't regret leaving the Horde, but I do regret leaving you behind. I just… I knew you wouldn't listen to me. You

loved Cobalt and Hordak and your team too much. I couldn't take you away from your home."

Wolfa swallowed back the emotion. She was about to reply to her when Kara's strong voice startled them both.

"Huntara?" Kara was standing a few steps away from them, next to Lonnie and Ophid. Actually, she had just let go of Lonnie's hands… were they dancing together? Anyway, she started walking towards them. Aggressively. Tauro and Ophid followed. "You bastard!" Kara hissed, heading towards Huntara. Wolfa put herself in the middle.

"Kara, wait! She was just…"

"She left us! She saved her own skin and left us to die for Hordak!"

Tauro grabbed Kara and held her still with Ophid's help.

"I know" Wolfa agreed. "But that's what we wanted. I reported her to Shadow Weaver when she defected, if she'd stayed to try to convince us, she'd be dead. She had no choice, think about it."

Huntara grabbed her shoulder and forced her to face her again.

"You did *what* ?"

Wolfa grinned at her.

"You know I can be a real bitch when I get mad."

Huntara stared at her for a while, then she burst out laughing, and Wolfa chuckled.

"Gah, I should stop calling you 'flea', you're more like a viper!"

"Can't I just be a damn wolf, which I am?!"

Huntara playfully and carefully bumped her fist against her shoulder.

“Nah, you’re definitely too puny to be a real wolf.”

Wolfa was everything but delicate or careful when she punched her massive shoulder instead.

“Fuck you, Huntara!”

Her former supervisor caught her between her buff arms and rubbed the top of her head while she tried to escape her grasp.

“Oh great!” Kara snorted, getting rid of both Tauro and Ophid with a couple of kicks. “First you become friends with Dumbora, now you forgive Huntara… then what, you’ll give Lonnie a kiss on her cheek?”

Wolfa growled playfully and pushed against Huntara’s head to make her stay still for a moment.

“I saw you dancing with that jerk five minutes ago…” Kara blushed and Wolfa gave her a wolfish sneer. “Your taste has worsened.”

Kara raised her chin and crossed her arms on her chest.

“My taste was always ridiculous.”

Huntara chuckled and let her go, then she walked to Kara, looking in her eyes. The girl’s stare cooled, but it became fragile when Huntara placed her big hand on her shoulder.

“Hey, I’m sorry, Little Fire.” Wolfa innerly smirked at Kara’s old nickname. She hadn't heard it in centuries. Little Fire, Nerdy Bull, Sneaky Snake, Flea and Tricky (Amy was always up to some kind of prank… damn, if she missed her best friend). “I never meant to hurt you, guys. I was just…”

Kara punched her in the stomach, taking her off guard and making her bend forward with a cough. Then she hugged her, right before pushing her away again, slapping her face once and pointing a threatening finger at her.

“You don’t deserve it, but we’re at a wedding and I can’t kick your ass so I forgive you, just this once.”

Huntara, a hand on her stomach, smirked at Kara, with a sparkle of proudness in her eyes.

“Okay.” Then she gazed at Tauro, who was clearly holding back the tears. He ran to her and hugged her tight. “Oh. Okay, Nerdy Bull, now… just, stop it.” She pushed him away, blushing slightly. She then flicked one of his horns. “These are much bigger now, huh? Useful in battle…”

“You should’ve seen him goring those robots” Ophid sneered, bumping his fist against Huntara’s. “He fought a tornado. Unstoppable.”

Tauro blushed and looked away, mumbling something. Then Huntara stopped smiling.

“Tricky?” she murmured. All of them gazed down.

“She’s gone” Wolfa murmured. “The rebels made her tank blow up.”

She gave Huntara a glance, and saw her falter.

“War is war” Ophid said in a low, sad voice.

Lonnie, who had stayed far enough all along, appeared next to them, together with Kyle and Rogelio. All of them were bringing glasses full of an amber liquid, Rogelio four of them, somehow. He handed two of the glasses to Ophid, Tauro, and Huntara, Kyle gave one to Kara, and Lonnie handed one of hers to Wolfa. She hesitated, wondering if she’d spit in it, or added some sort of poison to the drink. She sniffed the air, but she couldn’t find any trace of spit, or poison. Not a flavoured one, at least. She grabbed the drink, just because Lonnie’s stare seemed… uncertain. Almost scared.

Then Lonnie raised her glass.

“To Amy.”

Wolfa met her friends’ stares. Kara was the first, after Rogelio and Kyle, to raise her glass in turn and repeat: “To Amy”. Then Tauro did, and Ophid. Wolfa gazed at Huntara, who was hesitating. There was something so regretful in her eyes that she felt the urge to lean a hand on her shoulder.

“You can’t know what would have happened.” Huntara’s eyes widened. “Hordak started that war, not you. If anyone’s to blame, it’s him, not you. I forced you to run away without us, because of my stubbornness. If I had been willing to listen, you wouldn’t have had to leave us behind. I’m sorry, Huntara.” Wolfa made her glass clink againt’s Huntara’s. “To Amy.”

Huntara kept staring at her.

“You did change a lot, Flea.”

Wolfa shrugged, taking a sip. The drink wasn’t bad, it was sparkling and slightly alcoholic. And it didn’t seem poisoned yet.

“Not really. I still hate Lonnie” she said grinning, eying the jerk in question, who rolled her eyes and grimaced at her. They smirked at each other.

Glimmer gave Bow a good nudge between the ribs, and he finally stopped staring at Sea Hawk with starry eyes.

“Ouch! Glimmer!”

“You’re drooling.”

“I’m not drooling!” Bow protested, his voice a little too high-pitched. “I was just admiring Sea Hawk’s suit. He looks like a real

prince today. A pirate prince."

Sea Hawk actually looked handsome that day. Well, okay, he always did. And Mermista, oh… she was simply gorgeous with that long, nuanced dress, her hair pulled up. They were wearing each other's earrings. They looked just perfect together, and she couldn't be happier for her friends. They had left the throne room, where the ceremony had taken place, and moved to the ballroom, where they were all dancing, following Scorpia's beautiful voice. Well, *almost* all of them: Adora had fallen asleep somehow, laying on one of the couches, her head on Catra's lap (Catra was distractingly caressing her hair while listening to Scorpia), and Azeria was standing next to the buffet, eating nervously while staring at… Wolfa, of course, who was surprisingly chatting with Huntara, *Lonnie?!* , Kyle, Rogelio, Tauro, Ophid and Kara. Bow noticed what she was looking at.

"Wow. How long will it take for the brawl to begin?" he muttered. Glimmer chuckled, eying him.

"I'm sure Huntara can convince them to keep calm. They don't seem about to kill each other, by the way."

Bow titled his head, narrowing his eyes.

"Mh… You're right. This is awesome! Maybe they're friends now!"

Glimmer smirked, staring up at him. He looked so handsome. He had picked a white, cropped shirt, of course, sleeveless, with light-blue trousers and white boots, decorated with the red heart, and white gloves. Glimmer stretched out to caress his cheek, and his enthusiastic expression was replaced by a sweet, loving stare. He leaned down and they kissed, tasting each other's love, enjoying the heat coming from their touching bodies.

Glimmer put her hand on his exposed abs, touching the solidity of his muscles, and pushed him away delicately, smiling, blushing, panting.

"Would it be that rude of us if we just… teleported to our room for an hour or so?" she whispered, making him laugh.

"Considering that you're the Queen of Bright Moon and, so, the guest of honor… I'd dare to say that it would, yes."

Glimmer snorted.

"Adora is the guest of honor too, as She-Ra, and she's sleeping."

He laughed again.

"Finally! I mean, she is surrounded by… how many, une hundred? Two hundred people? And still she feels safe enough to sleep. I can't believe it! Do you remember that she used to sleep with *a dagger* under her pillow?"

Glimmer couldn't help but smile.

"She never slept. She just closed her eyes and, you know… wasn't completely awake."

Bow nodded.

"Yeah. And look at her now." They both turned and gazed at Adora. Catra was still caressing her hair, looking completely relaxed in turn. Now and then she looked away from Scorpia's performance and simply stared at her fiancéé, a tender smile on her face. Glimmer snorted.

"Can you imagine how it would have been if Catra had joined the Rebellion together with her?"

"Yeah. We would have defeated the Horde in one week."

Glimmer gazed at him, and they both burst into laughter.

"And Adora would have slept better."

"That's for sure."

“Did you expect this? Them, I mean?”

“Them to be in love, you mean? Of course!”

Glimmer stared at her boyfriend.

“What? HOW?!”

“Are you kidding me?” he said, frowning. “They were obsessed with each other! And Catra? Honestly, she could have killed Adora so many times. Did you notice how strong she is? When Adora isn’t She-Ra, she doesn’t stand a chance against her. And yet, all she did in battle was… teasing her. Let alone that dance at the prom...”

Glimmer blinked, flabbergasted.

“Shit. You’re right.”

Bow sneered.

“I’m an observer.”

“You’re smart, and I love it.” Glimmer cupped his face and kissed him again. “So we can’t teleport to Bright Moon, can we?”

He shook his head, and she snorted.

“The price of power…”

Bow chuckled. Then Scorpia and Sea Hawk started to duet in a shanty, and he sneered.

“Bow, nooo…”

“We need to dance this one.”

“Bow…”

He grabbed her and started pirouetting with her, and she started laughing, following his lead.

“I love you” he said before swinging her. Glimmer felt her heart beat faster, and, as she fell back into his hands, she kissed him again.

“I love you too, Bow.”

Wolfa joined her when she was drinking her fifth glass of cider. Despite what she thought, Azeria was bloody jealous, and watching her hang with her ex-girlfriend was a torture. She trusted Wolfa, and she knew that she would never lie to her, but a lot could happen. Kara had been important to her, she still was, it was evident. Not in a romantic way, maybe… but a lot could happen. She knew Wolfa still missed the good old days at the Horde. She couldn’t blame her, she’d been quite happy there, somehow, and that’s why she feared Kara so much.

“Hey” Wolfa greeted her, right before kissing her. She looked relaxed. Serene. “I missed you, Vixen.”

And that was enough to warm her heart and push away her fears.

“I missed you too, Lionheart.”

Wolfa gave a start and looked at her with surprise in her lupine eyes.

“What?”

“You’re the bravest person I know.” Azeria caressed her face, then dug her fingers inside her wavy hair. “You’re my lionheart. My stubborn, gorgeous lionheart.”

Wolfa blushed slightly, then narrowed her eyes, a tiny smirk on her lips.

“Are you drunk?”

“I’m in love.”

She blushed even more. Then her stare softened.

“Makes two of us” she murmured. Her words, her gaze, and her voice low and sweet, as it rarely was, made her heart beat faster than ever. Wolfa wrapped her waist with her arm and pulled her closer, then leaned in for a long, passionate yet tender kiss that left her breathless.

Then Wolfa looked at her, and there was again that hint of doubt in her eyes, that pain that seemed to never fade away for good. “I’m sorry I pushed you away for so long” she almost whispered. “Sorry for myself. I’ve wasted so much time…”

Azeria stroked her soft, white hair.

“Hey, we have plenty of time. The rest of our lives, to be exact.” Wolfa widened her eyes and she realized what she had just said. She felt her cheeks burn. “I mean, if that’s what you want, of course. I didn’t mean to push you…”

Wolfa placed a finger over her lips, shutting her up the softest and sexiest way possible. That girl was the strongest magnet, and she was pure iron.

“There’s nothing I desire more than to spend the rest of my life with you. You’re way more than I expected… and way more than I deserve, probably.” Azeria tried to protest, but Wolfa pushed a little bit with her finger, stopping her. “I’m trying to be the best I can be. And you have no idea of how grateful I am that you… love me” she concluded, blushing once again, as if she was still having a hard time trying to wrap her head around that concept. She let her finger slide down, over her lower lip, bending it. Azeria gulped, aroused, even because Wolfa was looking at her mouth

now. Then Wolfa moved her hand, taking hers. “You’re amazing, Azeria.” She met her penetrating gaze. And then Azeria just needed another kiss, a hot, steamy one, too hot and steamy in public, but she couldn’t care less. She had to tidy up Wolfa’s shirt when they ended the kiss, chuckling.

“So… You and Huntara seem to get along again…”

“Yeah, she… she clarified a couple of things. And I’ve got my fair share of faults, so..”

Azeria snorted.

“You always say it’s your fault…”

Wolfa shrugged.

“Well, I was a dickhead. It’s simply true.”

“Not really.”

“I tried to force her to stay using a stun-baton and I reported her to Shadow Weaver as she left. *Shadow Weaver* . She could’ve killed her if Huntara wasn’t so good at… surviving.”

Azeria sighed.

“You dickhead.”

They both cracked up laughing.

Of happiness and love

Chapter Notes

> Hello there :) First of all, I can't express how sorry I am for making you wait for so long. I was blocked. I couldn't write anything, I'm sorry. It's over now, hopefully forever :)
> This is the last chapter of this story, and I wrote it right now, quickly, I must admit. I couldn't wait to write this chapter, beacuse they deserved their happy ending, but I will miss them all. I love this series and, maybe, but I can't promise I will, I will write a third part. Right now, tho, I'm working on something different. Scorpia will be the main protagonist, this time, and... well, no spoiler ;)
> Anyway, I do hope you'll enjoy this chapter, and I hope you liked my story. Thank you all for the kudos, the comments, the support. It's so important to me. Thank you, really, and, again, forgive my slowness. Next time I'll make sure to write the whole story before publishing it, I promise :)
> Ciao, see you soon :)

“I've never hated someone as much as I used to hate Catra.”

Everyone laughed, Glimmer included. She fidgeted with the microphone, glanced at the two brides. Catra grimaced at her, and she winked at her. “She's been my pain in the ass for years, and I really couldn't stand her. I hated the way she moved, the way she talked, and her grin especially.” Catra raised one eyebrow, and Glimmer pointed at her with her free hand. Adora looked slightly worried. “I mean, she can be a real bitch when she wants to.” Again, the crowd laughed hard. “The fact that, even if she stayed with the Horde, she was still so important to Adora made her even more annoying.” And at that both Adora and Catra widened their eyes a little bit. “Adora, let me tell you, you were the only one who didn’t notice you were in love with her. Except for Catra herself, of course.” And again, everyone burst into laughing (but the two of them, who were blushing). Glimmer couldn’t hold back a smirk. “Anyway, back to Horde Scum.. ehm, Catra… with the

time passing, I got quite used to her. And I realized how smart she is. Which made her even more annoying, obviously" Glimmer paused to laugh, and this time both Catra and Adora followed her and the invitees, "because, you know, jealousy. I mean…" She shrugged. "Smart, devilish and hot? Who could blame me?" She smiled as everyone laughed, and noticed with satisfaction how Catra was blushing. "Anyway… She's not that bad, after all, you know? It took a while for me to realize it, but… damn!" Glimmer chuckled, shaking her head. "She's one of the bravest, actually most caring and, of course, smartest people I've ever met. And she's one of my best friends now." She gazed at Catra, who had lowered her ears and was now staring at her in disbelief. Glimmer smiled at her. "And I'm so happy for her. Because she deserves this. Today, and the days to come. She deserves happiness, and I wish her to live happily ever after. Without stealing fabrics from my castle, if possible." She laughed together with her, and noticed how Catra quickly dried a tear from her yellow eye. Glimmer sat back and Bow stood up. She gave him the microphone, welcoming his approving nod.

"When we first met Adora, we thought she was an enemy. A soldier from the Horde. Which she was, to be clear." He chuckled, Glimmer smiled looking at him. Dressed in dark red with white details, he was gorgeous. "But as I looked her in the eyes, I knew she wasn't just that. I didn't see a soldier, I saw a girl who had lost her way. A girl who was desperately looking for a new path." Glimmer followed Bow's stare, and saw Adora gulp. "I knew I wanted to help her. I knew she wasn't bad. I don't know why, I just felt it, that she was a good person." He placed his hand over his chest. "Fortunately, I was right, or we wouldn't be here." Glimmer laughed with him, and saw Adora doing the same. "Adora is one of my dearest friends. I couldn't imagine my life without her… light. She's like a torch. She brings light. She's strong, so brave and… I can't even find the words to describe how much I admire her. I know we wouldn't be here without her, and not only because she's She-Ra, of course, but because she's Adora. She's always been there when we needed her, when I needed her. She's the best friend I could ever hope for, and I can't express how

proud and happy I am to see her finally really, truly happy. Adora," Adora was uselessly trying to hide her tears, a smile on her face. Bow grabbed his glass and raised it towards her "Catra, I am so grateful to both of you, because your happiness makes me happy. So thank you, and congratulations! I wish you both all the happiness in the universes." He raised his glass a little bit more, then he drank a sip of champagne. Glimmer rushed to do the same. Bow sat back next to her, and their stares met.

"That was a great speech you made" she told him, and he grinned.

"You think? I was so nervous…"

Glimmer held his hand.

"You did great" she said right before giving him a quick kiss. She tasted the champagne from his lips.

"We're not supposed to make a speech, too, right?"

Glimmer turned and looked smiling at Scorpia.

"No, don't worry. None is supposed to. It's just nice since I'm the Queen, and we're best friends…"

"But I'm a Queen, too, and also Catra's bestie. So… should I?"

"You'll sing at the party, Scorp" Wolfa cut in while chewing an olive. "You're already paying them respects. Relax."

"Exactly" Glimmer said together with Frosta, and smirked, grateful to her Royal Guard. Azeria, next to her, was silently sipping her champagne. They were both wearing dark-grey shading into red, Wolfa in a suit and Azeria in a dress.

"Do you think that's enough? I don't want them to think…"

Perfuma stretched over the table and placed her hand upon her claw.

“Sweetie, relax. They know how happy for them you are. Don’t worry.”

Glimmer watched them stare at each other for a while, then Scorpia finally relaxed against the chair.

“Okay, okay. So, what’s for dinner again?”

Adora glanced at Catra while tasting… whatever she was eating. And, whatever it was, it was sooooo good.

“Mmmhpf…” she moaned while chewing. “This thing is amazing!”

Catra turned to give her an amused stare.

“It’s fried bread, Adora.”

“I love it!”

Catra chuckled and brought another little piece of that celestial food to her mouth.

Catra’s eyes, that day, were shimmering. She’d never seen her smile so much. She’d never seen her so happy. And she never felt so happy, in turn. Married. They were married, now. Wife and wife.

Adora glanced at her pin on Catra’s coat, and touched Catra’s belt, wrapped around her hips. A family on their own. Legally, formally. Married. It still felt so unreal, so incredible. They made it. She felt so happy she was afraid her chest would explode.

“So… will you sing again?”

Catra glared at her.

“No way.”

“But you’re so good at it!”

“Forget it, Adora.”

“Please? I love your voice!”

Catra glowered at her. But there still was that powerful happiness in her beautiful eyes, the shadow of a smile on her soft lips.

“Adora…”

“What?”

“Don’t do that.”

“Do what?”

“The puppy eyes.”

She frowned.

“Am I?”

Catra nodded.

“And is it working?” she sneered. Catra snorted.

“No. Really, I can’t sing today. Scorpia worked so hard to compose her songs in time, I can’t take her spotlight.”

Adora arched one eyebrow.

“Oh, so you think you can sing better than her.”

Catra narrowed her eyes.

“I think all eyes are already on us, today. There’s no need to search for more attention, especially when we already have such a good singer to entertain us all.”

Adora sighed, defeated.

“You’re too smart for me.”

Catra grinned.

"I know."

Adora punched her shoulder and they both burst into laughter. And then, they fell into each other's eyes. And, when they kissed, nothing else existed anymore.

Scorpia was filling the air with her powerful yet sweet voice, and most of the invitees were dancing, gathered around the two brides.

Wolfa leaned against the balustrade, slowly sipping from her glass. Swift Wind was making everyone laugh with a weird and uncoordinated dance, and she couldn't help but chuckle while tasting another sip of champagne. The night had fallen delicately over Bright Moon, painting the sky with thousands of shining stars. A soft, fresh wind caressed her hair. There was peace, a happy and feisty peace. She loved it.

From a distance, she watched Tauro join Swift Wind in his dumb dance. He dragged Kara with him, and she laughed softly at the scene. Kara didn't seem quite happy about his choice. She'd probably make him pay with a prank, someday.

Another sip of champagne. Her glass was almost empty, but she'd never felt so full. Of life, of friends, of love.

She noticed a group of people split from the crowd, and she recognized Glimmer, Frosta, Bow and Mermista. Sea Hawk was now dancing on Swift Wind back. What a weird pirate he was.

Glimmer noticed her, and started walking towards her. She smiled at the Queen. She liked to have her around.

"Hey. What are you doing here, all alone?" Glimmer looked slightly worried, but her relaxed smirk seemed to reassure her. Wolfa shrugged.

“Just… you know, enjoying the moment. This night is beautiful” she answered, letting her voice fly soft and unguarded in the air as she looked up at the stars. So many. So shiny, and far, far away. That vastity made her feel so little, but not in a bad way. It made her feel a part of something big, beautiful, important.

Glimmer moved to her side and mirrored her move.

“Yeah. Yes, it really is. I think Spinnerella pushed those big clouds away, this morning.”

Wolfa frowned.

“That woman scares me. Her power is so… powerful.”

Glimmer laughed with a hint of incredulity in her voice.

“Seriously? You’re scared of Spinnerella?”

Wolfa grinned looking down at her Queen.

“You remember I was raised to be terrified by all of you, right?”

Glimmer laughed again, and she joined her. Her gaze fell again on the crowd. Scorpia had just ended her “dance” song, gaining a huge applause, and was now starting a slow ballad.

Catra wrapped her arms around Adora’s neck, and Adora placed her hand on Catra’s hips. Adora looked around for a moment before starting the slow-dance. Until she met her stare. Surprised, Wolfa saw the glimpse of a question in her light-blue eyes. Was she really…?

Wolfa smirked and nodded, and a wide grin exploded on Adora’s face.

Wolfa snorted, shaking her head.

“I can’t believe that that idiot needs my approval.”

Glimmer looked at her, opened her mouth to protest but then stayed silent. Wolfa glances at her.

“What?”

“Nothing. You’re right. She’s made this way.”

Wolfa frowned, then looked at the couple again.

“It makes her… vulnerable” she mumbled. Now Glimmer looked at her attentively, curious.

“Are you worrying for Adora?”

Wolfa clenched her jaws, stiffening. Hiding a smile.

“I made a simple statement” she grunted, and Glimmer sneered and gave her a nudge.

“Oh, come on! It’s impossible not to care about her!”

But Wolfa was already smirking, avoiding her stare though.

“It’s quite possible if you hate her” she corrected the Queen, who laughed briefly.

“Yeah, except that you don’t!”

Wolfa glanced at her, and she looked amused.

“You know what they say about revenge. Maybe I’m just waiting for the right moment to cut her throat.”

Glimmer stared at her for a moment. Then they both burst out into laughter, Wolfa even leaned her hand on her shoulder. Then she stopped suddenly, but the ghost of that laugh was still there, lingering on her soft smile and her shimmering eyes. Glimmer followed the direction of her stare, finding Azeria at the end of that invisible string, walking to them through the crowd. Wolfa felt her heart beat faster at that sight.

Azeria bowed her head to her as she approached them and Glimmer dismissed that act with a snort.

“You need to stop that.”

Azeria arched her eyebrows.

“But you’re the Queen.”

“Mh-mh. But we’re also friends, and that comes first.”

Azeria gave her a bright smile.

“I’m honoured to call you ‘friend’... Glimmer.”

Glimmer was about to reply when someone hugged her from behind, taking her off guard… Bow, Wolfa realized a second later. She was so distracted, and relaxed, that she didn’t even smell his familiar scent. Glimmer turned her head and placed a kiss on his smiling lips, holding his strong arms, wrapped around her shoulders.

“How’s it going here?” he asked.

Wolfa raised her glass to him.

“Pretty well, I’d dare to say.” In the meantime, Azeria held her hand and interlaced her fingers with Wolfa’s as if it was the most natural thing in the world. Glimmer almost squealed of contentedness. “None interrupted the wedding with bombs or anything, so…”

“That’s your specialty” Bow grinned, and Wolfa grimaced at him, making them laugh.

“Hey, losers!” They all turned to look at Frosta. She had grown quite tall lately, and she had cut her hair, shaving one side of her head. “Who doesn’t dance is a Kyle!” and she ran towards the dance-floor. They all stayed there, flabbergasted. In the distance, Kyle asked: “Hey! Was that an insult?”

Wolfa shared the other's dumbstruck glances.

"Did she really say that?" Bow asked.

Wolfa blinked.

"That princess is ferocious" she whispered, shivering.

Glimmer grinned.

"Poor Kyle. But she's right!" And she darted behind Frosta, shouting: "Last one to the dance-floor sings the next song!"

Wolfa widened her eyes.

"What?" she yelped. Azeria laughed and rushed to follow Glimmer, giving Wolfa an amused glance while running. She ran in turn, surpassing Bow in a split second.

"Hey! Wait, I can't sing!" he yelled.

And she laughed, running behind her girlfriend, grabbing her hand at the last moment and kissing her on the dance-floor, surrounded by her new, huge family.

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